

Resource: Study Notes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Psalms 1:1

- *Blessed*: The Hebrew term (*'ashrey*) appears twenty-six times in Psalms. While some translations use “blessed,” a different term (*barak*) is used for blessings ([Psalms 5:12](#); [45:2](#); [107:38](#)).
- The godly avoid living under the influence of sinners. Those who do not fear the Lord are wicked ([Psalm 36:1](#)). They oppose those who love God, do right, and the poor and oppressed (see [10:2–13](#); [37:14](#)). The wicked might seem devoted to God ([50:16](#)). Sometimes they enjoy success, but it does not last long ([37:35](#)). They will face sadness and ruin when they must deal with the results of their bad actions ([1:4–6](#); [9:16](#); [32:10](#)).
- People who turn away from God's path and rebel against him are sinners ([Psalms 25:8](#); [78:17](#)). They commit serious crimes like adultery (being unfaithful to their spouse) and murder (compare [Psalm 51](#)).
- *sit in the seat of*: This expression describes a person who is controlled by sin (compare [Psalm 1:2](#); [26:3–7](#); [Deuteronomy 6:7](#)).
- Mockers are people who disrespect and reject God's wisdom. Mockers hate the Lord and insult anyone who tries to correct them ([Proverbs 9:7–8](#)). They seek only the “wisdom” that justifies their actions. These bold people have little respect for God, his plans, or his followers (see [Psalms 86:14](#); [119:51](#), [69](#), [78](#), [85](#), [122](#)). These three terms (wicked, sinners, mockers) describe all kinds of people who do not live in a way that pleases God.

Psalms 1:1–2

The Lord brings true happiness to those who turn away from evil and find joy in him.

Psalms 1:1–6

This wisdom psalm sets the tone for the whole Psalter. The psalmist strongly contrasts the happiness of the godly with the condemnation of the wicked; in the end, the way of wisdom will triumph. This idealization of the godly person (as in [Ps 8](#)) highlights the Lord's expectations of his people and especially of the coming Messiah ([Ps 2](#)). The people of Israel did not live up to this ideal, and neither did the kings of David's dynasty. Not even the best of them could bring in the triumph of righteousness described in [Psalms 1, 2, and 72](#). In the New Testament, the apostles' use of the Psalter to describe the life and ministry of Jesus the Messiah confirms that Jesus alone fulfills the ideal of the godly person presented in the psalms. Only Jesus could please God and secure redemption, happiness, and peace. [Psalm 1](#) introduces the hopeful anticipation of the final hallelujah ([Ps 150](#)), when the Lord will remove all evil from his creation and prosper his children.

Psalms 1:1–2.12

The first two psalms serve as an introduction to the whole book of Psalms (called the Psalter). [Psalm 1](#) presents the Lord's guidance in wisdom, while [Psalm 2](#) shows God's rule over a rebellious and sinful world. Together, these psalms invite people to abandon foolishness, which leads to destruction. These psalms invite people to follow God's path instead, which leads to wisdom and salvation. The New Testament confirms that God will govern the nations through Jesus Christ, his chosen representative ([Hebrews 1:5](#); [Revelation 12:5](#); [19:15](#)).

Psalms 1:1–8.9

[Psalms 1](#) and [8](#) form an *inclusio* (set of literary bookends) that describes what God expects of the ideal person (cp. [Pss 19](#); [33](#); [104](#); [145](#)), contrasts the godly person with the wicked, and extols the godly person's dignity. Jesus the Messiah ([Ps 2](#))—

the sovereign Lord ([Heb 2:6–8](#); see [1 Cor 15:27](#)) and perfection of humanity—embodies this ideal.

Psalms 1:2

The law (Hebrew torah) of the Lord is the full revelation of God's instructions (see study note on Deut 4:44). • Meditating is a process of inner reflection that can be positive ([Pss 1:2](#); [63:6](#); [77:12](#); [143:5](#)) or negative (see [2:1](#); [38:12](#)). The Lord's word is the object of godly meditation ([119:48](#)). • Day and night includes all times, whether one is walking, standing, sitting, or sleeping (see [Deut 6:7](#)).

Psalms 1:3

Well-watered trees endure and bear abundant fruit (cp. [Jer 17:8](#)).

Psalms 1:3–5

The future belongs to the godly.

Psalms 1:4

The coming time of judgment ([1:5](#)) will carry off the wicked and their deeds ([35:5](#); [83:13](#); [Isa 17:13](#); see study note on Jer 13:24).

Psalms 1:5

The wicked cannot abide the scrutiny of the Lord's judgment; they are already condemned (see [5:5](#); [7:6](#); [101:7](#)).

Psalms 1:6

- When God takes care of people who obey him and punishes people who do evil, it shows how God gives people what their actions deserve (see [Galatians 6:7–10](#)). This is called "retribution." The wicked might appear successful for a short while, but their lives are short and meaningless in the end. God and the people who remain faithful to him will have the final victory (see [Psalms 9:5](#), [6](#), [18](#); [10:16](#); [37:20](#); [73:27](#); [92:9](#); compare [142:4](#); [Isaiah 57:1](#)).
- People who live in a way that pleases God are happy ([Psalms 1:1](#); [5:12](#); [14:5](#)). They are happy because God protects and cares for them, listens when they ask for justice, and secures their future (see [121:3–4](#)).
- A person's path is their life and character.

Psalms 2:1

plot: The Hebrew verb translated as "meditates" in [Psalm 1:2](#) suggests opposing the Lord through speech ([Isaiah 59:13](#)) or thought ([Psalm 38:12](#); [Proverbs 24:2](#)).

Psalms 2:1–3

Their futile paths lead to death ([1:4](#), [6](#)), but fallen human beings unite in opposing the true God and his Messiah.

Psalms 2:1–12

This royal psalm pertains to the Lord's appointment of a king descended from David. It celebrates the mission of all the kings in David's line, and it introduces the hope of an ideal ruler who will accomplish the Lord's goal of bringing all nations into submission ([2:11](#)) or to destruction ([2:9](#)). The New Testament identifies Jesus as this descendant (see [Acts 13:33](#); [1 Cor 15:25–27](#); [Heb 1:5](#); [5:5](#); [Rev 19:15](#)).

Psalms 2:2

The kings hate the Lord's established order in the world, so they desire to be independent of him (see [36:4](#)). They scheme about dominating the Lord's people ([31:13](#); see [83:1-4](#)). Their goal is to subvert the Lord's rule in the world by overthrowing his anointed one (or *his messiah*); the Lord chose the kings of David's dynasty to establish his kingdom throughout the earth. The New Testament confirms that Jesus, the appointed and anointed Son of God ([Acts 4:26](#); [13:33](#); [Heb 1:5](#); [5:5](#)), fulfills the role in which these earlier kings failed.

Psalms 2:3

break their chains: These kings believe that acknowledging the true God and his chosen ruler will result in their enslavement ([Isa 28:22](#); [52:2](#); cp. [Lam 3:7](#); [Rom 1:1](#); [1 Cor 7:22](#); [Titus 1:1](#)).

Psalms 2:4

rules in heaven: The Lord's place in the universe is so certain that he scoffs at humans who boast that they can rebel against his power and authority (see [37:13](#); [59:8](#)).

Psalms 2:4-6

The Lord finds the human threat insignificant. He provided a solution long before their rebellion. He will end their agitation through the appointment of a human agent, a descendant of David's line who will rule the nations.

Psalms 2:6

my chosen king: The Lord establishes his anointed ruler.

Psalms 2:7

Today I have become your Father: People in the ancient Near East commonly accepted a father-son relationship between gods and kings. In Israel, the Lord adopted kings as his sons. God set David apart

as his most excellent and exalted son ([89:27](#)). All descendants of David were the Lord's representatives or agents. As an eternal member of the Godhead ([John 1:1](#)) and a descendant of David ([Acts 13:33](#); [Heb 1:5](#); [5:5](#)), Jesus is the true Son of God.

Psalms 2:7-9

The Lord adopted the king of David's dynasty to conquer rebellious nations by force (see [89:26-27](#)).

Psalms 2:8

In an example of the suzerain-vassal relationship between the Lord and Israel's king (see Deuteronomy Book Introduction, "Literary Form"), the Lord invites the king to ask for favors (see [Ps 21:2, 4](#)). • All nations will be subject to David's descendant, the Messiah.

Psalms 2:9

The Lord gives his anointed ruler the power to conquer the nations as his inheritance ([Isa 11:4](#); [Rev 2:27](#); [12:5](#); [19:15](#)), breaking their rebellion, resistance, and independence.

Psalms 2:10

It pleases the Lord when his people submit to him and seek his protection. The wise accept the Lord's rebuke and desire to repent.

Psalms 2:11-12

rejoice: Rulers must welcome the Son as their true and only King. • Submit to God's royal son (or *Submit to God's royal Son*, or *kiss the son*): Kissing was an expression of submission ([Hos 13:2](#)). • The Lord gives joy to all who fear him ([Ps 1:1-2](#)) and trust him ([18:30](#); [34:22](#); [119:1-3](#)).

Psalms 3:1

title

This sad episode in David's life (see 2 Sam 15-18) helps readers keep the promises of Ps 2 in perspective. The Lord granted victory to his anointed king (Ps 2), but the manner and timing of this victory remained in God's hands.

Psalms 4:1-8

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Psalms 3:1-2

The psalmist's many enemies speak brashly ([4:6](#); [12:4](#); [40:15](#)) and question the Lord's ability to rescue ([10:11](#); [22:7-8](#); [71:10](#)). Their words haunt him because it seems that the Lord will not answer his prayer. • These enemies wield great power (cp. [2:1-3](#)); unlike [Ps 2](#), this psalm does not resolve the crisis.

Psalms 3:1-8

This psalm laments that the expectations raised by [Pss 1-2](#) have not been met. But even when beset by enemies, godly people need not question the Lord's just dealings. Rather, they can confidently trust his goodness and expect God to rescue them.

Psalms 3:1-7.17

This group of psalms moves readers from the orderly world of [Pss 1-2](#) to a disoriented one. The Lord's anointed cries out while facing enemies, ferocious opposition, evil schemes, and the Lord's apparent distance.

Psalms 3:3

The psalmist contrasts the contention of his enemies ([3:2](#)) with the Lord's provision. The Lord is a shield for his people; he turns their defeat and shame into victory and glory.

Psalms 3:3-4

The psalmist's eyes turn from his enemies to the Lord.

Psalms 3:5

By refocusing on the Lord ([3:3-4](#)) in the midst of his crisis, the psalmist can rest, confident of his safety (see study note on 4:8). The Lord cares for his servant; he protects him and keeps his mind and heart from fear ([37:17](#); [54:4](#); [119:116](#); [145:14](#)).

Psalms 3:6

The psalmist's peaceful confidence in the Lord's protection and care shields him from evil and gives him a new sense of reality ([23:4](#); [27:1](#); [3](#); [46:1](#); [56:4](#); [11](#); [91:5-6](#); [118:6](#)).

Psalms 3:7-8

The psalmist does not seek revenge; instead, he waits for the Lord's vengeance. • Arise: The psalmist calls upon the Lord to take action now.

Psalms 4:1

Waiting for the Lord's answer allows for growth in patience and for the refinement of living faith ([38:15](#)).

Psalms 4:1-8

This personal lament includes:

- a prayer for rescue ([Psalm 4:1](#))
- a rebuke of the enemy ([Psalm 4:2-3](#))
- advice to the faithful ([Psalm 4:4-5](#))
- a statement of confidence ([Psalm 4:6-8](#))

Psalms 4:2

- The opponents of those who follow God rely on false beliefs, deceit, and idol worship.
- *my honor* (or *my glory*): The psalmist's honor, or possibly the Lord's, is being challenged.

Psalms 4:4

Angry feelings are not sinful, but letting anger control you leads to sin (see [37:7–8](#); cp. [Eph 4:26–27, 31–32](#)). • Instead of acting on their emotions, the godly think about their circumstances overnight. They might be disturbed as they sleep, but silence opens their hearts to trust in the Lord ([Ps 4:5](#)).

Psalms 4:5

Offer sacrifices in the right spirit: Redirecting emotions toward the Lord prevents a godly individual from doing too much self-reflection ([40:6–8](#); [51:17](#)).

Psalms 4:6

your face (or *the light of your face*): The psalmist seeks God's favor and peace ([Num 6:25–26](#)), which can transform darkness into light (see [Ps 27:1](#)). Confident trust in the Lord is an antidote to anger, resentment, jealousy, and materialism.

Psalms 4:8

Peace comes from God's blessing and protection ([4:6](#); see [37:11](#)).

Psalms 5:1–2

The request *hear me* appears in several prayers as a call for God's attention during a time of trouble ([39:12](#); [84:8](#); [143:1](#)), as does *pay attention* ([17:1](#); [54:2](#); [130:2](#)). The needy ask their God, "Are you listening?"

Psalms 5:1–12

This morning prayer ([5:3](#)) expresses unwavering confidence in the Lord's help and protection. The psalmist asks for and awaits God's response ([5:1–3](#)). He describes the schemes of the wicked in detail but does not get lost in his circumstances. The psalmist also knows that the wicked cannot coexist with God ([5:4–6, 9](#); see [1:5](#)). He keeps returning to the Lord ([5:7–8, 10](#); see [5:1–3](#)), and then he prays for the godly community ([5:10–12](#); see [3:8](#)).

Psalms 5:3

The psalmist begins and ends each day with prayer, awaiting new expressions of God's fidelity and goodness ([143:8](#)). • *wait expectantly*: The psalmist does not demand God's grace but places hope in it (see [Mic 7:7](#); [Hab 2:1](#)).

Psalms 5:5

the proud: Mockers (see study note on 1:1), the wicked ([73:3](#); [75:4](#)), and the arrogant ([10:2](#)) use their mouths to twist truth and challenge the faith of the godly. • The Lord allows only the godly into his presence (see [1:5](#)). His holiness and justice do not tolerate oppression or those who do evil. • *you hate*: The Lord rejects proud sinners (see also [11:5](#)).

Psalms 5:7

God promises his unfailing love—his covenant goodness and faithfulness—to his people (see [25:6](#); [69:16](#); [Lam 3:32](#)). • *your house*: The godly long to come into God's presence with reverence and awe (see [Heb 12:28](#)).

Psalms 5:8

God guides those who are obedient, submissive, and patient in waiting for him to lead, provide, and protect them ([27:11](#); [43:3](#); [143:10](#)), not those who expect God simply to endorse their own decisions. • Following the right path of wisdom leads to the Lord ([27:11](#); [61:2](#); [139:24](#)).

Psalms 5:9–10

The psalmist again describes the vile acts of the wicked, who cannot stand in God's presence.

Psalms 5:10

The psalmist prays for the justice and retribution that God promised against the wicked ([1:6](#))—those who have rebelled against the Lord. • The wicked lay traps to kill ([38:12](#)) or deceive ([140:4–5](#)).

Psalms 5:11

A blessing rests on all who take refuge in God (see [18:30](#)). • Joy and praise make good companions. The godly rejoice when they see evidence of God's rescue. They sing joyful praises as a new song (see [33:3](#)). When the Lord restores peace to this world, puts down evil, and rewards the righteous, they will have lasting joy ([9:2–4](#); [53:6](#); [90:14–15](#); [118:24](#)). • The children of God, who find refuge in him, love his name. To love his name is to love his very character.

Psalms 5:12

The psalmist extends his concern beyond himself to all the godly. • A shield, here an image of God's protection, deflects spears and arrows from its bearer.

Psalms 6:1

don't rebuke me . . . or discipline me: The psalmist does not explicitly connect God's discipline with sin here (cp. [39:8–11](#)), but it might be implied.

Psalms 6:1–3

The psalmist asks for God's favor and restoration at a difficult time.

Psalms 6:1–10

The occasion for this lament might have been sickness or a mental or spiritual depression from which the psalmist sought healing.

Psalms 6:2–3

In his longing for God's response to his prayer, the psalmist grew physically weak ([6:6](#); see [77:3](#); [119:81](#); [142:1–3](#); see also [Ps 101](#)). Fasting might have played a part in his agony, but this is not mentioned.

Psalms 6:4–5

The experience was so painful that the psalmist might as well have been dead, or perhaps he feared for his life.

Psalms 6:5

from the grave? Hebrew *from Sheol*? In the Old Testament, Sheol is the abode of the dead. It is not necessarily associated with punishment.

Psalms 6:6–7

The psalmist is exhausted to the depths of his being from the anguish of his spiritual distance from the Lord ([22:1](#); [31:9–10](#); [102:5](#)). • When eyes dim, the body is failing (see [13:3](#); [31:9](#); [38:10](#); [Matt 6:22](#)).

Psalms 6:8–10

In a closing note of triumph, the psalmist reasserts his confidence in the Lord.

Psalms 7:1

Persecutors (a common term for "enemies") intentionally seek out people in order to destroy them ([31:15](#); [56:1–2](#); [71:11](#); [143:3](#)).

Psalms 7:1–17

This psalm consists of a lament ([7:1–2](#)), an oath of innocence ([7:3–5](#)), an appeal to God's justice ([7:6–9](#)), an affirmation of God's just kingship ([7:10–16](#)), and a concluding hymn of praise ([7:17](#)).

Psalms 7:title

an unknown person of the tribe of Benjamin, remained hostile to David.

Psalms 7:2

Like a lion, a wicked enemy relentlessly and violently pursues its prey ([10:9](#); [17:12](#); [22:13](#), [21](#); [35:17](#); [57:4](#)), but God promises victory ([91:13](#)).

Psalms 7:3

The psalmist does not claim to be without sin, but he knows that he does not deserve the brutal attacks of his opponents (see [35:7](#)).

Psalms 7:3–5

The psalmist swears to his innocence, making himself vulnerable to scrutiny ([7:9](#)).

Psalms 7:5

trample: Cp. [44:5](#); [60:12](#); [91:13](#); [108:13](#). • into the ground . . . in the dust: Disgrace and shame can lead to death and the grave ([143:3](#); see [13:3–4](#)).

Psalms 7:6

God's judgment brings justice, despite the chaos created by adversaries (see [7:11](#)).

Psalms 7:6–9

With this appeal to God for justice in the world, the psalmist also submits to God's examination.

Psalms 7:8

The judgment is against the defendants (the nations) and in favor of the righteous plaintiff (the psalmist; see [43:1](#)). • Although not innocent of all sin, the psalmist is a person of authentic integrity (see [15:2](#); [25:21](#); [41:12](#); [78:72](#); cp. [Job 1:1](#), [8](#); [9:20](#), [22](#)).

Psalms 7:9

God examines the mind and heart of each person (see [11:3–4](#); [26:2](#); [139:1](#), [23](#)).

Psalms 7:10–13

The psalmist moves from his own situation ([7:1–9](#)) to speak for all the godly who long for redemption ([7:10–16](#)). He depicts God as the righteous King who vindicates his subjects when they cry out for rescue.

Psalms 7:11

The honest Lord cannot be bought or bribed, nor does he abuse his power ([9:4](#); cp. [82:1–8](#)).

Psalms 7:12–13

sword . . . bow . . . deadly weapons . . . flaming arrows: As the Divine Warrior, God goes on the offensive on behalf of himself and his people.

Psalms 7:14

Evil begins with small words or steps, and gives birth to increasingly worse deeds as time goes on (see [Isa 59:4–5](#)).

Psalms 7:17

I will thank . . . sing praise: The laments in [Pss 3–7](#) usually move from lament to praise, as does the Psalter as a whole. • Most High: This is an ancient designation for God (see [Gen 14:19](#)). • God is just and reliable, so his order prevails in this world.

Psalms 8:1

The Lord (Hebrew Yahweh), the covenant God of Israel ([Exod 3:15](#)), also holds the title of Lord (Hebrew 'adonay), the king of the earth. • The word translated majestic (sometimes translated "mighty") can describe kings ([Ps 136:18](#)), heroes ([16:3](#)), mountains ([76:4](#)), or waves breaking on the

seashore ([93:4](#)). While all are awe-inspiring and mighty, the created order pales in comparison with the Lord. • A person's name embodies their reputation. • The earth and the heavens reveal the Lord's splendor. All creation worships and praises the Lord ([66:4](#); [113:3](#); [145:21](#)).

Psalms 8:1–9

[Psalm 8](#) begins the second part of Book One of the Psalms ([Psalms 8–14](#)). The psalmist praises God's creation and the dignity of the ideal human (see [Psalm 1](#)). Instead of the world of enemies, wicked people, and unfair justice shown in [Psalms 3–7](#), this psalm presents the world as God first made it. Someone who is tired (both physically and emotionally) can imagine a place of dignity in God's world.

Psalms 8:2

silencing: The loud noise of the oppressors contrasts with the praise of God. In the end, the praise of God will overwhelm the sound of evil ([31:18](#); [63:11](#); [101:5](#); [143:12](#)). • Those who oppose God seethe with vindictive anger ([2:1–3](#); [44:16](#); cp. [149:6–7](#)).

Psalms 8:3

The nations around Israel worshiped heavenly objects as deities. The sun, moon, and stars are indeed immense and glorious, but they are merely the work of your fingers, a reason to praise the Almighty.

Psalms 8:3–5

In light of God's awesome glory, it might seem that people would be insignificant to him. However, he has crowned them with glory and honor and placed them over all creation.

Psalms 8:4

human beings (literally *son of Adam*): The Hebrew idiom *son of man* (or *son of Adam*) means a human being. Through the influence of [Dan 7:13–14](#), it became a title with divine overtones in the New

Testament. See [Heb 2:6–8](#), where this passage is quoted.

Psalms 8:5

Yet you made them only a little lower than God: Humans bear God's image; the Lord has endowed humans with dignity and charged them to rule ([Gen 1:26–27](#)). [Hebrews 2:6–8](#) applies these words to Jesus Christ, the ideal human who fully realized God's purposes.

Psalms 8:6

gave them charge of everything: The psalmist is still referring to humans in general. Paul applies these words to Jesus as the perfect man who has made the created order—even death ([1 Cor 15:25–27](#))—subject to God and his glory. The New Testament connects these themes of creation and salvation with Jesus Christ ([John 1:1–2](#), [14](#); [Col 1:16](#)).

Psalms 8:7–8

Wild animals, including birds and fish, remind readers of God's creation of the animal world in [Gen 1](#). Contrary to beliefs among Israel's neighbors in the ancient Near East, animals are not sacred.

Psalms 9:1

The verb translated praise is translated “thank” in [7:17](#), suggesting a close connection between [Pss 7](#) and [9](#) (see [7:17](#); [8:1–2](#)). With all my heart expresses the psalmist's deep devotion and commitment ([86:12](#); [111:1](#); [119:10](#); [138:1](#)). • I will tell: These stories educate the next generation ([78:4](#); [145:4](#)); when they are not remembered, a generation might easily depart from the Lord ([78:11](#), [32](#)). • The marvelous things include the Lord's judgments on the enemies of his people ([9:4](#)) and his care for the oppressed ([9:9](#)). The wonders in creation, in redemption, and in revelation reveal his character and show his power ([89:5](#); [111:4](#); [119:18](#), [27](#)). His powerful manifestations evoke public praise ([9:1](#); [26:7](#); [75:1](#)).

Psalms 9:title

but that tune is no longer known. So also with the tunes mentioned in [Pss 22, 45, 56-60, 69, 75, and 80](#).

Psalms 9:1-10:18

This hymn celebrates the Lord's kingship and victory over evil. It might also serve as a response to the laments of [Pss 3-7](#). Some believe that [Pss 9](#) and [10](#) should be read together as one psalm in two parts because [Ps 9](#) includes a title and [Ps 10](#) does not, and although several letters are missing or inverted, the two psalms connect as an acrostic of the Hebrew alphabet (other such alphabetic acrostics are [Pss 25, 34, 37, 111-112, 119, 145](#)). The ancient Greek and Latin translations treat 9 and 10 as one.

Psalms 9:2

filled with joy . . . sing praises: The psalmist often connects joy with praises, as one leads to the other ([5:11-12](#); [32:11](#); [67:4](#); [90:14](#); [92:4](#)).

Psalms 9:3

retreated . . . staggered: The Lord overpowers even powerful enemies (see [27:2](#)). Israel also experienced judgment when it resisted the Lord ([107:12](#)).

Psalms 9:3-6

The psalmist celebrates God's judgment of the wicked, which is a testimony to the Lord's reliable promise to establish his kingdom on earth ([1:6](#); [Ps 2](#)).

Psalms 9:4

The throne represents the Lord's royal authority.

Psalms 9:5

God created the heavens and the earth with a word ([Gen 1](#)), and he can bring nations to an end with a

word (see [Ps 2:5](#)). Evil and those who do evil will come to an absolute end ([69:28](#); [109:13](#); [Rev 21:4](#)).

Psalms 9:7-10

The godly do not put their hope in corruptible human government but in God's everlasting rule of justice and fairness (see [Pss 96-100](#)).

Psalms 9:9

The Lord provides shelter in dangerous circumstances and refuge from powerful and oppressive people. The Psalter includes many similar images of the Lord, such as fortress ([18:2](#); [31:2](#)), rock ([18:2](#); [42:9](#)), strength ([18:1](#)), and strong tower ([144:2](#)). These images occur frequently in the royal prayers (see [9:9](#); [18:30](#)). • Even oppressed, afflicted, and marginalized people ([10:17](#); [74:21](#)) can enjoy divine protection. • The times of trouble ([10:1](#); [20:1](#)) stand in contrast with appointed times when the Lord openly bestows his favor upon the afflicted ([69:13](#); [102:13](#); see [Ps 107:6](#)).

Psalms 9:10

Alienation from the Lord might be part of an individual's experience ([22:1](#); [42:9](#); [119:8](#)), yet the psalms affirm that the Lord will not abandon his people ([16:10](#); [37:25](#), [28](#)).

Psalms 9:11

The psalm writers often connect the idea that God reigns (or *sits*, or *is enthroned*) with a place, such as heaven ([2:4](#); see [47:9](#)), Jerusalem, "between the cherubim" ([80:1](#); [99:1](#)), "on high" ([113:5](#)), or "at my right hand" ([110:1](#)). Since the Lord rules the world, all people must know of his unforgettable deeds of salvation (see [9:1](#); [64:9](#); [66:16](#); [105:1](#)).

Psalms 9:11-12

Recognition that the Lord's judgment falls on some of the wicked ([9:3-6](#)) and that God promises to judge all evil ([9:7-10](#)) motivates praise. The psalmist calls on the godly community to join him.

Psalms 9:12

The Lord saves his servants and punishes those who have harmed them ([Psalm 18:46](#)). He defends his servants by fairly judging his enemies on earth ([Psalm 58:11](#)). Those who follow God do not seek revenge. Instead, they wait for the Lord to defend them ([Psalm 94:1–2](#); [Deuteronomy 32:35](#); [Romans 12:19](#)).

Psalms 9:13–14

The psalmist returns from a vision of the glorious future to the reality of facing his enemies ([9:3](#)). • The jaws (literally *gates*) are a vivid image of the powerful grip of death (see [13:3–4](#)). • Jerusalem's gates provide an intentional contrast to the "gates" of death.

Psalms 9:18

Hope requires waiting for the Lord's rescue or justice ([25:3](#), [5](#), [21](#)). The godly find hope, rest, and quietness as they await the Lord (see [1:6](#); [27:14](#)).

Psalms 9:19–20

The psalmist ends his lament with a prayer for the Lord's intervention and divine vengeance. • mere mortals . . . merely human: Humans who have received authority and glory sometimes become oppressive and assume glory for themselves (see [8:4](#); [10:18](#)).

Psalms 10:1

The opening questions set the mood. The Lord does not seem to hear the prayers of his people ([22:1](#), [19](#); see [2 Kgs 4:27](#); [Isa 1:15](#)).

Psalms 10:1–18

The lament of [9:13–20](#) continues in [Ps 10](#) (see study note on Pss 9–10), but the mood changes from confident assertion to anguished questioning. The psalmist prays for rescue, believing that the Lord, as a just king, takes care of the needy.

Psalms 10:2

The wicked brazenly defy God with their acts and speech ([17:10](#); [31:18](#); [59:12](#); [73:8](#); [123:4](#)). Although the Lord will deal with them ([31:23](#)), they disturb the righteous (see [5:4–6](#)) prior to their condemnation and judgment.

Psalms 10:2–11

Wicked and oppressive people might prosper, leaving ugly consequences. Evil can be as dramatic as the psalmist portrays it here, or it could be more subtle.

Psalms 10:3

Unlike those who have evil desires, the godly wait for justice ([10:17](#)).

Psalms 10:4

God is dead: See [10:11](#); [14:1](#).

Psalms 10:6–7

Despite their evil ways ([5:9](#); [28:3](#); [Rom 3:14](#)), the wicked expect a future free of trouble such as the righteous will enjoy.

Psalms 10:8

The wicked rely on outright violence ([11:5](#); [37:32](#)) and deception ([Prov 12:6](#); [23:27–28](#)).

Psalms 10:12–15

With confidence that the wicked will be held responsible for their deeds and that the Lord will care for the helpless, the psalmist prays intensely for rescue from evil.

Psalms 10:14

Because the Lord cares for the afflicted, he will take note and punish evildoers (see [72:14](#); [116:15](#)).

Psalms 10:15

The psalmist strongly invokes a curse as he prays (see “Prayers for Vengeance” Theme Note). • Arms represent an ability to wage war ([18:34](#); [44:3](#)).

Psalms 10:16

As the true and just king, God will bring the wicked to an end, as he promises ([1:6](#)).

Psalms 10:17–18

The psalmist expresses his confidence in the Lord.

Psalms 10:18

Mere people misuse their power and enslave the very people God wants them to serve (see [9:19–20](#); [Luke 22:25–26](#)).

Psalms 11:1

God provides protection (or *refuge*; see [5:11](#); [9:9](#); [25:20](#)) when the foundations of justice collapse. • The mountains provide another place of refuge (see [121:1](#)).

Psalms 11:1–7

The psalmist affirms his faith in the righteous God. Even though the world appears hopelessly chaotic, both the godly and the wicked can count on God’s justice. The godly can depend on him as a refuge and shelter.

Psalms 11:2

The wicked live in the shadows and create gloom for the godly ([82:5](#); [139:11](#); [143:3](#); [Prov 4:19](#)).

Psalms 11:2–3

In the inevitable battle between the evil and the godly, the wicked cannot tolerate the righteous, so they victimize them. This seems to leave the godly with nothing but questions.

Psalms 11:3

The wicked create a world of darkness (see [82:5](#)).

Psalms 11:4

The righteous King rules from heaven, where his throne is untouched by human corruption (see [2:4](#)). He examines everyone and sees everything that happens on earth (see [14:2–3](#)).

Psalms 11:5

hates: See [5:4–6](#); [Prov 6:16–18](#). • Wicked deeds result in destruction and violence ([Pss 58:2](#); [73:6](#); [74:20](#)).

Psalms 11:6

God rained blazing coals and burning sulfur on Sodom and Gomorrah ([Gen 19](#)) as symbols of judgment ([Pss 18:8](#); [120:4](#); [140:10](#)).

Psalms 11:7

The godly are assured of the Lord’s favorable presence when they see his face (see [23:6](#)).

Psalms 12:1–4

Evil becomes so pervasive that the godly pray for rescue ([Isa 57:1](#); [Mic 7:2](#); cp. [Pss 1:6](#); [37:20](#); [58:7](#); [104:35](#)).

Psalms 12:1–8

This community lament seeks the Lord’s help against the prevalence of evil. Because of the Lord’s

answer, the godly can face the future knowing that God protects them.

Psalms 12:4

The words they say reveal the character of the wicked. They deceive and overpower the godly and arrogantly question the Lord's purposes.

Psalms 12:6

The godly can rely on the Lord's promises, but not on the lies of the wicked ([12:2-4](#)). • Seven times means totally or completely.

Psalms 12:7-8

The godly know that the Lord cares, even though the wicked continue to oppress them. The Lord sees the corrupt and foolish people who praise evildoers (see [9:19-20](#); [14:2-6](#)).

Psalms 13:1-2

How long? The fourfold repetition expresses agitation and deep anguish ([79:5](#)).

Psalms 13:1-6

The psalmist's piercing cry for help becomes a confident song of hope.

Psalms 13:2

A sense of anguish and sorrow closes off any perspective of hope ([6:3](#)). Unless the Lord answers the psalmist's prayers ([22:1](#)), death seems inescapable, torturous, and slow ([6:6](#); [32:3](#); [55:4](#); [61:2](#); [102:5](#); [116:3](#)). The psalmist hardly knows how to pray; he longs for God's redemption ([25:17-18](#); [31:10](#); [38:8](#); [39:2](#)).

Psalms 13:3

The psalmist's affliction feels like death ([22:15](#); [55:4](#); [88:15](#); [94:17](#); [116:3](#)).

Psalms 13:3-4

Only the Lord can bring enlightenment and relief. The psalmist longs for the Lord's vindication so that his foes will not rejoice.

Psalms 13:5-6

The psalmist no longer hears the ridicule of his foes. Instead, because of his trust in the Lord, he is full of joy.

Psalms 14:1

Also known as fools, the wicked speak to themselves, think, scheme ([10:4](#), [6](#), [11](#)), and make claims; however, because they do not heed God's revelation, they possess no understanding ([14:1](#); [39:8](#); [53:1](#); [74:18](#), [22](#)).

Psalms 14:1-3

Paul uses phrases from the Greek translation of this passage in his description of the depravity of all people ([Rom 3:10-12](#)).

Psalms 14:1-7

This wisdom psalm contains some characteristics of lament and prophetic speech. The ideals of [Ps 8](#) have run aground on the reality of foolish human attitudes and sinful actions. With the exception of vv [5-6](#), this psalm parallels [Ps 53](#).

Psalms 14:2-3

From heaven ([33:13](#); [80:14](#); [102:19](#)), the Lord sees the wicked, who stand out as vile sinners ([11:3-5](#)). The entire human race lacks wisdom and fails to live up to the glory originally given to them ([10:4-11](#); see [Rom 1-3](#)).

Psalms 14:4

The evil live at the expense of others ([27:2](#); [44:11](#); [53:4](#); see [Isa 5:8](#)) and have no reverence or knowledge of God ([Ps 79:6](#)).

Psalms 14:5

Though the wicked perish ([1:5-6](#)), God is with the godly.

Psalms 14:7

The psalmist prays for the renewal of God's relationship with his people. • Jacob is a synonym for Israel (see [Gen 35:9-10](#)).

Psalms 15:1

Only the godly may reside in the Lord's presence ([5:4](#)). As his guests, they experience his hospitality and protection. • sanctuary (or *tent*): In David's time, God's sanctuary was a tent (the Tabernacle; see [1 Sam 21:6](#); [2 Sam 6:17](#); [7:6](#); [12:20](#); [1 Chr 6:32](#)).

Psalms 15:1-5

In this wisdom poem, the psalmist contrasts the lifestyle of the godly with the actions of fools ([Ps 14](#)). The questions in this psalm invite readers to examine themselves and to look away from problems with the wicked. The question of who dwells in God's presence leads into a description of godly character qualities (cp. [24:3-6](#); [Isa 33:14-16](#)).

Psalms 15:1-19.14

The psalms in this section affirm integrity and purity ([17:15](#); [18:20-26](#); [19:13-14](#)). They refer to people as dwelling in God's presence ([16:9-11](#); [17:15](#)) and as not being shaken ([15:5](#); [16:8](#)).

Psalms 15:2

The godly speak truthfully and act faithfully in their relationships. Unlike the wicked, they are open and transparent ([12:2-4](#)).

Psalms 15:5

The Lord prohibited Israel from charging interest to people in need ([Exod 22:25-27](#)). • The assurance of God's presence keeps the godly from destruction ([Pss 16:8](#); [46:5](#); [125:1](#)). Their circumstances might shake them temporarily, but they ultimately stand firm ([30:6](#); [94:18](#); [112:6](#)).

Psalms 16:1

The psalmist feels safe because the Lord alone offers security ([16:5-6](#)), guidance ([16:7-8](#)), and the joy of his presence ([16:9-11](#)).

Psalms 16:1-11

In this psalm of confidence, the poet moves quickly from a short petition ([16:1](#)), to expressions of passionate commitment to God and his people ([16:2-6](#)), to a conclusion of confident praise ([16:7-11](#)).

Psalms 16:2

I said to the Lord: The various writers of the psalms pray, lament, and praise the Lord throughout the Psalter, and the Lord answers them (see [12:5-6](#)).

Psalms 16:4

The psalmist dissociates himself from ungodly worship, rituals, and words (see [15:3-5](#)).

Psalms 16:5

The cup of blessing represents God's provision for all the psalmist's needs ([23:5](#); see [116:13](#); cp. [75:8](#); [Isa 51:17](#)).

Psalms 16:6

The land is God's gift for his people ([Deut 18:8](#)).

Psalms 16:7-8

God's instruction brings life ([16:11](#); see [5:8](#); [23:1-3](#); [32:8](#); [73:24](#)). • The psalmist so deeply depends on the Lord for strength and joy that he senses that God is right beside him ([16:11](#); see [73:23](#); [109:31](#); [110:1](#); [5](#); [121:5](#)). • Peter quoted [16:8-11](#) in his sermon on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:25-28](#)).

Psalms 16:9-11

Knowing that not even death can separate him from the Lord strengthens the psalmist's confidence. He fears a separation (see [13:3-4](#)), but he remains confident of seeing the Lord (see [11:7](#)).

Psalms 16:10

The psalmist expresses his confidence that life continues beyond death. The apostles applied this text to the resurrection of Jesus ([Acts 2:25-33](#); [13:35](#)).

Psalms 16:11

with you: See [16:7-8](#); [110:1](#).

Psalms 17:1

comes from honest lips: Deception characterizes the wicked. The godly reject such deceit as a failure of character and pray for rescue from such people ([5:6](#); [43:1](#); [120:2](#)). They love honesty, truth, and integrity ([15:2-3](#); [24:4](#); [101:7](#)).

Psalms 17:1-15

The psalmist pleads for God's protection and vindication, affirms his own integrity, and prays that the Lord will prevail against his fierce enemies.

Psalms 17:3

Though he is not perfect, the psalmist commits himself to the Lord. He does not want to sin through deception, flattery, or gossip (see [10:7](#); [15:2-3](#); [17:1](#)).

Psalms 17:3-5

The psalmist declares his innocence ([17:1](#)) and commits himself to integrity by being open to God's examination.

Psalms 17:6-9

This prayer for God's care returns to the petition begun in [17:1-2](#) for redemption from evil.

Psalms 17:8

as you would guard your own eyes (literally *as the pupil of your eye*): This metaphor expresses God's care and affection for the psalmist (see [Deut 32:10](#)). • The shadow of God's wings is a place of his protection from enemies and adversity ([Pss 36:7](#); [57:1](#); [61:4](#); [63:7](#); [91:4](#)).

Psalms 17:13-14

The psalmist confidently prays for the Lord's victory, knowing that God possesses more power than the evildoers. The psalmist finds his joy in the Lord's inheritance ([16:5](#)), whereas the wicked search for joy in this world.

Psalms 17:15

see you face to face: The psalmist does not allow temporary concerns raised by adversaries to stand in the way of his experiencing a real and lasting relationship with the Lord.

Psalms 18:1

Lord, charged with the responsibility of establishing God's kingdom on earth (see [78:70](#); [132:10](#); [144:10](#)). • The Lord rescued David from all his enemies when he enabled David to conquer them (see [2 Sam 8:1-14](#)).

Psalms 18:1–50

This royal drama of divine rescue (also found with minor variations in [2 Sam 22:1–51](#)) encourages readers who are following the laments and requests for rescue in [Pss 16](#) and [17](#). The psalmist describes the dramatic nature of God's rescue in three different ways ([18:7–15](#), [16–19](#), [30–36](#)). The psalm also extends hope that a future Son of David will be totally victorious over evil ([18:43–50](#); cp. [Ps 2](#)).

Psalms 18:2

A shield is an image of protection, salvation, and victory ([7:10](#); [18:2](#), [30](#), [35](#); [84:11](#); [91:4](#); [115:9](#), [10](#), [11](#); [119:114](#); [144:2](#)). It evokes a response of trust, waiting, and godly confidence.

Psalms 18:3

God deserves praise for his greatness and faithfulness ([48:1](#); [96:4](#); [145:3](#)).

Psalms 18:6

God dwells in his sanctuary, the heavenly temple ([102:19](#); see [14:2–3](#)). He knows everything, sees everyone, and will vindicate the godly (see [11:3–7](#)).

Psalms 18:7

The destabilization of the whole earth will be a means of God's judgment ([77:17–18](#); [96:9](#); [97:4](#); [99:1](#); [104:32](#); [Isa 29:6](#); [Mic 1:3–4](#); [Nah 1:2–6](#); [Hag 2:7](#), [21](#)).

Psalms 18:7–15

The psalmist depicts the Lord's descent from heaven to earth with phenomena such as earthquakes, flames, smoke, darkness, and rain. Creation shudders at God's marvelous coming as the Divine Warrior (see [97:2–5](#)) and Judge (see [50:1–6](#)).

Psalms 18:8

his nostrils . . . his mouth: The psalmist likens God to an angry person or a fierce creature (see [Job 41:12–22](#)). • The terrifying images of smoke, flames, and glowing coals express God's wrath against sin.

Psalms 18:9–11

The Lord's sovereignty extends over all of nature (see [104:2–4](#); [148:5–6](#)).

Psalms 18:10

a mighty angelic being (Hebrew *a cherub*): See study notes on 1 Chr 28:18; 2 Chr 3:10–13.

Psalms 18:19

Because God loves and delights in the psalmist (see [18:1](#)), he will save him ([37:23](#); [41:11](#); [91:14–16](#)).

Psalms 18:20–24

The psalmist affirms that loyalty is rewarded. He puts his trust in the Lord (see [16:1](#)) and commits himself to living with integrity (see [Pss 1](#), [15](#), [24](#); see also [19:12–14](#)).

Psalms 18:21

kept the ways of the Lord: The psalmist faithfully obeys God's instructions (see [25:8–10](#)). • not turned . . . to follow evil: The psalmist rejects the way of folly (see [Pss 1](#) and [14](#)) and chooses the way of wisdom (see [Pss 1](#) and [15](#)).

Psalms 18:25–29

The faithful God remains true to his character. He loves faithfulness, blamelessness, and purity, and he hates the perverse (see [1:6](#)).

Psalms 18:26

The pure have clean hands (see [18:20-24](#)). • to the crooked you show yourself shrewd: The Lord knows each person's character, and he justly responds to them in kind.

Psalms 18:27

proud: The Lord hates pride ([101:5](#); [131:1](#); see [Prov 6:16-17](#); [21:4](#); [30:13](#)).

Psalms 18:28

light a lamp: The Lord renews the psalmist's life, helping him overcome the darkness of adversity (see [Pss 112:4](#); [119:105](#)).

Psalms 18:29

scale any wall: God helps his servants fight their battles.

Psalms 18:30

perfect: God's character has integrity (see [18:26](#)). • God promises to protect his people, and he does so. • Seeking God's protection entails trust and faith. Regardless of his feelings or external circumstances, the psalmist makes a deep commitment to the Lord. He experiences joy ([5:11](#); [64:10](#)) as he awaits the Lord's rescue ([57:1](#)).

Psalms 18:30-36

The psalmist experiences God's rescue and provision of victory.

Psalms 18:32-34

The psalmist's victories come from the Lord. He completely depends on God.

Psalms 18:36

A wide path represents freedom and safety (see [4:8](#); [119:35](#)).

Psalms 18:37-42

With help from the Divine Warrior, the psalmist experienced victory over his enemies.

Psalms 18:40

Placing a foot on the necks of the enemy represents total victory (see [Josh 10:23-26](#)).

Psalms 18:43-45

With God's victorious help, the psalmist achieved military and political success, thus fulfilling the history of David's dynasty ([Ps 2](#)). The previous laments find some resolution in this psalm.

Psalms 18:46-50

The psalmist again reflects on the Lord's victories. God's marvelous rescue and the king's victory are cause for celebration.

Psalms 18:47

God vindicates his servant and so fulfills his mission ([Ps 2](#); see [47:3](#); [144:2](#)).

Psalms 18:49

The psalmist's vision of praise . . . among the nations motivated Paul in his mission to the Gentiles ([Rom 15:9](#)).

Psalms 18:50

God appointed David, his anointed ruler, to bring order into God's world (see [Ps 2](#)). Both David and his descendants received this responsibility.

Psalms 19:1

The glory of God refers to the splendor or manifest presence of the Creator ([113:4](#)). • God (Hebrew 'el): *El* is an ancient designation for God that signifies his creative power.

Psalms 19:1–4

The created order is an arena of God's wisdom, and the heavens are the place of God's dwelling ([2:4](#); see [8:1](#); [57:5](#); [89:6](#); [115:3](#)). From heaven, God observes humanity ([11:4](#); [14:2](#); [33:13](#); [53:2](#); [80:14](#); [102:19](#)) and comes to the rescue of his servants ([18:6–8](#), [13](#); [20:6](#); [57:3](#); [76:8](#); [144:5](#)). The heavens remain unaffected by human failures and rebellions (see [2:1–4](#)). They display God's qualities of fidelity, righteousness ([36:5](#); [50:6](#); [57:10](#); [85:11](#); [89:2](#), [5](#); [97:6](#); [108:4](#)), and wisdom ([136:5](#); see [119:89–90](#)). The heavens reveal the Lord's glory (see [19:1](#)) and give evidence of his presence and handiwork.

Psalms 19:1–14

God's wisdom is manifest in heaven ([19:1–4](#)), in nature ([19:4–6](#)), in his instruction ([19:7–11](#)), and in the life of the psalmist ([19:12–14](#)). Like [Ps 8](#), this hymn uses creation to motivate reflection—it is a peaceful oasis after the drama of the lament and victory psalms. The psalm begins with creation as a source of wisdom, then moves to God's word as the perfect source of wisdom, and ends with the human need for redemption.

Psalms 19:3–4

God's wisdom does not need to be spoken. Through creation, it is seen, felt, and experienced. Paul applied this text to condemn Israel for its lack of receptivity to Jesus Christ ([Rom 10:18](#)). • The sun is part of God's creation, but it is not a deity, as people of other nations in the ancient Near East commonly believed.

Psalms 19:7–11

God's instructions to humans reveal his character and wisdom. God's instruction is precious and pleasant ([119:103](#)). It nourishes the person ([Prov](#)

[16:24](#); [24:14](#)) and is of more value than objects of human worth ([Ps 81:13–16](#)).

Psalms 19:12–14

The psalmist knows his faults, so he prays to remain faithful and commits himself to the Lord.

Psalms 19:13

An individual who commits deliberate sins does so with an insolent ([86:14](#)) or arrogant ([119:21](#), [69](#)) attitude. • The great sin is rebellion (see [32:1](#)).

Psalms 19:14

words of my mouth . . . meditation of my heart: The psalmist desires to please God in everything he says and thinks (see [Luke 6:45](#); [Rom 12:1–2](#)).

Psalms 20:1

The title God of Jacob affectionately expresses God's ancient relationship with his people (see [46:7](#), [11](#); [75:9](#); [76:6](#); [81:1](#), [4](#); [84:8](#); [94:7](#); [114:7](#); [146:5](#)). • keep you safe from all harm: See [59:1–2](#).

Psalms 20:1–5

The community prays for the king's protection and victory.

Psalms 20:1–9

This royal prayer for God's victory ([20:1–5](#)) leads to confidence in God's rescue ([20:6–8](#)) and a communal request for God's response ([20:9](#)).

Psalms 20:1–24:10

This sequence of psalms expresses the experience of moving from confidence and commitment ([Pss 20–21](#)), through anguish and abandonment ([Ps 22](#)), and finally to comfort, insight, and hope ([Pss 23–24](#)).

Psalms 20:3

Gifts and burnt offerings express submission to the Lord (cp. [40:6](#)).

Psalms 20:4–5

make all your plans succeed . . . answer all your prayers: These requests could be those stated in [21:3–6](#) (cp. [27:4](#)).

Psalms 20:5

Troops carried a victory banner to battle, under which they gathered and roused one another to action (see [Isa 11:10, 12](#)).

Psalms 20:6

God chose his anointed king to be ruler (see [2:7](#)).

Psalms 20:6–8

An individual member of the community ([20:1–5](#)) responds with a word of assurance and confidence in God's help.

Psalms 20:7

chariots and horses: These were instruments of war (see [33:16–17](#); [76:6](#); [147:10](#); [Isa 30:16](#); [31:1–3](#)).

Psalms 21:1–13

God's people thank him for giving victory to the king.

Psalms 21:2

The king has experienced his heart's desire—God's protection and blessing (see [20:5](#); see also [2:8](#)).

Psalms 21:3

success and prosperity: See [Prov 10:6](#).

Psalms 21:3–6

The king returned victorious from battle and received honor from the people. His greatest honor came from God, who gave him blessings, life, and his presence.

Psalms 21:4

God offers a rich quality of life ([61:6–7](#); [91:14–16](#); [128:4–6](#)) characterized by his presence ([16:11](#); [23:6](#); [27:4](#); [36:9](#)), joy ([16:11](#)), goodness ([23:6](#); [34:14–15](#)), and protection ([41:2](#); [61:7](#)).

Psalms 21:6

God's eternal blessings also bring fullness of life in the present (see [Ps 133](#)).

Psalms 21:7

The king enjoyed victory not because of his strength or intrinsic goodness but because God honored his faith.

Psalms 21:8–12

As long as even a single enemy opposed the king's authority, God's kingdom was not fully present. This prayer requests victory over all evil in the world.

Psalms 21:9

The flaming furnace and fire portray the severity of God's judgment on the wicked. In the Old Testament, this image often refers to hell ([11:6](#); [18:8](#); [50:3](#); [68:2](#); [78:21](#); [79:5](#); [80:16](#); [89:46](#); [97:3](#); [104:4](#); [140:10](#); see [Isa 66:24](#)).

Psalms 21:10

children . . . descendants: Evil will end when God destroys all opposition to himself ([109:13](#); cp. [18:50](#); [22:30-31](#); [25:13](#); [102:28](#)).

Psalms 21:13

Rise up (or *be exalted*, as in [57:5](#), [11](#); [108:5](#)) expresses communal praise and joy in God's greatness and power.

Psalms 22:1-2

A deep sense of alienation from God overwhelms the psalmist (see [10:1](#)).

Psalms 22:1-21

The psalmist alternates between reflections on his present dire circumstances and memories of the Lord's past faithfulness; he ends with a prayer for rescue.

Psalms 22:1-31

All previous laments pale in comparison with this outcry against the enemy and God's abandonment. The psalm contains two main sections: the lament ([22:1-21](#)) and praise for redemption ([22:22-31](#)), which leads naturally to [Ps 23](#). The apostles saw in this psalm an expression of the sufferings of Jesus Christ, who ultimately fulfilled the purpose of David's humiliation, rejection by people, and divine abandonment ([Matt 27:35](#), [39](#), [43](#), [46](#); [Mark 15:34](#); [John 19:23-24](#), [28](#); [Heb 2:12](#)).

Psalms 22:3

God, the holy King, is set apart from all his creation, but he chooses to reveal himself to Israel. • God greatly desires that his people offer praises to him.

Psalms 22:6-8

Both the Lord and people reject the psalmist. He vividly describes his anguish ([22:1-2](#)); he lives like a lowly animal.

Psalms 22:7

Everyone mocks the psalmist's confidence in the Lord (see [3:2](#); [Matt 27:43](#)), which shames him ([Pss 44:13-14](#); [74:10](#); [89:50](#); [109:25](#)).

Psalms 22:9

The Lord took care of the psalmist before he could do anything for himself (see [71:6](#); [139:13](#)).

Psalms 22:9-11

The psalmist reflects on his past relationship with God (see [22:3-5](#)). The Lord has been his very life.

Psalms 22:12

Bashan, a region known for its herds and vegetation, produced strong bulls ([68:30](#)).

Psalms 22:12-18

The psalmist returns to expressing his anguish and suffering (see [22:1-2](#), [6-8](#)). His trouble comes from human beings who act like beasts.

Psalms 22:14

The psalmist's sense of being poured out like water expresses a meaningless, transitory existence that leaves him depleted.

Psalms 22:15

Facing adversity is as horrible as dying of thirst (see [137:6](#)). • Jesus may have had this verse in mind when he said, "I am thirsty" ([John 19:28](#)).

Psalms 22:16

The wild pack of dogs represents fierce and unscrupulous people.

Psalms 22:17–18

I can count all my bones: The psalmist's enemies have utterly shamed him by taking his garments. Jesus also suffered this disgrace (see [Matt 27:35](#)). • stare at me and gloat: Enemies make the psalmist the object of their scorn (see [Pss 35:24, 26; 38:16; 55:3](#); cp. [59:10](#)). • throw dice: Literally *cast lots*. The casting of lots was sometimes a way for godly people to find God's direction ([Lev 16:8; Num 27:21; Acts 1:24–26](#)). Here, the lots are thrown simply as a game of chance. The soldiers threw dice for Jesus' clothing after the crucifixion ([Matt 27:35; Mark 15:24; Luke 23:34; John 19:24](#)).

Psalms 22:19–21

The psalmist faces his troubles by praying for God's rescue. Only the Lord has the strength to ward off dogs, lions, and oxen.

Psalms 22:20

The sword makes evident the lethal intent of the enemy.

Psalms 22:22

I will proclaim your name: The writer to the Hebrews ascribes these words to Jesus ([Heb 2:12](#)). • my brothers and sisters: Literally *my brothers*. In the New Testament quotation, the Greek translation picks up the broader meaning as “my brothers and sisters.”

Psalms 22:22–24

The psalmist praises the Lord and calls for the godly to join him. He tells of God's goodness to the needy, including himself.

Psalms 22:23

The godly respond with awe (see [22:25](#)).

Psalms 22:24

Unlike his response to the wicked (see [21:8–12](#)), God cares about the needy and hears their prayers ([51:17; 69:33; 102:17](#)).

Psalms 22:25

The great assembly might include all nations ([22:27; 26:12; 35:18](#)).

Psalms 22:25–31

The psalmist vows to praise the Lord, the great King of the earth ([22:27–28](#)) who cares for the needy. God alone deserves praise.

Psalms 22:26

God knows his people's needs and addresses them ([63:5; 81:16; 103:5; 107:9; 132:15; 145:16; 147:14](#)).

Psalms 22:27

families of the nations: All clans and tribes of humanity (see [Gen 12:3; Rev 5:9–10](#)) will live in submission to the Lord ([Ps 96:1–3](#); see [Pss 2, 72; Isa 2:2–4; 1 Cor 15:25–27](#)).

Psalms 22:28

The universal kingdom belongs to God alone ([Obad 1:21](#)).

Psalms 22:29

The Lord invites all people, rich and poor ([22:26](#)), to the banquet as long as they worship him.

Psalms 22:30

Future generations will join those from the past who praised the Lord ([22:3–5](#)). The descendants of the godly will receive blessings ([22:30–31](#)), unlike the offspring of the wicked ([21:10](#)).

Psalms 22:31

The Lord's acts of redemption ([40:9](#); [50:6](#); [71:15](#), [16](#), [24](#); [97:6](#)) demonstrate that he is righteous (see [4:1](#)). His righteousness provides the character required for rule, judicial decisions, and relationships. This virtue leads to harmony and order (see [50:6](#)).

Psalms 23:1

The Lord promises to take care of his children ([34:9-10](#); [Isa 51:14](#)). He demonstrated this ability to Israel in the wilderness ([Deut 2:7](#)) and in the Promised Land ([Deut 8:9](#)).

Psalms 23:1-3

People in the ancient Near East commonly viewed their rulers as shepherds.

Psalms 23:1-6

This psalm of trust and confidence in the Lord has been a favorite of God's people for generations. It expresses assurance of God's presence in the midst of adversity. It evokes images of the Good Shepherd ([23:1-3](#); see [Ezek 34:12](#); [John 10:11](#)) and of the messianic banquet ([Ps 23:5-6](#); see [Isa 25:6](#); [Rev 19:9](#)).

Psalms 23:1-28.9

These psalms develop the importance of integrity ([25:4-7](#), [12-14](#), [21](#); [26:6](#), [11](#); [27:7-12](#)), God's shepherding care ([23:1](#); [28:9](#)), God's guidance ([23:2-3](#); [25:5](#); [27:11](#)), God's goodness ([23:6](#); [25:7-8](#); [27:13](#)), and living in his house ([23:6](#); [26:8](#); [27:4, 8](#)).

Psalms 23:2

Sheep rest after they have eaten their fill ([Zeph 3:13](#); see [Isa 11:7](#); cp. [Isa 13:20](#); [27:10](#)). • The Lord leads the sheep for their own benefit (see [Ps 5:8](#)). • Sheep only drink from still water, so the shepherd seeks out peaceful streams for his flock.

Psalms 23:3

Cp. [19:7](#); the Lord's word renews my strength. • The Lord guides by rescuing his people from evil ([23:4-5](#); see [31:3](#)), bringing them back to himself ([5:8](#); [61:2](#)), caring ([48:14](#); [139:10](#)), ruling ([67:4](#)), counseling ([73:24](#)), protecting ([78:53](#); [107:30](#); [143:11](#)), and instructing them in wisdom ([27:11](#); see [Prov 4:11](#)). • The Lord's name guarantees the relationship; he guards his reputation against any accusation of his abandoning his people or allowing them to sin (see [Pss 25:11](#); [31:3](#); [106:8](#); [143:11](#)).

Psalms 23:4

The shepherd used his rod and staff to fend off danger.

Psalms 23:5

A feast demonstrates the Lord's care and mercy toward his people (see [22:26](#), [29](#)). Although enemies can watch, they cannot trouble the guests. • The ritual of anointing the head with oil showed guests honor ([92:9-11](#)), hospitality, and refreshment ([104:15](#); [133:2](#)).

Psalms 23:6

The Lord expresses his unfailing love through the goodness of his presence and other benefits that he alone provides ([69:16](#); [86:17](#); [109:21](#); see [18:6](#); [61:4](#)). He actively bestows care that is greater than the temporary trials imposed by enemies ([7:1](#)).

Psalms 24:1

The Lord created and now rules the earth and everything in it (see [1 Cor 10:25-26](#)). He sees all its people ([Ps 33:14](#)), regardless of their status ([49:1-2](#)).

Psalms 24:1-2

The kingdom belongs to the Creator, the Great King (cp. [22:27](#)).

Psalms 24:1–10

The shepherd of [Ps 23](#), who is also the King of the whole world, takes possession of Zion.

Psalms 24:2

God created everything in an orderly and stable manner (see [89:11](#); [102:25](#); [104:5](#)).

Psalms 24:3

These questions invite readers to look away from their problems with the wicked and to examine themselves (see [15:1](#)). • God's holy place is the holy mountain, a reference both to Jerusalem and to heaven.

Psalms 24:3–6

The citizens of the King's realm include all who seek him. The Lord invites them to enter his presence.

Psalms 24:4

Those with pure hands have not shed blood or injured relationships between people (see [9:12](#); [15:2–5](#)). • Those with pure hearts commit themselves fully to the Lord, as evidenced in strength of character, transparency, and selflessness ([51:10](#); [73:1](#); see [Matt 5:8](#)).

Psalms 24:10

The Lord of Heaven's Armies reigns from his home, the Temple in Jerusalem ([84:3–5](#)). He excludes sin and sinners ([24:3–6](#)) but protects all who dwell in Zion.

Psalms 25:1

The psalmist commits himself to the Lord instead of to idols (see [24:3–4](#)).

Psalms 25:1–3

The psalmist expresses confidence that the godly will be vindicated and his enemies will not succeed (see [25:15–22](#)).

Psalms 25:1–22

This individual lament includes instruction in wisdom and a community lament; it begins and ends with an affirmation of trust in the Lord ([25:1–3](#), [15–22](#)). The psalmist prays for guidance ([25:4–7](#)) and encourages the godly to practice a lifestyle of wisdom ([25:12–14](#)). In addition to the enemies who trouble him, the psalmist confesses his sins ([25:7](#), [11](#), [18](#)) as part of his anguish. Trust develops with understanding God's character: He is compassionate, faithful, and good ([25:8–10](#)).

Psalms 25:2

Enemies would rejoice by singing a victory song.

Psalms 25:4–6

The right path, the path of wisdom (see [5:8](#)), means being open to instruction that leads to life ([27:11](#); [43:3](#); [73:24](#); [119:12](#)).

Psalms 25:4–7

In this prayer for guidance, compassion, and forgiveness, the psalmist turns to the Lord for instruction in wisdom. He confesses his past failures and acknowledges that his hope lies with his merciful Savior.

Psalms 25:5

Biblical hope does not mean wishing for an event to turn out favorably. Hope trusts the Lord's will and gives the courage to face disappointments ([33:22](#); [130:5](#)).

Psalms 25:6

compassion: See also [51:1](#); [57:1](#); [103:8](#).

Psalms 25:8–10

The Lord keeps his people close to himself.

Psalms 25:11

The psalmist again asks forgiveness for his many sins ([25:7](#); [32:1–5](#)). The sins of Israel's kings demonstrated the weaknesses inherent in David's dynasty and the reasons for its failure in Old Testament Israel (see [Ps 89](#)).

Psalms 25:12–15

Those who fear the Lord will receive further instruction and experience God's presence ([25:14](#)) and blessing ([25:13](#)).

Psalms 25:13

prosperity: See [23:6](#). • inherit the land: Unlike the wicked, who will perish ([1:6](#)), the godly have a secure future. In the end, God will bless them, and their blessings will endure (see [37:9](#), [11](#), [22](#), [29](#), [34](#); [Isa 57:13](#); [Matt 5:5](#)).

Psalms 25:15

the traps of my enemies: See [5:9–10](#); [31:4](#); [140:5](#); [Prov 3:26](#).

Psalms 25:15–22

The psalmist expresses confidence in the Lord, commits to a life of integrity, and prays for rescue.

Psalms 25:17–18

The psalmist can find no relief (see [4:1](#); [13:1–2](#)) as his problems go from bad to worse. He associates his anguish with sin, but he does not elaborate on the nature of his sin (see [25:7](#), [11](#)).

Psalms 25:19–20

Knowing that the Lord hates violent people (see [11:5](#)), the psalmist pleads with God to deal with these enemies.

Psalms 25:21

Just as it opened, the psalm closes with a commitment of trust and hope (see [9:18](#); [25:5](#)).

Psalms 26:1–3

The psalmist opens himself to divine examination of his life, especially in the areas of his character and devotion.

Psalms 26:1–12

In this individual lament, the psalmist prays for redemption on the basis of his own innocence and the Lord's justice.

Psalms 26:3

For God's truth to become part of one's character requires a habitual commitment.

Psalms 26:4–5

Because of his devotion to the Lord ([26:1–3](#)), the psalmist dissociates himself from evil people (see [1:1](#)).

Psalms 26:6

Ritual purity required the worshiper to wash their hands, symbolic of separation from evil and evildoers (see [73:13](#)). • The altar symbolizes God's presence ([43:4](#)).

Psalms 26:6–8

The psalmist demonstrates his loyalty to the Lord through pious rituals, praise, and acknowledgment of the Lord's presence in the Temple.

Psalms 26:8

The sanctuary symbolized the manifest presence of the Lord (see [18:6](#)).

Psalms 26:9

Don't let me suffer: The end of the godly cannot be the same as that of the wicked.

Psalms 26:12

The psalmist's footing on solid ground represents salvation (cp. [143:10](#)). • publicly: Or *in the great assembly* at the Temple ([26:6–8](#); [22:25](#)).

Psalms 27:1

Light expresses the Lord's goodness ([27:13](#); see [4:6](#); [23:6](#); [31:19](#); [38:10](#); [43:3](#); [56:13](#)).

Psalms 27:1–3

The psalmist acknowledges the Lord at the center of his life ([27:1](#)). Because of God's presence, he engages his adversaries with confidence. They cannot intimidate him or penetrate his inner security.

Psalms 27:1–14

This psalm mixes two genres—a psalm of confidence ([27:1–6](#)) and an individual lament ([27:7–14](#))—held together by the theme of longing for the Lord's presence. The psalmist focuses on the Lord; his circumstances are secondary. The strength of the psalmist's faith is expressed in his openness to the Lord's instruction, timing, and priorities.

Psalms 27:2

The psalmist's enemies seek to devour him by living at his expense (see study note on [14:4](#)).

Psalms 27:3

remain confident: See [25:2](#); [26:1](#).

Psalms 27:4–6

Searching for and enjoying the Lord's presence provides the psalmist's foundation for confidence and security. He lives in the assurance of God's protection and looks forward to offering sacrifices of thanksgiving and praise (see [18:6](#)).

Psalms 27:5

sanctuary (or *tabernacle*): This early shrine was the Israelites' place of worship before the Temple was constructed.

Psalms 27:6

hold my head high: A sign of victory. • The granting of the request of [27:4](#) prompts sacrifices with shouts of joy.

Psalms 27:7–8

Unlike the wicked ([10:4](#)), who only want a temporary advantage ([78:34–36](#)), the godly search for the Lord as a thirsty person searches for water in the desert ([63:1](#); [105:4](#); [119:2](#), [10](#); [Matt 6:33](#)). They act wisely ([Ps 34:10](#), [14](#)) while waiting for the Lord to resolve their crisis ([34:4](#); [69:6](#); [77:2](#); [119:58](#)).

Psalms 27:7–12

The psalmist requests the Lord's mercy, presence, and instruction. God is the psalmist's greatest good; enemies and other circumstances are peripheral.

Psalms 27:13–14

The psalmist expresses confidence and hope in the Lord's presence. To live in faith means to wait patiently in recognition of the Lord's goodness. Such a life is not always pleasant for the godly ([42:2–3](#); [43:5](#)), but their future is secure ([37:9](#); [130:7](#); see [9:18](#)).

Psalms 28:1

if you are silent: The psalmist appeals to the Lord to take action ([35:22](#); [50:3](#); [83:1](#); [109:1](#)).

Psalms 28:1–2

The psalmist urges the Lord to listen; his urgency flows out of the tension between his deep relationship with the Lord and the adversity he faces.

Psalms 28:1–9

In this individual lament, the psalmist pleads for justice and mercy. He expresses confidence in the Lord's strength and faithfulness, and he intercedes for the Lord's people.

Psalms 28:2

It was common to lift up one's hands in a gesture of devoted prayer ([63:4](#); [134:2](#)).

Psalms 28:3–5

The psalmist curses his enemies, asking God for retribution and vindication.

Psalms 28:5

The wicked do not acknowledge the difference between the sacred and the common, so they have no respect for the Lord's creation, redemption, or revelation.

Psalms 28:6–8

The psalmist anticipates rescue because of his confidence in the Lord's justice.

Psalms 28:7

my strength and shield: The Lord protects the psalmist (see [59:9](#), [17](#)).

Psalms 28:9

The poem closes with intercession for the Lord's people. • Bless Israel, your special possession: See [29:11](#); [133:3](#).

Psalms 29:1–2

The psalmist issues a call to honor the Lord for his power (cp. [96:7–8](#)). • you heavenly beings: Angels or deities who, some believed, held special powers. The psalmist did not believe in other deities but called on people who thought they were real to look to the Lord as the only God.

Psalms 29:1–11

This nature hymn in praise of the Creator declares that the Lord holds all power over nature. God uses the same unsurpassed strength to care for his people.

Psalms 29:3–9

The word translated voice (Hebrew *qol*) can also mean "noise" ([1 Kgs 1:45](#)) or "thunder" ([Joel 3:16](#)). The Lord's voice is awe-inspiring, and it dominates whatever rumblings people might attribute to other deities.

Psalms 29:5

The cedars of Lebanon were known for their size and quality (see [Isa 2:13](#)).

Psalms 29:6

Lebanon's mountains and Hermon are high mountains to the north of Israel. • The Lord can cause even immense mountains to shake at his command (see [114:4](#)).

Psalms 29:8

The wilderness of Kadesh was located south of Judah. God's voice can be heard throughout the land, from the north ([29:6](#)) to the south.

Psalms 29:10

The image of powerful floodwaters connects with the Genesis flood ([Gen 6:17](#)). The Lord reigns as king over the whole created order; no one contests his kingdom.

Psalms 29:11

The ruler of nature blesses his people with peace (see [28:8-9](#); [37:11](#); [133:3](#)).

Psalms 30:1

I will exalt you is a call to lift up the Lord's name in praise and thanksgiving ([34:3](#); [81:1](#); [99:5](#), [9](#); [107:32](#); [118:28](#); [145:1](#); see [Exod 15:1](#); [Isa 25:1](#)). • you rescued me: God pulled the psalmist from death ([Ps 30:3](#)). • In his justice and care, God refused to let the psalmist's enemies triumph (see [26:9](#); [27:12](#); [28:3](#); [31:8](#)).

Psalms 30:1-3

The psalmist praises God for his triumph over adversity, which he likens to salvation from the grave.

Psalms 30:1-12

This individual thanksgiving psalm opens in praise to the Lord for his salvation ([30:1-3](#)), then contrasts God's favor with his anger ([30:4-7](#)), and ends with a transformation from mourning to dancing ([30:8-12](#)).

Psalms 30:title

wrote this psalm in advance for the dedication of the Temple, making his own experience representative of the nation's.

Psalms 30:4

The godly should celebrate the Lord's acts of rescue with song and praise ([33:21](#); [97:12](#); [103:1](#); [105:3](#); [145:21](#)).

Psalms 30:6-7

Nothing can stop me now! The psalmist confesses his presumptuous attitude (cp. [32:3-4](#)). • secure as a mountain: In the psalms, this phrase creates a powerful image of stability and of God's control (see [11:1](#); [18:7](#); [36:6](#); [46:2](#); [72:3](#); [76:4](#); [83:14](#); [97:5](#); [114:4](#), [6](#); [125:2](#)). • I was shattered: The absence of God's favor destroys the security of the proud (cp. [104:27-30](#)).

Psalms 30:8-12

The psalmist faced death (also in [30:1-3](#))—perhaps literally, perhaps figuratively. But when he turned to the Lord, the Lord rescued him and turned his mourning into joyful dancing. Only God's favor can permanently and powerfully overcome human failure and the depths of despair.

Psalms 31:1-5

The Lord offers refuge to anyone who comes to him for protection. The psalmist trusts in and submits to the Lord. See also [71:1-3](#).

Psalms 31:1-24

The psalmist encourages the godly to find refuge in the Lord and wait for his salvation. Despite having had a death-like experience, he testifies to the Lord's faithfulness. This psalm foreshadows the suffering of Jesus ([Luke 23:46](#)).

Psalms 31:2

The psalmist issues an urgent call for the Lord to pay attention to his desperate situation ([71:2](#); [88:2](#); [102:2](#)).

Psalms 31:5

I entrust my spirit into your hand: Whether he lives or dies, the psalmist will trust his Lord. Jesus uttered these words on the cross just before he died ([Luke 23:46](#)).

Psalms 31:6-8

Trust in the Lord requires confidence that he has our best interests at heart.

Psalms 31:8

A safe place literally means a broad place, in contrast to a “narrow” or constricted place of distress (see [18:19](#)).

Psalms 31:9-13

In this prayer for mercy, the psalmist wedges a description of the intensity of suffering and the pain of rejection between two affirmations of trust ([31:6](#), [14](#)).

Psalms 31:10

wasting away from within: This is a powerful description of how despair takes a toll on our physical well-being.

Psalms 31:14-18

Hope does not confide in frail and changeable human beings but only in the Lord. The sufferer entrusts himself to God while waiting for the Lord’s justice.

Psalms 31:15

My future is in your hands: To relinquish control of timing is one way to express submission.

Psalms 31:17

The psalmist, who did not deserve to be disgraced, invokes the principle of retribution (see study note on 1:6; see also “Prayers for Vengeance” Theme Note).

Psalms 31:19-20

Since the godly are under the Lord’s protection and shelter, evil has no power over them.

Psalms 31:19-24

The psalmist thanks the Lord for answering his prayer ([31:1-18](#)) and rescuing him.

Psalms 31:21-22

Praise the Lord: The psalmist expresses his joy at the experience of God’s goodness and love. Throughout his ordeal, the Lord has cared for him.

Psalms 31:23-24

Out of his own pain and renewed awareness of the Lord’s goodness, the psalmist turns to others who suffer. He holds out the promise of God’s loving care for those who persevere in hoping for the Lord.

Psalms 32:1-2

The Lord’s forgiveness restores people to fellowship with him, clears them of guilt, and gives them great joy. Paul quoted this text when explaining justification by faith alone ([Rom 4:4-8](#)).

Psalms 32:1-11

This wisdom psalm of confession and thanksgiving encourages and exhorts the godly to learn from the psalmist’s experience of sin, denial, confession, and forgiveness. This psalm was one of the seven psalms of penitence used in the early church (also [Pss 6, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143](#)).

Psalms 32:3-5

The psalmist acknowledges his own sin (see [19:12-13](#); [25:7](#), [11](#), [15-22](#)) and his resistance to confessing sin. The Lord pressed him hard until he confessed his guilt.

Psalms 32:4

The psalmist attributes his suffering directly to the Lord's hand of discipline (cp. [38:2](#); [39:10](#)).

Psalms 32:5

God has forgiven the guilt and rebellion of [32:1](#). The Lord's nature is to reconcile and forgive ([78:38](#); [85:2](#); [130:4](#)), but he requires confession and repentance.

Psalms 32:6

The godly will learn from the psalmist's experience to pray for forgiveness before it is too late.

Psalms 32:7

The Lord promises to be his people's hiding place ([31:20](#)). Instead of being overwhelmed by terror ([31:13](#)), the psalmist is surrounded by songs of victory.

Psalms 32:8

God interrupts the psalmist's teaching with a message that invites the godly to receive the Lord's wisdom (see [5:8](#); [23:3](#); [25:4-6](#)).

Psalms 32:9

The senseless person is not wise. Rejecting the Lord's counsel ruins life and makes one like an animal (see [Isa 1:3](#); [Jas 3:3](#)).

Psalms 32:10

Difficulties common to all of life will ensnare the wicked, whereas the Lord promises to protect the godly with his care.

Psalms 33:1-3

The psalmist exhorts the godly to praise the Lord with melodies, with a new song, and with skillfully-played music.

Psalms 33:1-22

This hymn of creation (see also [Pss 8](#), [19](#), [104](#), [145](#)) might be a continuation of [Ps 32](#). It exhorts readers to praise God ([33:1-3](#)), to recognize the power of his word in creation ([33:4-7](#)), and to fear the Creator ([33:8-11](#)). It offers hope to forgiven sinners ([Ps 32](#)) that they can live a new life in the fear of the Lord and under divine protection.

Psalms 33:4-7

God's word displays his character and his power.

Psalms 33:7

The nations surrounding Israel thought that the sea had divine power, but it is under God's control, within boundaries that he set (see [104:8-10](#)).

Psalms 33:8

The power of the Lord extends to all the nations (see [2](#); [96:1-3](#)).

Psalms 33:8-11

Fear of the Lord begins with awe for God and for his powerful word. His word created everything and continues to order and sustain creation. He frustrates the plans of people who oppose his will.

Psalms 33:10

The plans and schemes of the mighty will not prevail, except by God's will (see [Isa 8:9-10](#)).

Psalms 33:11

God's word still orders creation and will do so forever. • God's intentions are marvelous ([40:5](#); [92:5](#)).

Psalms 33:12

People who fear God are chosen as his inheritance (see [33:13-19](#)); this excludes rebellious people ([78:62](#)).

Psalms 33:13-19

From the heavens, the Lord searches out and cares for anyone who fears him (see [14:2-3](#)).

Psalms 33:16-17

army . . . great strength . . . warhorse: Even military might is under God's control (see [33:10-11](#); [Eccl 9:11](#)).

Psalms 33:18

God watches over all who live by his counsel ([32:8](#)). He protects, rescues, and remains close to them ([34:15-22](#)).

Psalms 33:20-22

The godly respond to this magnificent vision of God's power in creation and in the affairs of the world with an affirmation of trust, commitment, joy, and hope as they pray and wait for God's rescue.

Psalms 33:22

Using a play on words, the psalmist contrasts his people's sure hope (Hebrew yakhal) in the Lord

with the supposed strength ([33:17](#); Hebrew khayil) of the horses of the wicked.

Psalms 34:1

is another name for Achish (see [1 Sam 21:10-15](#)). The body of the psalm makes no explicit connection to this event.

Psalms 34:1-3

The psalmist exhorts the helpless to join him in praise.

Psalms 34:1-22

This wisdom psalm includes a thanksgiving hymn ([34:1-7](#)) that celebrates the Lord's care for and protection of godly sufferers. It also includes an invitation to wisdom ([34:8-14](#)) and an exposition of wisdom concerning the Lord's care for the needy and the suffering of the wicked ([34:15-22](#)).

Psalms 34:5-6

The psalmist narrates his experiences of answered prayer.

Psalms 34:7

The angel of the Lord represented the Lord's presence during the wilderness journey. He protected Israel from the forces of Egypt ([Exod 14:19-20](#)), and he will guard all the godly ([Ps 91:11](#)).

Psalms 34:8-14

The godly encourage everyone to seek wisdom, to fear the Lord, and to place themselves under the protection of the Lord's angel.

Psalms 34:9–10

Fear of the Lord includes reverence and respect, and it motivates a life of wisdom (see [Prov 1:7; 9:10](#)).

Psalms 34:11

Anyone who listens, even children, can become wise followers of God.

Psalms 34:11–13

Wisdom contains three components: fearing the Lord ([34:11](#)), doing good ([34:14](#)), and rejecting evil ([34:13](#)).

Psalms 34:12–16

Peter quotes this passage in his instructions for peaceful living ([1 Pet 3:10–12](#)).

Psalms 34:13

Godly people control their words; speaking evil and telling lies are foolish (see [10:7](#); cp. [17:1](#)).

Psalms 34:14

The way of peace leads to harmony and order, whereas evil destroys them (see [37:11](#)).

Psalms 34:15–16

The Lord distinguishes between wise and foolish people; he shows his concern for the wise by rescuing them from trouble ([34:15, 17–20](#)), but he destroys the foolish ([34:16, 21](#)).

Psalms 34:18

Those who are brokenhearted possess a spirit of deep contrition and dependence on the Lord. God accepts this spirit as a proper sacrifice ([51:17](#)). The wicked hate the brokenhearted ([109:16](#)), but the Lord heals them ([147:3](#); see [Isa 57:15; 61:1](#)).

Psalms 34:19–22

The godly might suffer, but the Lord will reward them in the end. Similarly, the wicked might prosper for a time, but ultimately they will perish ([1:6; 34:15–16](#)).

Psalms 34:20

Bones represent a person's entire being (see [6:2](#)). • not one of them is broken: John applied this statement to Jesus at the crucifixion ([John 19:36](#)).

Psalms 35:1–28

In this lament, the Lord's troubled servant calls for God to see his circumstances and vindicate him.

Psalms 35:4–10

The psalmist longs for the Lord's salvation. The language seems vindictive, but it arises from a desire for justice and for the Lord to care for the needy and oppressed.

Psalms 35:6

A path that is dark and slippery suggests instability and untimely doom under the Lord's judgment (see [69:23; 73:18; 82:5; 107:10; 143:3](#)). • The angel of the Lord is an agent of judgment as well as salvation.

Psalms 35:10

Nothing in the universe can compare with the Lord (see [86:8; 89:6, 8; Isa 40:18, 25](#)).

Psalms 35:11

Malicious witnesses want nothing but violence (see [11:4–6; 54:3](#)).

Psalms 35:11–18

The psalmist presents the Lord with the reasons for his suffering. Evil has many faces. He is tired and worn out, and he knows that only the Lord can help him.

Psalms 35:16

The psalmist's attackers snarl to express their bitter envy.

Psalms 35:19

John applied this claim of innocence (see also [69:4](#)) to Jesus ([John 15:25](#)).

Psalms 35:19–25

In this prayer for vindication, the psalmist's crisis looms so large that a resolution must be found in the Lord. The psalmist has taken the high road, believing that vengeance belongs to the Lord. God's patience hardens the hearts of the wicked and gives them reasons to justify their evil lifestyle.

Psalms 35:21

Aha! . . . Look: Both words translate the same expression of glee (Hebrew *he'akh*).

Psalms 35:26–28

The psalmist calls on the Lord to judge the wicked and to rescue the godly and bring them joy.

Psalms 36:1

no fear of God: Paul includes this phrase in his description of the depravity of all people ([Rom 3:18](#)).

Psalms 36:1–4

Fools despise what is wise and good as they pursue evil.

Psalms 36:1–12

This lament contrasts the world of folly devised by the wicked with the world of wisdom created and sustained by the Lord. The wicked care only about themselves, whereas the Lord cares for all of creation. He will intervene to bring about justice in his world. The righteous will enjoy his protection, but the wicked will perish.

Psalms 36:5–6

God's all-encompassing goodness surpasses that of the created order. God graciously meets his people's practical needs.

Psalms 36:5–9

As the source of wisdom, the Lord is reliable and incomparable. His faithful care extends to all parts of the created order.

Psalms 36:6–9

All creatures live by God's grace ([1 Tim 4:10](#)).

Psalms 36:7–8

God invites all humanity to the banquet in his house (cp. [Prov 9:1–6](#)).

Psalms 36:9

Light represents salvation and celebration ([18:25–29](#); [27:1](#); cp. [35:6](#)).

Psalms 36:10–11

Since God's wisdom extends to all of creation, it protects the godly.

Psalms 36:12

The psalmist remains confident that the disorder caused by the wicked ([36:1-4](#)) will end when they meet their demise.

Psalms 37:1

envy: The jealous desire to have what others enjoy leads to further sin ([73:3](#); [Prov 3:31](#); [Jas 1:14-15](#); [4:1-2](#)).

Psalms 37:1-9

The wise respond to evil by trusting in the Lord. Trust includes five dimensions: (1) renouncing irritability and envy ([37:1-2](#)); (2) delighting in the Lord ([37:3-4](#)); (3) submitting to the Lord ([37:5-6](#)); (4) practicing patience in hope ([37:7](#)); and (5) avoiding anger ([37:8-9](#)).

Psalms 37:1-40

This psalm elaborates on the problems posed in [Ps 36](#): How should the godly respond to the reality of evil? When will the Lord bring justice? Why does he permit the wicked to destroy his created order? [Psalm 37](#) offers clear responses that reduce the tensions of life ([37:1-9](#), [34](#)) and promise that the meek will have a future ([37:10-11](#), [39-40](#)). The alternating contrast between the godly and the wicked emphasizes the futility of folly ([37:12-24](#), [27-33](#)). The personal observations of the psalmist add a human touch ([37:25-26](#), [35-38](#)). He encourages viewing the inheritance of the land from a long-range perspective: The earth belongs to the Lord, who will give it to those he blesses—the lowly and godly who trust in him, put their hope in him, and follow him (see [37:9](#), [11](#), [22](#), [29](#), [34](#); see also [Isa 57:13](#); [Matt 5:5](#)).

Psalms 37:2

Finite existence is part of the human condition (see [90:5-6](#); [92:7](#); [102:4](#), [11](#); [103:15](#); [129:6](#); [Isa 40:7-8](#)).

Psalms 37:3

To do good means cultivating a devotion to wisdom (see [34:14](#); [Prov 3:5-7](#)).

Psalms 37:3-4

The antidote to irritability and envy ([37:1](#)) is trust in the Lord.

Psalms 37:4

To take delight in the Lord means aligning with the Lord's way in order to enjoy him.

Psalms 37:6

Justice occurs when the Lord's will triumphs and the godly experience his rescue ([Isa 45:8](#); [51:5-6](#); [58:8](#), [10-11](#)).

Psalms 37:7

Be still: We should let the Lord be God rather than taking matters into our own hands.

Psalms 37:8

Irritability and anger quickly corrode character.

Psalms 37:9-11

The wicked will not possess the land; those who trust in the Lord will. The Lord promises an inheritance because he is committed to caring for his people.

Psalms 37:11

The Lord is the author of peace ([85:10](#))—he brings peace to a chaotic world ([29:11](#); [37:11](#); [85:8](#); [147:14](#)). His wisdom guides the lowly into the way of peace ([119:165](#); [Matt 5:5](#)).

Psalms 37:12-13

The wicked snarl to express their bitter envy. They plot to bring an end to the godly, but the Lord derides them because they cannot succeed ([2:4](#)).

Psalms 37:12-17

The wicked seek to destroy the Lord's order, but he defeats them.

Psalms 37:14-15

The weapons of the wicked will turn against them (cp. [7:12-13](#)).

Psalms 37:16

Being wise with modest means is better than having prosperity and power and being wicked ([Prov 15:16](#); [16:8](#), [19](#); [17:1](#); [28:6](#)).

Psalms 37:18-20

The Lord cares for the blameless in this life and for eternity, but the wicked will perish.

Psalms 37:20

Smoke depicts the temporary nature of life ([68:2](#); [102:3](#)).

Psalms 37:21

To borrow and never repay is a behavior of a crooked lifestyle. • Generous givers freely share what they freely receive from the Lord (see [111:5](#); [112:5](#)).

Psalms 37:23-24

The rectitude and strength of a godly person's life comes from the Lord (see [Prov 4:12](#); [14:15](#); [16:9](#); [20:24](#)).

Psalms 37:25-26

The Lord does not abandon his children or their descendants.

Psalms 37:27-33

The godly are wise; they do good and reject evil. The Lord cares for them, protecting them and ensuring that they receive their rightful portion of the land as their inheritance. The wicked might try to ambush the godly, but they will not succeed.

Psalms 37:30

The godly base their counsel on the Lord's wisdom.

Psalms 37:31

They have made God's law their own: The godly internalize God's wisdom and instructions (see [119:11](#); [Jer 24:7](#); [31:31-34](#)).

Psalms 37:35-36

The wicked might appear to be flourishing like a tree (cp. [52:8](#); [92:12-13](#)), but they eventually die and are forgotten ([37:2](#)).

Psalms 37:39-40

The Lord provides strength for his people.

Psalms 38:1

The meaning of this phrase is uncertain (also in [70:title](#)).

Psalms 38:1-4

The psalmist's sins had triggered the Lord's anger and rage, resulting in the arrows and blows of discipline and rebuke; as a result, his whole body is sick.

Psalms 38:1-17

These verses form a prelude to the psalmist's confession ([38:18](#)) and describe his woeful condition.

Psalms 38:1-22

This psalm is a lament and prayer for healing. The psalmist's suffering is associated with his unconfessed sin. He confesses his sin and entrusts his case to the Lord.

Psalms 38:3

Sin can lead to sickness and even death ([1 Cor 11:30](#)). Whether the psalmist actually felt physically ill or his sickness was a metaphor for emotional turmoil, he knew that it came from God and threatened his life (see [Pss 32:3](#); [39:10](#)).

Psalms 38:4

The psalmist's burden results from sin (see [40:12](#); [41:4](#); cp. [Gen 4:13](#)).

Psalms 38:5-8

The severity of God's punishment brings anguish that affects every part of the psalmist's being.

Psalms 38:9-12

The psalmist longs for a restored relationship with God, but he feels alienated. He finds himself lost and alone as his friends disappear.

Psalms 38:13

The psalmist suffers quietly before his opponents (see [Isa 53:7](#)).

Psalms 38:15

The Lord alone will resolve the conflict ([9:18](#); [27:14](#); [37:9](#), [34](#)).

Psalms 38:17-20

No longer able to endure his suffering and teetering on the verge of collapse (cp. [15:5](#)), the psalmist confesses his sin (see [32:5](#)).

Psalms 38:19

That the psalmist's enemies hate him without reason compounds his pain.

Psalms 38:22

Asking the Lord to act quickly in times of great need is common in the Psalter ([22:19](#); [31:2](#); [40:13](#); [69:17](#); [70:1](#); [71:12](#); [79:8](#); [102:2](#); [141:1](#); [143:7](#)). However, wisdom and experience teach that God's people must often wait for him to act ([27:14](#); [37:7](#); [Isa 8:17](#); [40:31](#)).

Psalms 39:1

was a levitical singer appointed by David along with Asaph ([1 Chr 9:16](#); [16:38](#); [25:1](#)).

Psalms 39:1-3

Suffering in silence only intensifies the psalmist's anguish, pain, and inner turmoil.

Psalms 39:1-13

This prayer for rescue reflects the psalmist's discouragement, which comes from having a limited perspective on his situation.

Psalms 39:4-5

how fleeting my life is: This perspective comes out of suffering (see [78:39](#); [89:47-48](#); [90:3-10](#)). The human lifetime is but a moment to God ([90:4](#)), as temporary as a breath (see [39:11](#); [144:4](#)).

Psalms 39:4-6

Because of his suffering and sin, the psalmist concludes that life is meaningless and fleeting (see [Job 7:7-10](#); [Isa 40:6-8](#)). He had expected a wicked life to have those qualities (see [Pss 37:2, 20; 103:15-16](#)), but now whether a person is godly or not seems to be irrelevant.

Psalms 39:8

The idea that rebellion brings on suffering is a common thread in [Pss 32, 38-41](#).

Psalms 39:9-11

The psalmist links suffering with God's discipline, assuming that it is punishment for his sin.

Psalms 39:11

The Lord uses discipline to correct his children ([38:1, 3, 7; 40:12](#); see [Prov 3:11-12](#); [Heb 12:5-6](#)).

Psalms 39:12

A guest (or *foreigner*) had no rights of land ownership (see [Lev 25:23](#)). The patriarchs had lived as guests in Canaan ([Ps 105:23](#)).

Psalms 39:13

Unlike the psalmist's earlier request that God stay close to him ([38:21-22](#)), his present desire for God to leave him alone echoes Job's disposition ([Job 7:17-19](#)).

Psalms 40:1-5

The psalmist thanks the Lord for his rescue and testifies that God can be trusted.

Psalms 40:1-17

This psalm includes a thanksgiving song ([40:1-10](#)) followed by a lament ([40:11-17](#)). The thanksgiving

song includes the reason for the thanksgiving ([40:1-5](#)), an affirmation of commitment ([40:6-8](#)), and a public testimony of God's character ([40:7-10](#)). The lament concerns the psalmist's troubles because of his sins ([40:11-12](#)) and is followed by two prayers for vindication ([40:13-15, 17](#)).

Psalms 40:6

The Lord delights in the attitude and character of the person making an offering more than in the offering itself. • Now that you have made me listen, I finally understand: Greek text reads *You have given me a body*. In [Heb 10:5-7](#), the writer quotes from the Greek version of [Ps 40:6-8](#). He casts the words as something Jesus said as he left heaven and came into the world.

Psalms 40:7

As is written about me in the Scriptures: Moses had recorded God's requirements for Israel's kings in [Deut 17:14-15](#).

Psalms 40:11

The psalmist prays that the Lord will be true to his character when answering this plea for mercy.

Psalms 40:12-17

The psalmist is troubled by both his adversities and his own sins and prays for rescue. • This passage is repeated almost verbatim as [Ps 70](#).

Psalms 41:1

The poor who suffer hardship have special protection under God's law ([Lev 14:21; 19:10](#)); they receive God's justice and godly rule ([Pss 72:13; 82:3-4](#)). The word translated *poor* is often a synonym for the godly ([113:7](#); see [Zeph 3:12](#)).

Psalms 41:1-13

In this wisdom psalm, the psalmist prays for healing ([41:4, 10](#)), laments his distress ([41:5-9](#)),

and expresses confidence in the Lord's blessing ([41:1-3](#), [11-12](#)).

Psalms 41:3

when they are sick: This illness might be physical or spiritual (see [6:2](#); [Ps 38](#)).

Psalms 41:4

The psalmist applies the blessing to himself ([41:12](#)). Apparently he has taken care of the poor ([41:1](#)), but he has sinned against the Lord in other ways. Out of his pain, he cries for healing while confessing his sin. The Lord alone can grant the restoration that brings true joy ([30:2](#); [107:20-21](#)).

Psalms 41:5

How soon will he die? The psalmist's opponents regard his suffering as a divine judgment (cp. [1:6](#)).

Psalms 41:5-9

The psalmist's enemies disguise themselves as friends, while his friends openly become his enemies.

Psalms 41:9

the one who shared my food: Eating together was a sign of unity ([Acts 2:42](#)). Refusing to eat with someone indicated hostility ([1 Cor 5:11](#)). Jesus experienced the same kind of betrayal ([John 13:1, 18](#)).

Psalms 41:11-12

The psalmist knows that the Lord has forgiven him and will bless him.

Psalms 41:13

This doxology closes Book One ([Pss 1-41](#)). Cp. [106:48](#).

Psalms 42:1

were members of a Levitical choir appointed by David to serve as Temple singers (see [1 Chr 6:22-38](#); [9:19-34](#); [2 Chr 20:19](#)). Their ancestor Korah was the apostate who had rebelled against Moses and whom the earth swallowed up ([Exod 6:24](#); [Num 16](#)).

Psalms 42:1-4

The psalmist's longing for God comes from being geographically distant from the Temple as he remembers the past. • The verb translated longs is found only here and in [Joel 1:20](#) ("cry out"); in both cases it refers to extreme thirst in a waterless desert (see [Pss 63:1](#); [143:6](#); see also [84:2](#)).

Psalms 42:1-43:5

These psalms, like [Pss 9](#) and [10](#), form a unit comprising a lament with a bittersweet refrain of hope ([42:5](#), [11](#); [43:5](#)). In many Hebrew manuscripts these two psalms are combined as one. The historical context is uncertain; these psalms might be the voice of God's people in exile, confessing their loyalty to God as he punishes them for their prevailing apostasy. The psalmist longs for fellowship with God such as he enjoyed in Jerusalem ([42:4](#)); his memories only make him more discouraged. As the psalmist cries out to God, he recalls God's love and faithfulness ([42:8](#)), which moves him to plead for vindication ([43:1-4](#)).

Psalms 42:3

Having tears for food speaks of great grief ([80:5](#); [102:9](#); see [6:6](#); [56:8](#); [119:136](#); [126:5](#)). • The wicked try to hold God to their timetable and deny his power to intervene.

Psalms 42:4

The psalmist recalls leading a great procession as a member of the Levitical choir, possibly during the high holy days.

Psalms 42:5

The psalmist feels depressed, but it does not incapacitate him. He remembers that the living God is his Savior. This verse is repeated in [42:11](#) and [43:5](#).

Psalms 42:5-6

The psalmist encourages himself with questions and answers.

Psalms 42:6

Mount Hermon is a high mountain range northeast of Israel. The source of the Jordan is by Dan at the foot of Mount Hermon. • Mount Mizar might be a peak in the Mount Hermon range.

Psalms 42:7

The raging seas, waves, and surging tides conjure images of God's wrath (see [88:7](#)).

Psalms 42:8

The psalmist sees rays of hope. A life oriented to God includes songs of joy and praying for justice and vindication ([42:9-10](#); [43:1-4](#)).

Psalms 42:9-10

The psalmist brings his many doubts, discouragements, and questions directly to God.

Psalms 43:1-4

The psalmist turns to the Lord for rescue from his troubles, for guidance, for restoration, and for vindication.

Psalms 43:2

tossed me aside: Other psalms similarly ask whether God has rejected his people ([44:9](#), [23](#); [60:1](#), [10](#); [74:1](#); [77:7](#); [88:14](#); [89:38](#); [108:11](#)).

Psalms 43:3

In this prayer for God's redemption, light and truth are viewed as guides (see [18:25-29](#); [27:1](#); [85:10-13](#); [89:14-18](#); see also [119:105](#); [John 3:19](#); [Eph 5:8](#); [1 Thes 5:5-7](#)). • The Temple on the mountain in Jerusalem symbolized God's holy presence among his people ([Pss 15:1](#); [43:3](#); [99:5](#), [9](#); [132:7](#)).

Psalms 43:5

This verse is repeated in [42:5](#), [11](#).

Psalms 44:1

we have heard . . . of all you did: The story of redemption encompasses the story of God's favor and power in his past acts of rescue (see [78:1-4](#); see also [Pss 105-106](#)).

Psalms 44:1-26

This national lament after defeat in battle continues the tone of the previous two psalms, including reflecting on an unspecified moment in Israel's history and calling on God for salvation. The people recite God's past acts of rescue ([44:1-3](#)), acknowledge God's power to save ([44:4-8](#)), describe their humiliation in exile ([44:9-16](#)), claim their innocence and lament the injustice of their current situation ([44:17-22](#)), and cry for vindication ([44:23-26](#)).

Psalms 44:2

God drove out the pagan nations during the conquests recorded in Joshua.

Psalms 44:3

Though the Israelites used swords and other weapons ([44:6](#)), they would have lost their battles without the light of the Lord's favor (see [18:25-29](#); [27:1](#); [89:15](#)).

Psalms 44:4–8

God's people feel confident about his mighty acts; he was with them in the past, and he is their king in the present.

Psalms 44:9–16

The people have experienced defeat ([44:9–12](#)), so they understand suffering and disgrace ([44:13–16](#)).

Psalms 44:11

scattered us among the nations: This probably refers to the Exile (see [51:18–19](#); [89:38–51](#); [106:40–47](#); [137](#)).

Psalms 44:22

Paul quotes this verse as a parenthetical aside in his list of things that cannot separate us from Christ's love ([Rom 8:36](#)).

Psalms 44:23

Wake up: Biblical authors often call for God's attention in a crisis ([35:23](#); [44:23](#); [73:20](#); [80:2](#); [Mark 4:38](#)).

Psalms 44:23–26

In the end, God's people can turn to the Lord and trust him for rescue. Their petition for God to remedy their situation is as strong as their lament about God's rejection.

Psalms 45:1

is no longer known (see also [Ps 69](#)).

Psalms 45:1–17

This psalm celebrates a royal wedding; it might have been sung on many occasions and not just at one wedding. As God's representative, the king

carried the responsibility of dispensing justice and maintaining order in God's world (see [Ps 2](#)).

Psalms 45:2

This general description of the king's symbolic status anticipates his permanent legacy ([45:16](#)). That the Lord has blessed him and charged him to bear God's attributes is symbolized by his handsome appearance and gracious words.

Psalms 45:3

Glory and majesty belong to the Lord ([96:6](#); [111:3](#)).

Psalms 45:3–5

The psalmist expounds on the royal splendor the king showed when fighting his enemies.

Psalms 45:4

As God's agent of truth, humility, and justice (see [72:1–2](#), [4](#), [7](#)), the king can carry out awe-inspiring deeds ([65:5](#); [96:4](#)).

Psalms 45:6

Justice characterizes God's rule, as it should characterize the king's administration.

Psalms 45:6–9

The king is like a god among humans; he is anointed by God, he has received a mighty throne, and he dispenses justice as he rules forever. • The writer to the Hebrews applies [45:6–7](#) to Jesus as he argues that the Son is greater than the angels ([Heb 1:8–9](#)).

Psalms 45:8

Fine spices mixed with oil create distinctive perfumes. • The king's palaces were wood paneled with ivory inlays (cp. [6:4](#); [Amos 3:15](#)).

Psalms 45:9

Marriages often sealed diplomatic connections between kings; the women became part of the harem (see [1 Kgs 11:1-3](#)).

Psalms 45:10-12

The bride is a representative of the king. Powerful people and nations try to gain her favor in order to get close to the king. This is a great honor, and she is encouraged to give herself fully to her new position.

Psalms 45:12

The princess of Tyre: Israel traded with Tyre, a powerful city-state. The noblest woman of the city bears a wedding gift to her counterpart, the new queen, who represents an honored kingdom.

Psalms 46:1

Hebrew *according to alamoṯh* ("maidens"; see also study note on 1 Chr 15:20). In worship, a choir or a group of instrumentalists performed this hymn.

Psalms 46:1-3

Even when faced with natural disasters, the citizens of Zion express no fear.

Psalms 46:1-11

This psalm of Zion celebrates God's special presence in Jerusalem (see also [Pss 48, 76, 87, 122](#)), inviting confidence in the Lord because the citizens of Zion enjoy his protection.

Psalms 46:4

Like the streams flowing through Eden, this river brings the water of life, restoration, and healing ([36:8-9](#); see [Gen 2:10](#); [Ezek 47](#); [Rev 22:2](#)).

Psalms 46:4-6

The strong city where God dwells protects its inhabitants. They enjoy the river flowing inside the city. This river contrasts with the turbulent waters (the powers of the nations) outside the city.

Psalms 46:5

From the very break of day: In the ancient Near East, enemies attacked cities during the day; even during the most dangerous times, the Lord will protect the place where his name dwells.

Psalms 46:6

People and nations live in chaos, characterized by opportunism ([83:2](#)), busyness ([39:6](#)), and noise. These people shake, totter, and crumble, unlike the city of God (cp. [15:5](#)). In contrast, when the godly feel disturbed, they cry out for God's help ([42:5, 11](#); [43:5](#); [55:17](#)).

Psalms 46:7

This refrain reminds readers of the identity of the God of Zion. • among us: Hebrew 'immanu, part of the name Immanuel, "God with us" ([Isa 7:14](#); [8:8](#); [Matt 1:23](#)).

Psalms 46:8

Israel saw the Lord's glorious works in the wilderness ([107:24](#); [111:2](#)), but the wicked, who have no concern for them ([28:5](#)), are left desolate ([73:19](#)).

Psalms 46:8-9

This invitation to trust in the Lord offers a perspective on God's interactions with human powers.

Psalms 46:10

A message directly from the Lord confirms the authenticity of the psalmist's vision (see also [12:5-6](#); [32:8](#)). • know that I am God: The Lord will do

what he promises ([Isa 45:3](#); [49:23](#); [60:16](#)). • God will be exalted ([Ps 47](#); [Isa 6:1](#)); he will judge the nations and rescue his people (see [Pss 57:11](#); [89:13](#); [108:5-6](#); [118:16](#)).

Psalms 47:1

People clap their hands in praise and recognition of marvelous deeds ([47:3-4](#); see [98:8](#); [Isa 55:12](#); cp. [Nah 3:19](#)).

Psalms 47:1-2

As the sovereign king over the nations, God requires praise.

Psalms 47:1-9

This psalm celebrates God's kingship over all the earth; it tells of God's victory in dealing with Israel and the nations. Both Israel ([47:3-4](#)) and the nations ([47:9](#)) participate in God's kingdom.

Psalms 47:3-4

The Lord made Israel victorious, especially under David (see [18:40-50](#)). God's mighty deeds of redemption manifest his love for Israel.

Psalms 47:4

Jacob's descendants: Jacob was the father of all Israelites ([Gen 32:28](#)); the name Jacob often represents the nation of Israel. • God loves and commits himself to Jacob (see [Pss 78:68](#); [127:2](#); see [Rom 11:28](#)).

Psalms 47:5

trumpets: Or *rams' horns* (see [81:3](#)). At times, rams' horns were sounded in celebration ([98:5-6](#); [2 Kgs 11:14](#); [1 Chr 15:28](#)).

Psalms 47:5-6

The psalmist portrays the Lord as returning to heaven, having accomplished his victories. For a portrayal of his descent, see [18:9-16](#).

Psalms 47:7

People from all the earth (see [96:1-3](#)) will worship God.

Psalms 48:1-14

This song of Zion (see also [Pss 46](#), [76](#), [87](#), [122](#)) explicitly views Jerusalem (Zion) as the city of the Great King where the godly find protection ([48:1-3](#)). God rules from Zion in faithfulness, righteousness, and justice, and he inspires his subjects with confidence and joy ([48:9-11](#)). They commit themselves to seeing the glory of Zion for themselves so that they can tell the next generation about it ([48:8](#), [12-14](#)).

Psalms 48:3

God dwells in Zion to protect it from all enemies (see [46:5](#)).

Psalms 48:7

The ships of Tarshish, built for long voyages, represent human accomplishment (see also [2 Chr 9:21](#); [Isa 2:16](#)). Their destruction might be the event mentioned in [1 Kgs 22:48](#).

Psalms 48:9-11

The psalmist joyfully celebrates the Lord's presence in the midst of the community, reflecting on the faithfulness, righteousness, and justice of God's rule.

Psalms 48:12-13

towers . . . fortified walls . . . citadels: These structures provide a visual tour of Zion's strength.

Psalms 48:14

No one is like God ([35:10](#); [71:19](#); [86:8](#); [89:6](#), [8](#); [113:5](#); see [Isa 40:18](#), [25](#)). He is the shepherd King ([Ps 95:7](#)) who will guide (see [5:8](#); [23:2](#)) the sheep of his flock ([77:20](#)).

Psalms 49:1-2

Anyone who will listen can gain wisdom ([Prov 1:5](#), [8](#), [33](#)).

Psalms 49:1-4

The wisdom teacher invites everyone to the hall of wisdom; he promises to instruct with a proverb and a riddle.

Psalms 49:1-20

In this wisdom psalm, a wise teacher warns against enemies, whom he portrays as living a rich lifestyle and caring only for themselves ([49:5-9](#)). They cannot keep anyone alive, least of all themselves, even in their memories ([49:10-12](#)). Like fattened animals, they are led to slaughter ([49:14-20](#)).

Psalms 49:4

The teacher used both proverbs and riddles for instruction in wisdom (see [Prov 1:5-6](#)).

Psalms 49:5-8

If enemies who live for material rewards cannot sustain themselves, how can they give life to others?

Psalms 49:11-12

The teacher brings wisdom through irony. Everyone dies, and even those with estates named after them will be forgotten.

Psalms 49:13-15

The teachers of false wisdom cannot rescue themselves from death. Only God has that power.

Psalms 49:16-20

The wicked might have rich, luxurious lives, but they forget that they cannot avoid death.

Psalms 50:1-3

The whole universe must pay attention when God approaches to bring justice into the world.

Psalms 50:1-23

God appears as judge to remind the godly and the ungodly in turn that outward performance of sacrificial rituals and recitation of the law are worthless without thankfulness, repentance, and justice.

Psalms 50:4-6

The Lord is coming to bring righteousness. This hope encourages his faithful people, but those who have been unfaithful will not experience blessing when the heavens above and earth below testify against them (cp. [Deut 30:19](#); [31:28](#); [32:1](#); [Isa 1:2](#)). The Lord comes to restore order to the world ([Pss 5:8](#); [22:31](#); [33:5](#); [40:9](#); [50:6](#); [71:16](#); [97:6](#)).

Psalms 50:7-13

The psalmist delivers a message against those who regard the sacrificial rituals as more important than having a proper heart attitude.

Psalms 50:9

Unlike pagan gods, God does not need food; instead, he wants his people to serve him with a right heart ([50:14-15](#)).

Psalms 50:10

I own the cattle on a thousand hills: God has no needs; he possesses everything.

Psalms 50:14

Thankfulness means looking beyond self-interest to express gratitude for God's blessings (see [51:15-17](#); [54:6](#)). • True sacrifice requires offering one's self to the glory of God ([50:23](#); [Rom 12:1-2](#)).

Psalms 50:15

God's response to his people's cry is to rescue them.

Psalms 50:16-21

This message is against the wicked, who only pretend to listen to God.

Psalms 50:17

my discipline . . . my words: The wicked may observe rituals, but they reject more important matters such as justice, mercy, and faithfulness (cp. [Matt 23:23-24](#)).

Psalms 50:21

Because he is patient, God remained silent.

Psalms 50:22

God will tear the wicked apart like a lion tearing its prey ([Isa 5:29](#); [31:4](#); [Ezek 19:3](#); cp. [Pss 7:2](#); [22:13](#)).

Psalms 50:22-23

The wicked will experience God's justice, while the godly will see God's everlasting salvation.

Psalms 51:1

A prayer for God's mercy and kindness is part of the genre of lament. Sometimes the plea comes from the psalmist's acknowledgment of his weakness and sin, as here (see also [6:2](#); [9:13](#); [25:16](#); [31:9](#); [41:4](#), [10](#)). At other times, it arises from the psalmist's commitment to the Lord (see [26:11](#); [27:7](#); [119:29](#), [58](#), [132](#)). In each case, God's mercy brings an inner renewal.

Psalms 51:1-2

The repentant offender has nothing to offer God. He needs God's favor, mercy, forgiveness, and blessing before he can experience renewal and restoration.

Psalms 51:1-19

This moving prayer for restoration asks for God's favor, mercy, forgiveness, and cleansing. Out of a broken spirit, the psalmist confesses and accepts responsibility for his sin ([51:3-6](#)), then petitions God to remove his guilt and renew him inwardly ([51:7-12](#)). The psalmist then recommits himself to a lifestyle of wisdom and joy in the service of God and others ([51:13-17](#)).

Psalms 51:title

See [2 Sam 11:1-27](#). The text of the psalm contains no explicit reference to this event.

Psalms 51:1-65.13

These psalms of David share a common thread in their reflection on the experience of evil. In [Ps 51](#), the psalmist confesses the evil he has done and asks God's forgiveness. [Psalms 52-64](#) lament specific evils that David experienced. A song of praise ([Ps 65](#)) brings David's laments to an end.

Psalms 51:2

Wash me . . . Purify me: The psalmist prays for cleansing and release from the guilt of his sin ([51:7](#); see [26:6](#); [Isa 1:16](#), [18](#); [4:4](#)).

Psalms 51:3–6

The psalmist accepts the consequences of his sin against God. He knows that there is nothing good in him unless God renews his life.

Psalms 51:4

Against . . . you alone: This is hyperbole—the psalmist knows he also sinned against human beings ([2 Sam 11:2–4](#), [15–17](#)), but his offense against God is more important. He expects God to rebuke him and will accept whatever verdict God renders (see [Rom 3:4](#)).

Psalms 51:5

I was born a sinner: The psalmist is not making excuses but is acknowledging the depth of his sinfulness. From the time we are conceived, we all share in the human condition of sinfulness.

Psalms 51:7

Purify me from my sins (literally *Purify me with the hyssop branch*; see [Exod 12:22](#); [Lev 14:4](#); [John 19:29](#); [Heb 9:19](#)): The psalmist depends on God to purify and renew him (see [Isa 1:18](#)).

Psalms 51:8

Regaining joy is a gracious gift from God. • you have broken me: The psalmist's whole being feels broken ([6:2](#); cp. [34:20](#)).

Psalms 51:10

A loyal spirit yields the inner qualities of constancy and perseverance.

Psalms 51:10–12

God's Spirit renews and recreates the human spirit.

Psalms 51:11

your Holy Spirit: Only the power of the Holy Spirit can change the human will to make it “loyal” ([51:10](#)) and “willing to obey” ([51:12](#)).

Psalms 51:13

As he learns from his sin and its consequences, the psalmist wants to teach others.

Psalms 51:14

shedding blood: This idiom includes any injustice, not just homicide ([9:12](#); [58:10](#); see [2 Sam 11:14–26](#); cp. [Isa 1:15–17](#)).

Psalms 51:18–19

rebuild the walls of Jerusalem: These verses were probably added as a prayer for national restoration after the Exile (see [Pss 42–43](#)); the entire community in exile identified with the spirit of the psalm.

Psalms 51:19

Sacrifices offered in the right spirit come from a heart that is right with God and with others (see [15:2–5](#); [24:3–6](#); [50:14](#); [Matt 5:23–24](#)).

Psalms 52:1

is a paradigm of evil.

Psalms 52:1–4

Liars foolishly deceive themselves by thinking that they can be heroes by their words. They believe themselves innocent of any charges of evildoing, though they love evil and cause destruction. Those who speak curses, sarcasm, bitterness, arrogant boasting, and deceptions ([31:18](#); [34:13](#); [59:7](#), [12](#); [120:2–3](#); [140:3](#), [9](#)) bring about chaos, alienation, and destruction ([Isa 3:5](#)). Their sharp words cut like swords and daggers ([Pss 55:21](#); [57:4](#); [64:3](#)), the fangs of a snake ([140:3](#)), or a razor.

Psalms 52:1-9

Wicked people use words to destroy relationships and communities. They foolishly think that they can be heroes by their words ([52:1-4](#)), but their fate suddenly overtakes them ([52:5-7](#)). In contrast, the godly renew their commitment to the Lord ([52:8-9](#)) and find their future secure in him.

Psalms 52:3

Deceptive speech changes one's character.

Psalms 52:5

God will strike the wicked down like a pagan altar, idol, or unclean vessel ([Exod 34:13](#); [Lev 11:35](#); [2 Kgs 10:27](#)).

Psalms 52:5-7

God's judgment on the wicked will come suddenly and forcibly. The godly rejoice in God's justice, not in the misfortunes of the wicked.

Psalms 52:6

In Hebrew, the verbs here translated see and be amazed sound almost alike.

Psalms 52:8-9

The psalmist commits himself to a life of trust in the Lord. • An olive tree lives a long time when cared for ([1:3](#); [128:3](#)). The psalmist desires to be close to the Lord, his Savior and the source of his blessing ([18:6](#); [23:6](#)).

Psalms 53:1-3

Paul uses the Greek translation of this passage in his description of the depravity of all people ([Rom 3:10-12](#)).

Psalms 53:1-6

This psalm parallels [Ps 14](#), differing only in verse 5.

Psalms 53:5

scatter the bones: Israel's enemies would suffer shameful defeat and lack the peaceful rest of a decent burial (cp. [141:7](#); [2 Kgs 9:10](#); [Jer 8:1-2](#); [Ezek 6:5](#)).

Psalms 54:1

were bent on violence.

Psalms 54:1-7

In this individual lament, occasioned by violent and godless people ([54:3](#)), the psalmist turns to God in prayer and maintains his focus on God's help ([54:4](#)). He prays for God to save him from evil and to judge his enemies ([54:5](#), [7](#)).

Psalms 54:3

The strangers were alienated from the covenant community (see [109:11](#); [Prov 5:10](#)). • Proud and violent people hold no regard for God or for other people (see [Pss 35:11](#), [25](#); [86:14](#); [Prov 11:16](#)).

Psalms 54:6

A voluntary offering is a sacrifice of praise. Sacrifices of praise are the kind of offering God most desires (see [Ps 50:14-15](#), [23](#)).

Psalms 54:6-7

In anticipation of God's response, the mood of the psalm changes from gloom to thanksgiving.

Psalms 55:1-3

The occasion for this prayer is an attack by an enemy.

Psalms 55:1-23

The psalmist is faced with adversaries whose leader is a former friend ([55:12-14](#)), and he is overwhelmed with anguish. He turns to the Lord in prayer and commits himself to the Lord for redress ([55:22-23](#)). Jesus experienced similar suffering when his friend (Judas) betrayed him. He also experienced the answer to the psalmist's prayer: (1) by taking the place of the wicked and receiving their judgment ([Isa 53:7-9](#)), and (2) by committing himself to the Father, who rescued ([Luke 23:46](#)) and rewarded him ([Isa 53:10-12](#)).

Psalms 55:4-8

In the experience of deep anguish, the psalmist confesses that his adversity has become unbearable and he seeks an escape.

Psalms 55:12-20

The psalmist's enemy was once a friend; memories of that close relationship bring him pain (see [31:11](#)).

Psalms 55:19-21

God is good and faithful, but the psalmist's enemies and so-called friend are deceitful and wicked.

Psalms 55:22-23

The psalmist commits all his cares to the Lord.

Psalms 55:23

To die young means that one fails to experience God's full blessing (cp. [Prov 3:2, 16](#)).

Psalms 56:1

by Philistines concerned about his loyalties and brought before King Achish ([1 Sam 21:10-15](#)).

Psalms 56:1-13

This individual lament moves from petition to confidence two times ([56:1-4](#), [5-13](#)).

Psalms 56:4

mere mortals: Or *mere flesh*, in contrast to the immortal and infinitely more powerful God (see [Isa 2:22](#)).

Psalms 56:5-7

The psalmist specifies his charge against his attackers as he prays for their evil to cease.

Psalms 56:8

The psalmist makes a play on the Hebrew words translated sorrows (Hebrew *nod*) and bottle (Hebrew *no'd*).

Psalms 56:11

mere mortals (Hebrew 'adam): The psalm also uses two other words for man: 'enosh ("people," [56:1](#)) and basar ("mere mortals," [56:4](#)). All express the ideas of mortality and finitude.

Psalms 56:13

The light of God's goodness and salvation will replace the darkness of death (see [18:25-29](#); [27:1](#)).

Psalms 57:1

shadow of your wings: As a bird protects its young, God protects the one who trusts in him (see [17:8](#)).

Psalms 57:1-11

The psalmist's cry for mercy and protection quickly turns into an affirmation of trust and confidence in the Lord ([57:1-4](#)). When the wicked fall into their own traps ([57:6](#)), the psalmist will praise the Lord ([57:7-10](#)).

Psalms 57:title

See [1 Sam 22:1](#) or [Ps 24:1-8](#).

Psalms 57:2

God Most High (Hebrew *Elohim-Elyon*) is a generic title for God, who is more powerful than all real or imagined supernatural beings (see [91:1](#); [97:9](#); [Gen 14:18-22](#)). • who will fulfill his purpose: Or *who will end my [trouble]*, or *who deals kindly with me*.

Psalms 57:3-4

These verses are a prayer for rescue from powerful enemies. The metaphor of fierce lions describes human enemies; the psalmist feels unable to escape them without God's intervention (see also [35:11-21](#); [124:6](#)).

Psalms 57:5

This verse is repeated in [57:11](#) and [108:5](#). • God's glory—his manifest presence that excludes all evil ([8:1](#); [19:1-4](#); [24:7](#))—will fill the whole created order ([Isa 6:3](#)).

Psalms 57:7-8

The psalmist is confident that God will end the night of evil (cp. [56:13](#)).

Psalms 57:7-11

This section is repeated with a few modifications in [108:1-5](#).

Psalms 57:10-11

God's glory extends to the whole universe, as will praise for his unfailing love and faithfulness.

Psalms 58:1

rulers (or *gods*): This designation was used for high officials and administrators of justice ([82:1](#), [6](#)). Elsewhere, it might refer to angelic creatures ([89:7](#)) or to the gods of the nations ([82:1](#); [Dan 11:36](#)).

Psalms 58:1-5

The administrators of justice were furthering their own interests rather than those of the needy. The absence of justice gradually resulted in a violent society.

Psalms 58:1-11

The administration of justice is a mark of good government. God expects nothing less from his people. The psalmist condemns Israel's leaders for abusing their power, and he calls on the Lord to rain down his curses upon the wicked. The demonstration of divine justice will reassure the godly that God is just.

Psalms 58:3

All human beings are born sinners (see [51:5](#)); however, whereas the wicked indulge their sinful nature, the godly fight against it ([Rom 7:19-23](#); [Jas 4:1-10](#)).

Psalms 58:4

Venom here means poisonous speech (see [140:3](#)).

Psalms 58:6

The psalmist calls on God to break the destructive power of the wicked.

Psalms 58:8

When moving over dry ground, snails dry up.

Psalms 58:9–10

God's judgment will come suddenly. The certainty of vindication brings joy to the godly.

Psalms 58:11

Vindication is the reward of those who live for God.

Psalms 59:1

See [1 Sam 19:11–18](#).

Psalms 59:1–2

Protect me (or *place me on high*): When surrounded by evil, the godly pray for God to set them apart for himself and protect them.

Psalms 59:1–17

The psalmist laments the power of enemies who conspire with other nations.

Psalms 59:4–5

The psalmist asks God to show the treacherous, deceptive, and wicked traitors no mercy (see [25:2](#)).

Psalms 59:6–8

The wicked threaten like vicious dogs, but the Lord responds with scorn.

Psalms 59:11–13

The psalmist prays that the wicked will be forced to endure the same agonizing pain they have caused.

Psalms 59:14–16

The wicked will go unsatisfied, but the psalmist will praise the Lord's power and unfailing love.

Psalms 60:1

This psalm was taught to young people as part of their education. • regarding the time: See [2 Sam 8:13–14](#). • Aram-naharaim and Aram-zobah refer to the Arameans of northwest Mesopotamia and Syria (see study note on Gen 24:10). • The tune "Lily of the Testimony" is unknown today.

Psalms 60:1–4

When God's people experience his discipline, they affirm their loyalty and await God's answer.

Psalms 60:1–12

The psalmist laments a national defeat and cries out to God for rescue.

Psalms 60:3

wine (Hebrew yayin) that sent us reeling: Yayin, the generic Hebrew term meaning "wine," is often associated with drunkenness ([2 Sam 13:28](#); [Isa 5:11](#); [28:7–8](#); cp. [Ps 104:15](#); [Deut 14:26](#); [Isa 55:1](#)); it symbolized God's judgment of the wicked ([Ps 75:8](#); [Jer 51:7](#)).

Psalms 60:4

God raised a banner over his people to serve as a rallying point and as a source of pride and confidence. • The fear of God that leads to wisdom ([111:10](#)) is not weakness; it provides the perspective and strength required to do what is right.

Psalms 60:5

The psalmist prays for rescue based on the special relationship between God and his people.

Psalms 60:5–12

This section is repeated verbatim in [108:6–13](#).

Psalms 60:6

Shechem and Succoth represent Israel's heartland.

Psalms 60:6-8

The Lord responds with a message of promise. He shares his land with his people as spoils of war.

Psalms 60:9

Destroying a defeated invader's capital (the fortified city) would help to ensure that they would not attack again. The capital of Edom was Bozrah, located to the southeast of Israel. Only God could grant victory.

Psalms 61:1-8

The lamenting psalmist petitions God to protect him and lead him into his presence ([61:4-5](#)). He prays for God to extend and protect the king's rule and makes vows to praise God.

Psalms 61:1-63.11

In these royal prayers, the psalmist longs for God's presence. All three psalms concern themselves with the king's security.

Psalms 61:2

the ends of the earth: This expression has the connotation of a cry that comes from a place far away from God. • The psalmist's heart is overwhelmed with deep anguish.

Psalms 61:4

The poet longs for God's presence and seeks entrance into God's home on earth for divine protection and care. To be received into God's sanctuary (literally *tent*) is the greatest good (see [15:1](#); [23:6](#); [24:3-6](#)). The Hebrew word translated *sanctuary* recalls the Tabernacle and the tent that David built for the Ark ([1 Chr 15:1](#)). See also study note on John 1:14. • The shelter of your wings

symbolizes God's protection and care (see [Pss 9:9](#); [17:8](#)).

Psalms 61:5

you have heard my vows: The psalmist's vows might also be a part of ceremonial sacrifices ([66:13-15](#); [76:11](#); [116:14](#), [18](#)). He praises and thanks God for his rescue. • The inheritance refers to the promise of the land (see [Ps 60](#)), the sacredness of the Temple, the joy of God's presence ([119:111](#)), or any similar reward ([16:6](#); [37:9](#), [11](#), [18](#), [22](#), [29](#), [34](#); [127:3](#)).

Psalms 62:1

See [1 Chr 25:1](#); also in [Pss 39](#) and [77](#).

Psalms 62:1-12

This psalm expresses confidence in the king and offers prayer for him. The king rests in God despite his difficulties. Although his deceptive and powerful adversaries push hard against him, he remains undaunted. He encourages himself and his people to trust in God and to see their human adversaries from God's perspective, where they appear frail, fleeting, and deceptive ([62:9](#)).

Psalms 62:3-4

The enemies desire to topple the king with lies and cunning.

Psalms 62:4

My high position refers to the royal throne.

Psalms 62:5-8

The psalmist encourages himself and others to place their hope in God.

Psalms 62:9

not what they appear to be: People often try to look stronger and better than they are.

Psalms 62:9-12

Unlike God, humans are transient beings. Even when they thrive, their prosperity is fleeting.

Psalms 62:10

The crime of extortion means using intimidation and threats to make others give up what is theirs, while stealing is taking what belongs to others.

Psalms 62:11-12

Strength and unfailing love remain in balance only in God. He cares for his people by ridding the world of evildoers (see [1:6](#)).

Psalms 63:1

Together, soul and whole body refer to a person's entire being. • parched and weary land: When David was living in the desert, he also found himself in a spiritual wasteland, separated from God's people and the sanctuary.

Psalms 63:1-11

The king longs for God's presence so vividly that he eats, drinks, and sees God's goodness. Though worn out and harassed by the wicked, the king sees God, and this animates him with praise. God becomes his life ([63:3](#)), while the wicked perish ([63:9](#)).

Psalms 63:2

The psalmist remembers that he had found God to be present in his sanctuary (see [18:6](#); [61:4](#); [62:5, 11-12](#)).

Psalms 63:3

better than life itself: The highest quality of life is found in relationship with God (see [4:7](#); [63:5](#); [Prov 16:8](#)).

Psalms 63:6

Meditating on God requires focused awareness, concentration, thought, and reflection (see [1:2](#)).

Psalms 63:6-8

The psalmist reflects and meditates on God's presence through the night. In the absence of light, God is the light. The quietness of the night and the longing for dawn provide time to focus on the true significance of life with the Lord.

Psalms 63:9

The wicked were plotting to destroy the psalmist's life through deception and lies, but they would meet their end. • The depths of the earth refers to the place of the dead.

Psalms 63:10

Wild jackals are associated with desolation and abandonment ([Isa 13:20-22](#); [34:10-15](#); [Jer 9:11](#); [49:33](#); [51:37](#); [Lam 5:18](#); [Mal 1:3](#)). The wicked will not receive honor in death; their bodies will be left to scavenging animals ([Eccl 6:3](#); [Jer 22:18-19](#); [36:29-30](#)).

Psalms 64:1-6

These verses form a prayer for rescue from bold and powerful liars.

Psalms 64:1-10

This lament decries the destructive plots and arrogant attitude of the wicked ([64:1-6](#)). The psalmist turns to God in prayer and takes heart in God's justice because whatever the wicked do will be undone by the righteous judge. The godly will

rejoice and grow in wisdom as they reflect on God's mighty acts.

Psalms 64:3

their tongues . . . bitter words: Liars use their speech to kill. This description might also refer to practicing magic.

Psalms 64:6

The enemies create a perfect plan to harm the innocent without getting caught. • Human beings will sink to unthinkable depths with evil words, acts, or plans ([83:3](#); see [Jer 17:9](#)).

Psalms 64:7–10

What God does is righteous. God undoes what is wicked and pays the wicked back with what they planned for others.

Psalms 65:1

God alone deserves praise and is worthy to have vows made to him.

Psalms 65:1–3

Praise is the appropriate response to God's majestic deeds in redemption ([65:3–5](#)) and in nature ([65:5–13](#)).

Psalms 65:1–13

This psalm recounts the reasons why all people should praise and revere God for his almighty power and merciful care for his universe.

Psalms 65:2

All of us means all humans.

Psalms 65:3

you forgive: God graciously removes the guilt of sin (see [32:5](#)).

Psalms 65:4

those you choose to bring near: This includes people from Israel and from other nations. • Only those whom God sees as blameless live in his holy courts ([Pss 15](#) and [24](#)). • At the Temple, God's earthly palace, all nations can gather to experience God's holy presence. No structure can separate humans from God (see [Rev 21:22](#)).

Psalms 65:6–7

God brought order to the mountains, the raging oceans, and the pounding waves (see [Pss 95:4–5](#); [104:6–9](#)). • The psalmist compares the chaotic forces of nature with the rebellion of the nations (see [2:1–12](#); [33:6–11](#); [46:6](#)).

Psalms 65:8

All over the world ([Job 38:13](#); see [Ps 50:1–3](#)), people should stand in awe of the Lord.

Psalms 65:9

The river of God and all rivers demonstrate God's victorious power and goodness through the order in nature and the regularity of the harvests (see [1:3](#); [36:8](#); [46:4](#); [Ezek 47:6–12](#); [Zech 14:8](#); [Rev 22:1](#)).

Psalms 65:9–13

The created order provides clear evidence of God's power ([65:6–8](#)). He shows his love by maintaining nature. Everything praises the Lord as all the parts fit together harmoniously.

Psalms 65:13

Nature bursts out in praise of the Creator (see [79:13](#); [96:11–13](#); [148:3–5](#), [7–12](#); [Isa 55:12–13](#)).

Psalms 66:1–4

The psalmist exhorts nature to join in a mighty chorus to praise God's glory, name, and power.

Psalms 66:1–20

This anonymous psalm includes two hymns ([66:1–12](#), [13–20](#)) that praise God for his redemption.

Psalms 66:2

The glory of his name represents the perfection of God's character.

Psalms 66:3

God conquers his enemies (see [18:44](#); [59:11](#); [81:15](#)).

Psalms 66:5–7

The story of the Exodus and God's victory over the sea evokes responses of astonishment ([66:5](#)) and worship ([66:6](#)). God works miracles . . . for people in order to redeem them for himself.

Psalms 66:7

God's power brings redemption. The same word occurs in [65:6](#) for God's power in creation (see also [80:2](#)).

Psalms 66:8–10

The orderly lives of the redeemed reflect the order of God's world. The Lord protects them from evil and purifies them.

Psalms 66:9

God guides his people into wisdom and away from folly ([17:5](#); [37:31](#); [121:3](#)).

Psalms 66:10

You have tested us, O God: As the silversmith heats silver to remove the dross, God's discipline removes sin from his people (see [12:6](#)).

Psalms 66:11

God decrees and permits the many trying circumstances his people experience.

Psalms 66:12

Then you put a leader over us: Or *You made people ride over our heads*. This expression possibly refers to a foreign ruler who kept the Israelites in submission.

Psalms 66:15

Vows often included sacrifices of thanksgiving, including burnt offerings (see [20:3](#); [40:6](#); [50:8](#); [51:19](#)).

Psalms 66:16–20

The private testimony in the conclusion of the psalm parallels the public praise of its opening ([66:1–4](#)).

Psalms 66:18

Confession leads to restoration (see [32:5](#)).

Psalms 67:1–2

This prayer is based on the priestly blessing found in [Num 6:24–26](#). God's goodness to Israel affects his reputation among the nations (see [Ps 96:1–3](#)).

Psalms 67:1–7

In this anonymous prayer for God's blessing, the psalmist addresses the knowledge and worship of God among the nations (cp. [64:9](#); [65:8](#)). The prayer

requests that God's name be kept holy and that his kingdom come (cp. [Matt 6:9-13](#)).

Psalms 67:3

God's international reputation leads to his praise among the nations (see [138:4](#)), whose turmoil and rebelliousness will cease when they join Israel in praise of God. • One God rules over all, and the nations will give thanks for God's just rule (see [67:4](#)).

Psalms 67:4

God brings the ultimate justice that human beings desire ([96:10](#); [98:9](#)).

Psalms 67:6-7

Bountiful harvests are evidence of God's blessing ([Gen 26:12](#); [Isa 30:23](#)). • all over the world: See [Pss 2:8](#); [96:1-3](#). • All will fear him, joining with Israel to acknowledge the God of Israel.

Psalms 68:1-3

These verses form a prayer for God to rise up and scatter his enemies, as he did when Israel entered the Promised Land (cp. [Num 10:35-36](#); [Josh 6-12](#)).

Psalms 68:1-35

This prayer for God's victorious rule traces God's march from Sinai to Zion ([68:7](#), [16-18](#), [24](#)). He rescued the nation of Israel from Egypt, guided it through the wilderness, brought it into the Promised Land, and established his kingdom. He is a caring and victorious God, whose nature is unchanging. Therefore, the godly hope and rejoice in the prospect of God's universal dominion.

Psalms 68:2

Both smoke and wax represent a transitory existence ([22:12-18](#); [37:20](#); [102:3](#)).

Psalms 68:3

The lot of the godly contrasts with that of the wicked (see [1:6](#)).

Psalms 68:4

him who rides the clouds: This is an ancient description of Baal, a Canaanite deity. The psalmist applies it to the Lord as the true "Rider of the Clouds" (see [68:33](#); [104:3](#)). God wields power over the clouds and the rain.

Psalms 68:4-6

The psalmist praises God's powerful and compassionate reign.

Psalms 68:5

God, the Father of all marginalized and needy people, shows them compassion and protects their rights (see [10:14](#), [18](#); [69:33](#); [82:3](#)). • Like his dwelling, the Lord is holy. The supreme example of the holy God coming down to rescue humanity is Jesus Christ.

Psalms 68:6

God released Israel from slavery in Egypt ([Exod 20:2](#); see [Ps 69:33](#)), and he still sets the prisoners free. • The sun-scorched desert represents alienation from God and separation from blessing.

Psalms 68:8-10

The earth trembled as in an earthquake (see [Exod 19:18](#)). • the heavens poured down rain: Wells in the desert and rain showers in Canaan supplied an abundance of water.

Psalms 68:11

a great army (or *a host of women*) brings: The Hebrew suggests women singers caroling the good news of victory (see [68:25](#); [Exod 15:20](#)).

Psalms 68:13

The seminomadic pastoral people who lived among the sheepfolds were surprised to receive silver and gold carvings from the battle.

Psalms 68:14

The Almighty (Hebrew Shaddai) is an ancient designation for God (see [91:1](#); [Gen 17:1](#)). • The identification of Mount Zalmon is uncertain; it was possibly a mountain in Bashan (see [Ps 68:15](#)).

Psalms 68:15

Bashan is a plateau northeast of Jerusalem and east of the Sea of Galilee that was known for its woods and pastureland (see [22:12](#); [Isa 2:13](#)). The mountains might have included Mount Hermon to the north of the plateau or Mount Zalmon, which might be Jebel ed-Druze on the east.

Psalms 68:16

Why do you look with envy? Bashan is physically much more impressive than the mountains around Jerusalem, but it was not the home of the Lord. Only Mount Zion enjoyed the privilege of providing God's dwelling place.

Psalms 68:17

Chariots, the ultimate weapon of the armed forces in the psalmist's day, are an image of the Lord's power to grant victory ([20:7](#); [44:3](#)).

Psalms 68:18

When you ascended to the heights: The Most High established his reign victoriously in Zion. • a crowd of captives . . . gifts: This is an image of a victorious ruler leading the victory march after battle. Paul applied this image to Jesus Christ ([Eph 4:8-13](#)).

Psalms 68:19

Like a caring father or a shepherd, God carries his people in his arms (see [55:22](#); [68:5-6](#)).

Psalms 68:19-20

The Divine Warrior cares for his people like a shepherd; the people praise him.

Psalms 68:21

God will smash the heads of his enemies: Cp. [Gen 3:15](#).

Psalms 68:22

God will deal with all enemies, whether from high places (represented by Bashan) or low (the depths of the sea).

Psalms 68:24-27

A great company joins together in the pilgrimage to Zion.

Psalms 68:28-31

The people pray for God's success and for victory over the enemy nations ([68:1-3](#)).

Psalms 68:29

The conquered kings will bring gifts to the Lord.

Psalms 68:30

Hostile and rebellious people delight in warfare and insurrection (see [2:1-3](#)).

Psalms 68:32

The term kingdoms of the earth includes all nations and power structures.

Psalms 68:32–35

The psalmist calls for the people to praise God, who is victorious over his enemies.

Psalms 68:34

When the Lord demonstrates his power, majesty, and strength against the nations, he strengthens his people (see [96:4–6](#)).

Psalms 69:1

[Psalm 45](#) also notes this tune, but [Ps 45](#) celebrates the glory of kingship, whereas [Ps 69](#) is the cry of a tired king who feels abandoned by the Lord.

Psalms 69:1–2

The psalmist sees himself as almost drowning but still surviving chaotic forces and alienation from God (see [42:7](#); [69:14](#), [15](#); [Isa 8:8](#)).

Psalms 69:1–36

In this individual lament, the poet expresses his vulnerability, humiliation, and overwhelming pain, asking God to vindicate him for the sake of the righteous.

Psalms 69:1–72.20

These last four psalms of Book Two contrast with the psalms describing God's mighty acts in creation and in redemption, capped by God's march to Zion ([Pss 65–68](#)). [Psalms 69–71](#) portray the king's anguish, and [Ps 72](#) responds with a prayer for God to bless the king.

Psalms 69:4

John applied this lament to Jesus ([John 15:25](#)).

Psalms 69:5–6

The psalmist confesses his sins and prays that God's response to him will encourage others in similar conditions to place their hope in the Lord.

Psalms 69:7–12

Mistreated and abandoned by family, friends, and community, the psalmist turns to the Lord for comfort, relief ([69:13–18](#)), and redress ([69:22–28](#)).

Psalms 69:9

Though the psalmist concerns himself with God and all that is holy, insults have been his earthly reward. This verse was later applied to Jesus' anger at the Temple's money changers ([John 2:17](#)) and to his undeserved suffering ([Rom 15:3](#)).

Psalms 69:10–12

When the psalmist denies himself normal comforts to seek God in prayer, the wicked ridicule him.

Psalms 69:13–18

The psalmist's only recourse is to pray for rescue and relief from his enemies.

Psalms 69:19–21

Alone and misunderstood, the psalmist confesses that he cannot bear his doubts. His heart has been broken by his problems.

Psalms 69:21

sour wine for my thirst: This description applies to Jesus' suffering ([Matt 27:34](#), [48](#); [Luke 23:36](#); [John 19:28–29](#)).

Psalms 69:22–23

The psalmist wants God to transfer his suffering ([69:3](#)) to his enemies. Paul applied these words to the unbelieving Jews of his day ([Rom 11:9–10](#)).

Psalms 69:25

Peter quoted this verse after the death of Judas Iscariot ([Acts 1:20](#)).

Psalms 69:28

Erase their names from the Book of Life: Cp. [1:5–6](#); [9:5](#); [Rev 3:5](#); [20:15](#); [21:22–27](#).

Psalms 69:29–33

The psalmist prays that his pain will turn to praise.

Psalms 69:31

Making a vow often included a sacrifice ([20:3](#); [51:19](#); cp. [50:13–14](#); [51:16](#)).

Psalms 69:32–33

despise: See [22:24](#); cp. [Matt 25:36](#); [Heb 13:3](#).

Psalms 69:34–36

The psalmist prays for Zion, offering a new petition from a new circumstance. He applies the prayer ([69:1–33](#)) to the desperate condition of Judah (see [51:18–19](#)).

Psalms 69:36

God's people will inherit the land because the wicked will perish (see [37:8–9](#)).

Psalms 70:1

The meaning of this phrase is unknown (also found in [38:title](#)).

Psalms 70:1–5

This psalm, nearly identical to [40:13–17](#), contains an urgency ([70:1](#), [5](#)) that fits with the surrounding psalms (cp. [69:17](#); [71:12](#)).

Psalms 71:1–4

The poet has learned to acknowledge God as the reliable rock who will do what is right toward him and his oppressors. See also [31:1–3](#).

Psalms 71:1–24

This untitled lament by an aging believer is more of a confession of confidence and hope than the cry of someone abandoned by God. The psalmist experienced God's power and protection in his youth ([71:5–8](#)) and now prays for rescue from the adversaries who stalk him in his old age ([71:9–13](#)). Even in the midst of his peril, he continues to tell of God's past faithfulness and looks forward with hope to a time when he can testify to the next generation that God is faithful and righteous.

Psalms 71:5–6

The psalmist has trusted God throughout his life (see [22:9](#)).

Psalms 71:9

The poet prays for continued fellowship with God (see [9:10](#); [51:11](#)). In his weakness, he needs the Lord's strength even more (see [143:7](#)).

Psalms 71:9–18

The aging believer turns to the Lord for hope. As questions from his adversaries get under his skin and his own strength fails, he asks God to answer his prayers. He does not seek answers to prayer for himself but so that he can tell the story to the next generation.

Psalms 71:10

In their plotting, the psalmist's enemies take counsel and scheme together ([2:2](#); [21:11](#); [31:13](#); [35:4](#); [63:9-10](#)).

Psalms 71:14

The psalmist contrasts his own goodness with his enemies' evil; he centers his life in the Lord, even during hard times (see [9:17-18](#); [27:13-14](#)).

Psalms 71:19-21

God's righteous character provides encouragement and strength in the midst of suffering. The wounded psalmist confesses faith in God's ability to transform his misery and weakness into abundant life.

Psalms 71:20

lift me up from the depths: The psalmist hopes for the renewal of an abundant earthly life. This later became grounds for belief in the resurrection of the dead.

Psalms 71:21

Being assured of God's comfort also assures the poet of God's presence, care, and goodness ([23:4](#), [6](#); [86:17](#)). God's comfort enhances the psalmist's sense of being alive (see [119:50](#)).

Psalms 71:22-24

As he awaits God's rescue, the psalmist prepares himself to declare with instruments and voice that God is faithful and righteous.

Psalms 72:1

love of justice . . . righteousness: Kings in the ancient Near East were expected to represent justice; the standard for Israel's kings was much higher because the Lord was their model.

Psalms 72:1-7

The blessings of justice create a balance in nature, resulting in harmony, prosperity, and fertility.

Psalms 72:1-20

This royal psalm closes Book Two, with [72:18-20](#) functioning as an epilogue to all of Book Two. The psalmist reflects on the prospects of David's royal line and on Zion (see [Pss 46](#), [48](#)). He prays that Israel's kings will be good and prosperous, extending the Lord's blessing on his people throughout the whole earth. The surpassing righteousness and dominion sought in this prayer foreshadow the coming of Jesus, the Son of David.

Psalms 72:3

The administration of justice transforms the earth into fruitfulness, abundance, harmony, and goodness (see [Isa 32:16-17](#)).

Psalms 72:4

A just ruler will defend the poor against injustice, rescue them from violence, and bring their oppressors to account for their wrongdoing.

Psalms 72:5

May they fear you: In Hebrew, this clause seems to be a response to the enforcement of justice. The Greek version reads *May they endure*, which makes this a prayer for longevity ([21:4](#); [72:15](#), [17](#)).

Psalms 72:6-7

The administration of justice is refreshing like spring rain, enabling the godly to flourish (see [Isa 45:8](#)) like flowers. • until the moon is no more: This phrase means forever (see [Ps 89:36-37](#)).

Psalms 72:8-9

from sea to sea: This phrase represents the whole world. • Solomon's kingdom extended from the Euphrates River in the east to the Philistine

territory in the west ([1 Kgs 4:21](#); see [Pss 80:8–11; 89:19–25](#)), where the Mediterranean Sea appeared to be at the ends of the earth (see [2:8](#)). Everyone will bow before this king, including the desert nomads ([72:9](#)), his enemies, and all the kings of the world (see [Mic 7:17](#)).

Psalms 72:8–11

The anointed king will rule over the whole world. Even hostile nations will submit to him. In the ancient Near East, bearing gifts to the king acknowledged his success and his reputation (see [1 Kgs 10](#)).

Psalms 72:10

The western kings of Tarshish came from a major colony in the western basin of the Mediterranean. The eastern kings of Sheba came from an area in southern Arabia, home of the queen of Sheba ([1 Kgs 10](#)). • Seba was probably located somewhere south of Egypt, perhaps on the western shore of the Red Sea across from Sheba. • The gifts offered to the king represented a tribute and a token of submission.

Psalms 72:11

All kings and all nations must submit to the messianic king. The hope expressed in [2:10–11](#) will be realized (see [96:1–3](#); [1 Cor 15:25](#)) when other leaders and peoples bow before and serve this king.

Psalms 72:12

To rescue the poor means to bring an end to the rule of their oppressors.

Psalms 72:12–14

The anointed king will rescue the needy. He is not only the judge but also a father to the poor ([10:14](#), [17](#); [68:5](#)).

Psalms 72:13

Like a father, the king feels pity for those in need (see [Mal 3:17](#)).

Psalms 72:15

The people will bless him, fulfilling God's promise to Abraham ([Gen 12:3](#); see [Ps 133:3](#)).

Psalms 72:15–17

The just kingdom will be long-lasting and universal. The summary combines the themes of abundance of crops, longevity, tribute of the nations, and the prayer of the nations.

Psalms 72:16

the trees of Lebanon: Lebanon was renowned for its lumber (see study note on [2 Chr 2:8](#)).

Psalms 72:18–19

This doxology concludes Book Two of the Psalter.

Psalms 72:20

This parenthetical note ends Book Two, which consists mostly of prayers of David. Books Three to Five were probably compiled after Book Two; they include additional psalms of David ([Pss 86, 101, 103, 108–110, 122, 124, 131, 133, 138–145](#)).

Psalms 73:1

People whose hearts are pure are renewed by God's Spirit ([51:10](#)), commit themselves to lives of godliness, keep away from anything that is sinful, and enjoy God's presence (see [24:3–4](#)).

Psalms 73:1–28

This wisdom psalm examines the injustice of the prosperity of the wicked. The psalmist affirms that God is good to the godly but his own experience

differs ([73:2-12](#)). Nearly overcome by his doubts ([73:13-16](#)), the psalmist meets the Lord in the sanctuary and gains a perspective that stretches beyond his life and renews his confidence in God ([73:17-26](#)). His disturbing doubts stir a greater passion for truth. He knows that he can trust God and that God will rescue him ([73:27-28](#)).

Psalms 73:title

was a Levitical singer appointed by David ([1 Chr 6:39](#)); his descendants were singers and instrumentalists ([1 Chr 15:16-17](#)). Many of the psalms of Asaph ([Pss 50, 73-83](#)) were probably written by Asaph's descendants at a later time in Israel's history (e.g., [Ps 74](#)).

Psalms 73:1-75.10

The apparent prosperity of the wicked ([Ps 73](#)) and God's apparent rejection of his people ([Ps 74](#)) raise questions about his justice. God is sovereign over the whole world, and he determines the time for judgment ([Ps 75](#)).

Psalms 73:2-3

The poet sees the prosperity of the wicked as unfair (see [72:7](#)) and resents it. • The psalmist's feet were slipping from the way of wisdom and godliness (see [17:5](#); [37:31](#)), but God kept him from falling off the trail entirely ([38:16](#); [66:9](#); [94:18](#); [121:3](#)). • when I saw them prosper: Cp. [72:3](#), [7](#).

Psalms 73:4-12

The psalmist presents a caricature of the bliss of the wicked (cp. [Ps 1](#)).

Psalms 73:6

The proud adorn themselves with pride and cruelty rather than wisdom ([Prov 1:9](#)).

Psalms 73:9

The proud boast, claiming that they own everything and are not subject to anyone (see [2:1-3](#)).

Psalms 73:13-14

These rhetorical questions expect a discouraging "yes" for an answer. The psalmist wonders if godliness has become a meaningless ritual (see [Mal 3:14-15](#)). • My heart refers to his whole being. • The psalmist's pain comes from discipline and rebuke ([Ps 39:11](#); [Prov 1:23, 25](#); [12:1](#)).

Psalms 73:13-17

Recognizing the ramifications of his discouragement and doubt, the psalmist turns to the Lord and receives special insight.

Psalms 73:15-16

If the psalmist had verbalized his suspicions about the futility of godly living, he would have discouraged God's people and given God's enemies an opportunity to blaspheme (cp. [John 13:20](#)). Instead, the psalmist internalizes the problem and reflects on it.

Psalms 73:17-20

At this time, God's sanctuary was the Temple in Jerusalem. There, in God's presence, the psalmist receives special insight (cp. [18:6](#)). • God deals with the wicked over the long term. He waits patiently and gives them time to repent ([Ezek 33:11](#); [2 Pet 3:9](#)); those who do not repent will get what they deserve.

Psalms 73:21-22

The psalmist's feelings about the prosperity of the wicked had given him a bitter spirit.

Psalms 73:24

The Lord leads the godly through their troubles and changes their misery into splendor.

Psalms 73:25-26

Nothing in heaven or on earth is better than being near God.

Psalms 74:1

God rejected his people because their sin aroused his anger ([106:34-46](#)). • Like a tender shepherd, God cares for his people, the sheep of his pasture ([Pss 23; 100:3](#)).

Psalms 74:1-2

In the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall, it seemed that God had forgotten his special covenant relationship with his people.

Psalms 74:1-23

The psalmist laments the destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem (586 BC) with vivid imagery, questions, fresh memories, and a direct appeal for the Lord to act ([74:19-23](#)).

Psalms 74:2

The Lord chose and redeemed Israel from Egypt in the Exodus (cp. [Exod 15:13](#)). • your own special possession: This is another expression for "your people" ([Pss 28:9; 78:62; 94:14; 106:40](#)).

Psalms 74:3-8

Like a guide, the psalmist points out to the Lord what took place during the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Psalms 74:12

my king from ages past: The psalmist acknowledges God's power and his historical bond with Israel ([5:2; 44:4; 84:3](#)).

Psalms 74:14

Leviathan: See [104:26; Job 3:8; 41:1, 12, 22, 31; Isa 27:1](#). Here, the creature's multiple heads suggest a mythical monster.

Psalms 74:15

springs and streams to gush forth: God provided water in the desert for his people (see [68:8-9; Exod 17:6](#)); he dried up the Red Sea ([Exod 14:21](#)) and the Jordan River ([Josh 3:17](#)).

Psalms 74:19-23

The poet urges God to act.

Psalms 75:1-10

This hymn of thanksgiving includes two direct messages from God that provide assurance of his justice ([75:2-3, 10](#)). The Lord rebukes arrogant people who defy him, promising to forcibly humble them ([75:4-8](#)). Together, the community and the psalmist respond with thanksgiving for God's character ([75:1, 9](#)).

Psalms 75:2-8

The Lord will bring justice in his own time.

Psalms 75:4-5

The wicked arrogantly defy the heavens—the dwelling place of God. Through their boasting they insist that they are wiser than God.

Psalms 75:6

No creature has the right to rebel against its Creator.

Psalms 75:7-8

The Lord alone is the Judge, with the power to exalt and humble (see [1 Sam 2:7](#); [Luke 1:52](#)).

Psalms 76:1

The Greek version reads *for the Assyrian*.

Psalms 76:1-3

God's victory over Zion's enemies foreshadows his worldwide victory over all his enemies.

Psalms 76:1-12

This psalm appears to celebrate a victory. The victory might have been recent, such as over the Assyrians (see note on [76:title](#); see also [Isa 37](#)); or the psalm might be recalling God's great acts of rescue in the past.

Psalms 76:3

God brings an end to the attacks of his enemies (see [46:9](#)).

Psalms 76:4

The victorious king's splendor, glory, and majesty are greater than anything in the created order ([8:1](#); [29:4](#); [111:3](#)).

Psalms 76:4-6

The psalmist praises God for his achievement and for his glorious majesty.

Psalms 76:7

The word translated feared (Hebrew *nora'*) is a wordplay on the word translated "glorious" in [76:4](#) (Hebrew *na'or*).

Psalms 76:7-9

The needy await their victorious God, while the wicked stand in fear of him.

Psalms 77:1-3

The night provides a special opportunity for prayer and meditation ([77:6](#), [11](#); see [6:6](#); [16:7](#); [17:3](#); [30:5](#); [63:6](#); [119:55](#), [62](#), [148](#)).

Psalms 77:1-20

The psalmist laments that God has turned away from him, even though he feels innocent. He reflects on his situation ([77:3](#), [6](#), [12](#)) and finds hope (see [25:5](#)) in remembering God's past deeds ([77:11](#)).

Psalms 77:3

I think of God: God's people inevitably face difficult times, but recalling his mighty acts at the beginning of their relationship assures them of God's commitment. • Feeling overwhelmed, the psalmist is unable to deal with the crisis ([142:3](#); [143:4](#)).

Psalms 77:4-6

As the psalmist meditates at night, he feels so disturbed that he cannot sleep or speak. He has pleasant memories of the past, but he cannot look beyond the present moment into the future.

Psalms 77:7

Feeling rejected (see [43:2](#)), the psalmist asks if the situation is permanent.

Psalms 77:7-9

The psalmist questions his status before God.

Psalms 77:10

The psalmist fears that God's hand of protection ([44:3](#); [77:15](#); [Exod 6:6](#)) and favor ([Pss 16:7-8](#); [110:1](#)) is now against him for no apparent reason.

Psalms 77:10-12

The memories of God's mighty works in the past fill the psalmist's mind.

Psalms 77:13-15

This central section of the poem reflects on God as the holy and powerful redeemer.

Psalms 77:16

the Red Sea: The Canaanites attributed divine power to the sea, but God is the one who made the sea and uses it for his own purposes.

Psalms 78:1-8

The prologue is an invitation to learn wisdom.

Psalms 78:1-72

This wisdom psalm exhorts the people to learn wisdom and faithfully pass it on.

Psalms 78:2

The psalmist recites Israel's story ([78:5-72](#)) in a parable in order to teach wisdom and insight. • Jesus quoted this verse to explain why he taught in parables ([Matt 13:35](#)).

Psalms 78:3-4

This story of what God has done should be told from generation to generation (see [Deut 6:20-25](#); [Prov 4:1-4](#)).

Psalms 78:5-6

The telling of the story should motivate God's people to obey what he commanded ([Deut 6:4-9](#)).

Psalms 78:7-8

God holds each generation responsible for its own response, which should be to maintain faith and hope (see [9:18](#); [27:14](#)) and avoid being stubborn, rebellious, and unfaithful (see [Deut 9:6-7](#); [10:16](#); [30:6](#); [31:27](#)).

Psalms 78:9-11

Ephraim, the second son of Joseph, received a special blessing from Jacob ([Gen 48:15-20](#); [49:22-26](#); [Deut 33:13-17](#)). The land that his descendants received included fertile valleys and strategic roads ([Judg 8:2](#)). However, the people of Ephraim did not live in obedience to God's gracious covenant.

Psalms 78:12

The miracles are the ten plagues against Egypt that God performed during Israel's captivity ([Exod 7-12](#)).

Psalms 78:12-16

The focus shifts from Ephraim ([78:9-11](#)) to Israel as a whole as the psalmist reflects on God's power in Egypt (see [81:4-7](#)) and in the wilderness.

Psalms 78:13

God divided the sea when Israel crossed through the Red Sea (see [Exod 14-15](#)).

Psalms 78:14

God used a cloud and a pillar of fire to guide and protect Israel in the wilderness ([Exod 13:21-22](#)).

Psalms 78:17-31

Israel rebelled in the wilderness despite God's abundant provision.

Psalms 78:23-25

Abundance comes through the doors of heaven ([Gen 8:2](#); [2 Kgs 7:2](#); [Mal 3:10](#)). • Israel ate manna for forty years in the wilderness ([Exod 16:31-36](#); [John 6:31](#)).

Psalms 78:26-31

God powerfully satisfied the people's desires, but they did not respond with gratitude or faith. Therefore, God exercised his justice.

Psalms 78:32-39

Israel's rebellion resulted in God's judgment, but even their short-lived and insincere repentance motivated God to exercise forbearance.

Psalms 78:33

An entire generation died in the wilderness ([Num 14:22-23](#), [28-35](#)).

Psalms 78:34

They repented: This demonstration of zeal was not sincere.

Psalms 78:34-39

Israel's continued existence, in spite of the people's rebellion and unbelief ([78:7-8](#)), was due to God's compassion.

Psalms 78:35-39

The Israelites remembered the right doctrine ([9:9](#); [91:1](#)), but they did not allow God to change their hearts ([Lev 26:41](#)).

Psalms 78:40-55

The Israelites rebelled even though the Lord had rescued them from powerful plagues.

Psalms 78:56-64

Israel's rebellion desecrated the Promised Land. The people built shrines to false gods and worshiped idols ([78:58](#)) during the period of the judges (e.g., [Judg 2:11](#); [3:7](#), [17-18](#)).

Psalms 78:60

God abandoned his dwelling at Shiloh because of the people's idol worship ([1 Sam 4:11](#); [Jer 7:12](#)).

Psalms 78:67

The tribe of Ephraim was not completely rejected, but God favored Judah ([78:68](#)).

Psalms 78:68-69

In the choice of Mount Zion instead of Shiloh as God's sanctuary on earth, God moved from the north to the south (see [Ps 69](#)).

Psalms 78:70-72

The God who had turned against his own people ([78:62](#)) chose David, a shepherd ([Gen 46:34](#); [1 Sam 16:10-11](#)), to become their shepherd ([Ps 78:52](#); cp. [23:1](#)).

Psalms 79:1

your special possession: This phrase might refer to the land, the Temple (see [61:5](#)), or the people (see [79:2](#); [78:71](#)).

Psalms 79:1-4

The poet laments the desecration of the Temple and the success of the enemy.

Psalms 79:1-13

This lament describes the occasion of Jerusalem's fall in 586 BC. The early history of Israel's rebellions described in [Ps 78](#) provoked God's wrath, resulting in the desolation of Zion described here as the defilement of the Temple and the disgraced bodies that littered the landscape. The psalmist then prays for forgiveness and rescue ([79:8-9](#)), as well as for God to pay back the nation's enemies ([79:12-13](#)). Other psalms lamenting the Exile include [Pss 42-44](#), [102](#), [107](#), [126](#), [137](#).

Psalms 79:5-8

The intensity of God's judgment surprises the people; they cry out in despair for compassion, forgiveness, and relief. Verses [6-7](#) are repeated almost verbatim in [Jer 10:25](#).

Psalms 79:6

The repentant among God's people ask him to vent his anger not on them but on their wicked and unrepentant enemies.

Psalms 79:8

The people's accumulation of past sins contributed to the Exile ([2 Kgs 17:7-23](#); [24:3-4](#)); however, the people perished because of their own sins ([Jer 31:30](#); [Ezek 18:20](#)).

Psalms 79:9-11

The people ask God to rescue them. Although Israel's sins caused the tragedy, the pagan nations must also be held responsible for the bloodshed.

Psalms 79:12

The Exile resulted in national suffering and in individual searching for the Lord. • pay back: See [1:6](#); [94:2](#); [Jer 32:18](#). • The expression seven times signifies something complete. • Israel's neighbors included Edom, Moab, and Ammon (see [Ps 137:7](#); [2 Kgs 24:2](#); [Obad 1](#)).

Psalms 80:1

is unknown today.

Psalms 80:1-2

God is the Shepherd of Israel: See also [23:1](#); [28:9](#); [78:52-53](#). • radiant glory . . . power: These expressions ([145:11](#)) refer to God's manifest presence.

Psalms 80:1-3

The psalmist urgently calls upon the Lord to act.

Psalms 80:1-19

This psalm of lament might originate with the remnant of the northern kingdom after its fall in 722 BC. The people call on God as their Shepherd and as the God of Heaven's Armies in the hope that he will return to them and restore them. They remember the Exodus and their special relationship with the Lord and conclude with an expression of renewed commitment to him ([80:18](#)).

Psalms 80:3

This verse is repeated (with an increasing crescendo) in [80:7](#), [19](#).

Psalms 80:4-7

The people cry out for rescue from the shame of their recent defeat. The enemy's victory is less devastating, however, than the knowledge that they themselves are objects of God's wrath.

Psalms 80:8–9

Israel had been a prosperous grapevine ([Gen 1:28](#); [Gal 5:22–23](#)) that God transplanted into the land of Canaan at the time of the conquest. However, the people forgot the source of their prosperity and chose to do evil ([Isa 5:1–7](#); [Hos 10:1](#)).

Psalms 80:8–11

Israel has a glorious past, beginning with its redemption from Egypt.

Psalms 80:10–11

Solomon's kingdom had extended west to the Mediterranean Sea and east to the Euphrates River (see [72:8–9](#); [89:25](#); [1 Kgs 4:21](#)).

Psalms 80:12

broken down our walls: God no longer defended Israel ([Isa 5:5](#)).

Psalms 80:13

The surrounding nations were ceremonially unclean, like a wild boar or vicious wild animals.

Psalms 80:15

Israel was the son that God had brought out of Egypt (see [Hos 11:1](#)) and planted in the Holy Land.

Psalms 80:16–19

The community prays for God to change their desperate situation and restore them. They are still the Lord's chosen people.

Psalms 80:17

The son of your choice was probably the northern kingdom of Israel, although it might allude to the king of David's dynasty ([110:1](#)).

Psalms 81:1–3

As a prelude to the message of warning, the psalmist invites Israel to contemplate their God in song and dance.

Psalms 81:1–16

This warning message invites Israel to worship only the Lord and to enjoy the fullness of his blessing.

Psalms 81:2

An Israelite tambourine was a hand drum—a round frame covered with a skin, used as a percussion instrument during festivities, often to accompany dancing ([68:25](#); [149:3](#); [150:4](#)). • The sweet lyre and the harp, both stringed instruments, are the instruments most frequently mentioned in the psalms (e.g., [33:2](#); [57:8](#); [71:22](#); [150:3](#)).

Psalms 81:3

The ram's horn mustered armies and announced special holy days ([47:5](#); [98:6](#)). • new moon: The first day of the lunar month marked a festival.

Psalms 81:4–5

The festival, a time to celebrate and listen to the Lord, took place at God's appointed time.

Psalms 81:5

for Israel: Literally *for Joseph*. The tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh (the sons of Joseph) are used here to refer to the entire nation of Israel.

Psalms 81:6–7

The Lord heard Israel's cry in Egypt and rescued them from oppressive slavery.

Psalms 81:8–10

God pleads with his people to remember the covenant and the Ten Commandments.

Psalms 81:10

God emphasizes that he and no one else rescued Israel. • The nation should open its mouth wide to take in God's word (cp. [Deut 8:3](#); [Ezek 3:1](#)).

Psalms 81:11–16

The Lord helps Israel to understand that their failure was not because of his weakness.

Psalms 81:13–14

God wants to give his children his goodness, but only if they listen ([Isa 1:18–19](#); [28:12](#); [48:18–19](#); see [Deut 6:3](#)). • God promises to subdue the enemies ([Deut 9:3](#)) of those who walk the paths of obedience and loyalty. He will also richly feed his people ([Isa 1:19](#)).

Psalms 82:1

God presides and stands ready to render judgment (see [Isa 3:13](#)). • heaven's court: See [Job 1:6](#).

Psalms 82:1–8

God condemns those who mistreat the helpless.

Psalms 82:2

Since justice marks God's reign ([89:4](#)), he opposes favoring the wicked. So the psalmist is perplexed and cries out to God for justice ([82:3–4](#), [8](#)).

Psalms 82:5

The unjust oppressors cannot bring or restore order. They wander about in darkness, unmoved by circumstances even when the whole world order falls apart around them (cp. [11:3](#)).

Psalms 82:6–7

The gods (see study notes on [29:1–2](#); [58:1](#)), like mere mortals, cannot escape the judgment common to human rulers. Jesus quoted from this passage in [John 10:34](#).

Psalms 82:8

The nations belong to God; he will take over the realms formerly ruled by local deities and give them to his people, just as he did with the Promised Land.

Psalms 83:1–4

The enemy has successfully intimidated God's people, so the poet prays that the Lord will hear and act.

Psalms 83:1–18

This community lament asks God for rescue and victory. The terse poetry suggests difficult times. A powerful coalition desires to destroy Israel ([83:1–4](#)) and allies itself against God ([83:5–8](#)). Recalling the fate of others who came against Israel ([83:9–12](#)), the psalmist prays that the same will happen to these enemies ([83:13–16](#)) so that God will receive honor among them ([83:17–18](#)). It is unclear whether this psalm arose out of a specific historical instance of opposition by these nations, or if it is a poetic collage of nations representing Israel's enemies.

Psalms 83:5–8

signed a treaty: The allies agreed to fight against God and his people. The nations that are named in the alliance were situated around Israel and Judah.

Psalms 83:6–7

The Edomites, descendants of Esau, were located to the southeast of Judah (see [Gen 25:30](#); [32:3](#); [36:1–8](#)). • Ishmaelites were desert-dwelling descendants of Hagar. • Moabites and Ammonites descended from Lot; both were located to the east of Israel and Judah. • The Hagrites were possibly located north of the Ammonites ([1 Chr 5:10](#)).

Psalms 83:7

The Gebalites probably came from Gebal/Byblos on the coast of Lebanon. • The Amalekites were located south of Israel in the Negev. • Philistia was southwest of Judah, by the Mediterranean Sea. • Tyre was a port city on the Mediterranean, northwest of Israel.

Psalms 83:8

Assyria was northeast of Israel and north of the Persian Gulf. • The descendants of Lot were the Moabites and the Ammonites ([83:6–7](#)).

Psalms 83:9–11

The Midianites, ruled by Zebah and Zalmunna and led by Oreb and Zeeb, were Israel's enemy in the days of Gideon ([Judg 7:1–8:5](#)). Barak's coalition defeated Sisera and Jabin ([Judg 4](#)).

Psalms 83:9–18

The psalmist prays that God will miraculously destroy the new coalition as he did three other enemies; doing so would bring him glory.

Psalms 83:12

The coalition's motivation for wiping out Israel was to acquire the land (see [Jer 3:19](#)).

Psalms 83:13

tumbleweed . . . chaff: This dry plant material easily blows away (see [Isa 17:13](#)).

Psalms 83:14–15

fire . . . fierce storm . . . tempest: These are images of God's manifestation in judgment (see [Isa 29:6](#)).

Psalms 84:1–4

The psalmist is far from the Temple. He turns toward it in hopeful reflection.

Psalms 84:1–12

The psalmist expresses his deep spiritual longing for God's presence. He faints with longing as he reflects on the Temple and on pilgrims making the journey to Jerusalem ([84:1–7](#)). He prays for himself and for the community ([84:8–9](#)). The conclusion of the psalm ([84:10–12](#)) clarifies that the Temple represents God—the psalmist truly longs for God's presence. He knows that God's goodness is greater than life and that only God can give his people favor and honor ([84:10–11](#)).

Psalms 84:3

The poet envies the birds that have nesting places in and around the Temple.

Psalms 84:4

The priests and Temple personnel lived in the Temple.

Psalms 84:5

Travelers needed strength to meet the challenges of pilgrimage by foot along unpaved paths, in all kinds of weather and with the possibility of assaults.

Psalms 84:5–7

The pilgrimage to Jerusalem reenacted the Exodus, when God marvelously provided for his people (see [78:15–16](#); [105:41](#)). The psalmist imagines the pains of travel turning to the joy of arrival.

Psalms 84:6

The Valley of Weeping probably refers to the anguish that lonely pilgrims endured (see [23:4](#)), rather than to an actual location. • refreshing springs . . . autumn rains: Even when pilgrims feel totally exhausted, the prospect of drawing near to the Lord renews their spirits (cp. [Isa 35:6–10](#); [41:18–20](#); [43:17–20](#); [49:10](#)).

Psalms 84:9

Both kings and priests were anointed to dedicate them for service (see [132:17](#); [Exod 28:41](#); [1 Sam 9:16](#); [16:1–13](#); cp. [Isa 61:1](#); [Acts 10:38](#)).

Psalms 84:10

The psalmist viewed being in God's presence as much better than being anywhere else.

Psalms 84:11

Some people worshiped the sun as a god, but the true God provides all that anyone needs.

Psalms 85:1

God restored the fortunes of Israel by bringing the nation back from exile (see [14:7](#); [126:1](#)).

Psalms 85:1–5

Though the psalmist gratefully acknowledges God's goodness, he also asks God whether his wrath will last forever.

Psalms 85:1–13

The psalmist leads the postexilic community in lament and prayer for full redemption. He ponders God's past rescue of Israel from exile ([85:1–3](#)), longs for greater evidence of God's goodness, and leads the community in prayer for full restoration ([85:4–7](#)). God responds with a message of peace ([85:8–9](#)), and the psalm concludes with a lyrical

outburst at the grandeur of God's salvation ([85:10–13](#)).

Psalms 85:2

When God forgave the guilt of their sins, he gave the people the possibility of fellowship with him (see [32:5](#)).

Psalms 85:6–7

This prayer for renewal is based on God's unfailing love for his people.

Psalms 85:8–9

When God the Lord speaks, his faithful people listen. He promises them peace, meaning wholeness and well-being (see [37:11](#)). They fear the Lord and know that he and his salvation are near to them. • The Lord does not tolerate foolish ways, such as those that resulted in the Exile.

Psalms 85:10–13

In the glorious world of renewal and salvation, all the qualities of God's care—love, truth, righteousness, and peace—come together and transform the created order into something new (see [Isa 32:15–20](#)).

Psalms 85:13

Righteousness is like a messenger preparing the world for God's coming in response to the prayers of his people ([85:4–7](#); [89:14](#)).

Psalms 86:1

This is the only Psalm connected to David in the third book.

Psalms 86:1-4

God's devoted servant prays for mercy. The psalmist sees himself as a member of the covenant community and as a citizen of the world.

Psalms 86:1-17

The psalmist invokes God's help and praises his character in a lament prompted by the presence of evil ([86:14](#), [17](#)). All people will worship the gracious and almighty God ([86:8-10](#)). To this end, the poet commits himself to a lifestyle of ethical integrity ([86:11](#)) and praising the Lord ([86:12-13](#)). The last stanza contrasts the qualities of evil people with those of the Lord ([86:14-17](#)).

Psalms 86:5

The psalmist recounts the catalog of divine perfections ([Exod 34:6-7](#)), especially God's willingness to forgive sin (see [Pss 32:5](#); [85:2](#); [145:7-10](#)).

Psalms 86:5-7

The psalmist appeals to God to remain true to his character, which is the basis for hope.

Psalms 86:8-10

All the nations must submit themselves to the Lord and worship him ([45:17](#); [117:1](#); [148:7-11](#)).

Psalms 86:11

The poet responds to the Lord by seeking faithful instruction in the truth. • An individual with purity of heart has integrity and wholeness (see [73:1](#)).

Psalms 86:12-13

In anticipation of God's rescue, the psalmist praises him and trusts in his goodness.

Psalms 86:14-17

The arrogant exist both inside and outside the community. The psalmist asks for a vision of God's character; God is so great that just a glimpse of his goodness will shut the mouths of the wicked.

Psalms 86:15

God has mercy on his people ([51:1](#)); he is gracious ([25:6](#)), slow to get angry ([103:8](#); [145:8](#)), and filled with unfailing love and faithfulness (Hebrew *khesed* and *'emeth*; [143:1](#)). This verse repeats a theme first expressed in [Exod 34:7](#); [Num 14:18](#) (cp. [Pss 103:8](#); [145:8](#); [Neh 9:17](#); [Joel 2:13](#); [Jon 4:2](#)).

Psalms 87:1

Jerusalem was Israel's capital and the location of the Temple, God's earthly palace (see [Ps 84](#)).

Psalms 87:1-7

This psalm envisions Jerusalem as the city of God where all the nations are citizens.

Psalms 87:4

As great as Zion is, it will be even greater when it becomes an international city where believers from all the nations have citizenship. • God keeps a record of all who confess him as their Lord ([Dan 7:10](#); [Rev 13:8](#)).

Psalms 87:5-6

Jerusalem becomes the international city where all God's children are citizens.

Psalms 88:1

might be a sage from Solomon's time ([1 Kgs 4:31](#)), a descendant of Judah ([1 Chr 2:6](#)), or a member of the Levitical family charged with singing at the Temple ([1 Chr 15:17](#); [2 Chr 5:12](#)).

Psalms 88:1–5

The psalmist calls on the Lord for salvation.

Psalms 88:1–18

In this lament, the psalmist sees himself as cast out from God's presence. At first, he calls on the Lord. When he finds no relief from his suffering, he presents three charges against God ([88:6–7](#), [8–12](#), [13–17](#)).

Psalms 88:6–7

In his first charge, the psalmist blames the Lord for his demise. God's overpowering anger did not make sense. • The phrase the darkest depths implies the place of the dead ([143:3](#); see [Lam 3:6](#)) or the depths of the sea ([Pss 68:22](#); [69:1–2](#)).

Psalms 88:8–12

In his second charge, the psalmist claims that God has isolated him and caused his loneliness (cp. [31:11](#); [38:11](#)). Loneliness was a curse in a culture where relationships were more important than personal achievement.

Psalms 88:13–17

In his third charge, the psalmist accuses the Lord of rejecting him. The force and apparent cruelty of the psalmist's suffering overwhelm him.

Psalms 88:18

The psalmist restates his second and first charges.

Psalms 89:1

God's unfailing love gives reason to celebrate forever.

Psalms 89:1–52

Book Three ([Pss 73–89](#)) begins and ends with weighty questions. Though [Ps 89](#) begins with a praise-filled account of how the Lord exalted the throne of David ([89:1–37](#)), the psalmist protests the Lord's apparent rejection of his covenant with David ([89:38–51](#); see [2 Sam 7:8–16](#)).

Psalms 89:title

was a wise man ([1 Kgs 4:31](#); cp. [Ps 88:title](#)).

Psalms 89:3

The Lord has sworn by his own holiness ([89:35](#); see [110:4](#)).

Psalms 89:3–4

The psalmist restates God's covenant with David (see also [89:19–37](#)).

Psalms 89:5

Praise for God's greatness (see [8:1](#)) comes from the inhabitants of heaven who witness his faithfulness.

Psalms 89:5–8

God is the absolute standard of faithfulness, commitment, and order. The angelic beings and the heavens testify to his constancy.

Psalms 89:6

mightiest angel: Literally *son of God* (see study note on [29:1–2](#)).

Psalms 89:9–10

The Lord rules over all parts of the created order, including evil. • You scattered your enemies: The Lord will crush ([Luke 1:51](#)) evil powers that oppose him ([Ps 2:1–3](#)). • with your mighty arm: This phrase represents God's strength ([89:13](#)).

Psalms 89:9–13

In this hymn, the psalmist celebrates God's comprehensive and powerful sovereignty over nature.

Psalms 89:12

Mount Tabor was in northern Israel. Mount Hermon formed the extreme northern border of the nation.

Psalms 89:14–18

God rules wisely over creation. The qualities of righteousness, justice, and faithfulness fit the profile of a wise ruler. The happy people who live under his rule enjoy his protection.

Psalms 89:15–16

Those who are wise worship God, walk in his light, rejoice in their relationship with him, and exult in his character.

Psalms 89:17–18

The Lord protects his people with the same power by which he established the created order.

Psalms 89:19–37

The Lord chose David as his son and as king of Israel (see [2:4–6](#); [2 Sam 7:8–16](#)) to provide protection for his people.

Psalms 89:20

I have anointed him: This is the verb from which *anointed one* (Hebrew *mashiakh*, “messiah”) is derived.

Psalms 89:26–29

The Lord adopted David as his son, appointed him as his commander over the nations, and promised to support him forever. Verse 26 recalls a verse from David's song of praise ([2 Sam 22:47](#)).

Psalms 89:27

David would be the most eminent of earthly kings. The Hebrew word translated mightiest is the same as the designation for God as “Most High” (*‘elyon*).

Psalms 89:29

The Lord writes his faithfulness in heaven, on the canvas of his universe (see [89:2](#)). He records his commitment to the dynasty of David in the same way.

Psalms 89:30–37

The Lord disciplines but does not reject his erring children. He foresees violation of trust and subsequent punishment, but he commits himself to uphold the covenant. His fidelity to David corresponds to his faithfulness to the created order.

Psalms 89:35

holiness: The Lord is wholly distinct from the created order ([22:3](#)); his character is totally pure. He does as he pleases ([115:3](#)), and he chooses to be faithful ([89:1](#); [115:1](#)); therefore, he cannot lie.

Psalms 89:38

You are angry: The harshness of God's wrath perplexes the psalmist.

Psalms 89:40

broken down the walls: The Lord's people are completely vulnerable.

Psalms 89:42

Although the Lord promised to strengthen David, he secretly strengthened David's enemies.

Psalms 89:46–47

The psalmist wonders if he will live to see the end of the Lord's anger. Our lifetimes are short, like a day in the Lord's sight ([90:4](#), [10](#)).

Psalms 89:50

The phrase your servants refers to the community loyal to the Lord.

Psalms 89:52

This doxology concludes all of Book Three ([Pss 73–89](#)); it is not intended to be read as part of [Ps 89](#). It stands in stark contrast to the anguish and questioning of [Ps 89](#). Cp. [41:13](#); [106:48](#).

Psalms 90:1

led God's people from slavery in Egypt to Mount Sinai, where he received the law and established God's covenant with Israel. • the man of God: Moses enjoyed a special relationship with God ([Deut 33:1](#)).

Psalms 90:1–2

The Lord becomes the home of the godly; he has provided shelter for countless generations. The word translated *home* is not used frequently in the Psalter. It describes a place of safety where the Lord meets his needy people and cares for them ([68:5](#); [71:3](#)).

Psalms 90:1–17

Although the Lord's people have made their home in him for generations, their sin widens the gap between them and their infinite Lord. The Lord's wrath against a person's sin might last a lifetime and yet be only a taste of his displeasure with sin. This lamentable situation calls the community to

seek the Lord's light. Taking the first step means seeking restoration with the Lord on the basis of his compassion and love ([90:13–14](#)). He alone makes his servants glad and blesses their future generations ([90:16–17](#)).

Psalms 90:2

The Lord is the eternal God. • The Lord gave birth to the earth by creating it.

Psalms 90:3–6

Unlike God, humans are mortal and transitory.

Psalms 90:7–10

Sinners cannot escape God's wrath because the Lord sees their sins. Their fleeting lives are filled with afflictions.

Psalms 90:9–10

A groan of sorrow ([Ezek 2:10](#)) sums up a life spent in facing the consequences of sin. • Humans cause trouble (see [Ps 10:6](#)) and receive pain in return.

Psalms 90:11–12

In the search for wisdom, no one can comprehend the Lord (see [Isa 40:13](#)). The appropriate human response to the Lord is godly fear (see [Ps 60:4](#)). The Lord alone can teach humans to follow the path of wisdom ([25:4–6](#)).

Psalms 90:13

The phrase your servants refers to the community of those loyal to the Lord.

Psalms 90:13–17

The psalmist prays for the Lord's favor and restoration.

Psalms 90:15

The psalmist calls upon the Lord to give the people gladness to replace their mourning (see [92:4-5](#)).

Psalms 90:16

The children represent future generations in contrast to the generations past ([90:1](#)).

Psalms 90:17

Humans waste their efforts unless the Lord makes them successful ([44:3](#)).

Psalms 91:1

The Most High is an ancient title that expresses the Lord's exalted status as the ruler and protector of the godly (see [Gen 14:19](#)).

Psalms 91:1-2

The Lord is an ancient shelter (see [90:1](#)), open to those who seek refuge in him.

Psalms 91:1-16

This wisdom psalm expresses confidence in the Almighty God, who provides a shelter for those who take refuge in him. They receive redemption, life, and glory from the Lord, who loves and cares for those who seek him.

Psalms 91:3

God protects the godly from deadly disease and even a destructive word.

Psalms 91:3-4

The psalmist invites the godly to trust in the Lord and find protection in him.

Psalms 91:4

The armor might refer to a body shield, while protection refers to a small shield worn on the arm.

Psalms 91:5-8

The godly should not be afraid, because the Lord watches over them. These promises do not guarantee an escape from trouble, but they create an expectation of the Lord's goodness.

Psalms 91:6

The reference to disease represents any kind of affliction.

Psalms 91:9-13

The poet again invites the godly to seek refuge in the Lord and enjoy the benefits of divine protection.

Psalms 91:11

he will order his angels: Satan cited these words when he tempted Jesus ([Matt 4:6](#); [Luke 4:10-11](#)), but God makes this promise for those who obey him ([Ps 91:14](#)), not for those who arrogantly test him ([Matt 4:4](#), [7](#)).

Psalms 91:14

Those who love the Lord will obey him ([Deut 30:20](#); [1 Jn 5:3](#)) and seek his protection ([Pss 91:1](#); [145:18](#)).

Psalms 91:14-16

The godly can trust the Lord's protection and provision.

Psalms 91:15

The Lord promises to answer the prayers of his people. • The Psalter often speaks of people

honoring the Lord ([50:15](#)); here, God promises to honor the godly who risk everything for his sake ([62:7](#); [71:21](#); [84:11](#)).

Psalms 91:16

A long life on earth represents just a small part of the Lord's goodness and eternal friendship ([23:6](#)).

Psalms 92:1

Jewish tradition assigned one psalm to each day of the week: Sunday ([Ps 24](#)), Monday ([Ps 48](#)), Tuesday ([Ps 82](#)), Wednesday ([Ps 94](#)), Thursday ([Ps 81](#)), Friday ([Ps 93](#)), and the Sabbath ([Ps 92](#)). This is the only psalm that indicates this use in its title.

Psalms 92:1-3

The psalmist offers praise and thanksgiving for God's unfailing love and faithfulness.

Psalms 92:1-15

Thanksgiving and praise open this psalm. The Lord—the Most High—is faithful and just in discerning between the godly and the wicked. The godly will enjoy a glorious, vigorous future, while the wicked will perish. The wise see and understand the Lord's works as they reveal his justice ([92:6-7](#), [11](#), [15](#)). The wicked, like grass, are quickly destroyed ([92:7-10](#)).

Psalms 92:4-5

The Lord acts and the psalmist responds in praise ([92:4](#)). God's actions spring from his thoughts ([92:5](#)).

Psalms 92:4-7

Fools perish because they do not understand the Lord's marvelous works and eternal plans.

Psalms 92:5-6

The Lord's thoughts do not make sense to the simpleton or the fool, the immoral person who desires no wisdom ([Prov 1:22](#); [10:23](#)).

Psalms 92:7

Even when the ungodly seem to grow luxuriantly ([73:3-5](#)), they have no future ([92:9](#); see [1:6](#); [90:5-6](#); [Isa 40:6-8](#)).

Psalms 92:8

The transcendent Lord stays above the world of human experience. From this exalted place, he rules and judges ([7:7](#)), celebrates his victories ([68:18](#); see [Ps 47](#)), comes to rescue the needy ([102:19](#)), brings an end to the wicked ([92:7-8](#)), and receives praise ([148:1](#)).

Psalms 92:8-10

The glory of the Lord provides the reason for the poet's renewed strength and glory, and for the imminent defeat of the enemy.

Psalms 92:10

as strong as a wild ox: The Lord allows the psalmist to share his exaltation ([92:8](#)), thus ensuring victory.

Psalms 92:11-15

The psalmist understands the Lord's mighty acts. He shares in the glory of the wise of heart.

Psalms 92:12

Carvings of palm trees ([1 Kgs 6:29](#), [32](#), [35](#); [7:36](#)) adorned the Temple, and builders made rich use of cedars ([1 Kgs 5:6](#)). The trees represent the godly, who are planted in the very courts of the Temple.

Psalms 92:13

The Temple area consisted of the Lord's own house and the courts that surrounded it.

Psalms 92:15

There is no evil in him! The Lord is consistently just; he rightly judges everyone (see [Zeph 3:5](#)).

Psalms 93:1

robed in majesty: The Lord stands victorious both before and after battle (see [45:3](#)).

Psalms 93:1-5

The everlasting Lord gloriously establishes his kingship (cp. [Pss 47, 99-100](#)).

Psalms 93:1-100.5

These psalms challenge the doubts created by the Exile (see [Ps 89](#)) and answer the questions asked in [90:11, 13](#). The Lord has established a kingdom ([Ps 93](#)) that is characterized by the punishment of the wicked ([Ps 94](#)), reverent obedience among his people ([Ps 95](#)), justice for the poor ([Ps 96](#)), celebration in Zion ([Ps 97](#)), salvation for Israel ([Ps 98](#)), holiness ([Ps 99](#)), and praise ([Ps 100](#)).

Psalms 93:3-4

God's victory over natural chaos gives the psalmist confidence that the Lord will also defeat his present enemies (cp. [Jer 46:8; 47:2](#)).

Psalms 93:5

Through his stable rule and royal laws, the Lord orders the world. • Your reign (literally *your house*): The *house* from which God reigns might be the Lord's heavenly palace or the earthly Temple.

Psalms 94:1-7

After the community falls victim to the wicked ([94:5-7](#)), they pray that the Lord will render justice (see [7:11; 9:12](#)).

Psalms 94:1-23

This plea for the Lord's justice includes both communal and individual expressions of lament ([94:1-7, 16-23](#)). The psalmist gives voice to the pain and suffering caused by the wicked, but he also depicts the comfort and stability of the Lord's protection. He calls on the Lord to avenge the needy against the arrogant and foolish, he rebukes such people for their folly ([94:8-11](#)), and he pronounces a blessing on the wise ([94:12-15](#)).

Psalms 94:2

Just as the Lord's enemies rise up against him and his people ([3:7; 93:3](#)), he must arise and make retribution against the enemy (see [79:12; Isa 65:6](#)).

Psalms 94:6

widows . . . foreigners . . . orphans: The Lord's law protects needy people ([Deut 24:17; 27:19](#)), but they remain vulnerable in society.

Psalms 94:7

The wicked think that they can get away with their vile acts and speech, foolishly assuming that God isn't looking or doesn't care.

Psalms 94:8-11

The psalmist rebukes human folly.

Psalms 94:9

It is preposterous that those with ears and eyes would imagine their Creator to be deaf and blind.

Psalms 94:10

punishes: This word also carries the idea of “warns” ([2:10](#)), “disciplines” ([6:1](#); [94:12](#)), or “instructs” ([16:7](#)). The Lord disciplines his people to purify their character ([Prov 3:11-12](#); [Heb 12:6-11](#)). He punishes his enemies by giving them what they deserve ([Ps 1:6](#); [Rom 6:23](#)).

Psalms 94:11

While the Lord’s thoughts are deep, people’s thoughts are worthless (cp. [92:5](#); [1 Cor 3:20](#)).

Psalms 94:12-15

True to his nature, the Lord rewards those who live by his wise instruction and makes them happy according to his promises.

Psalms 94:13

God’s relief includes his comfort and rescue.

Psalms 94:14

Even when it seems that he has, the Lord will not reject his people.

Psalms 94:16

Only God has the power to stand up to the wicked (see [2:2](#)).

Psalms 94:16-23

The psalmist’s prayer resumes (see [94:1-7](#)) with a desperate cry for the Lord’s justice; it concludes with the hopeful expectation that evil will end.

Psalms 94:18-19

The psalmist’s experience of slipping contrasts with God’s promise to stand with him ([94:12-13](#); see [15:5](#); [93:1](#)).

Psalms 95:1-11

This call to worship urges the people to respond to the Lord, the Shepherd, and to follow him faithfully. The previous generation, who refused to obey, did not receive the blessings of the Promised Land.

Psalms 95:3

above all gods: The psalmist refutes idolatry and paganism ([96:4-6](#); [135:15-18](#); see also [Isa 46:5-7](#)).

Psalms 95:3-5

The Lord is the great King over the whole universe.

Psalms 95:4-5

The whole created order owes its existence to the sovereign Lord alone—not to various gods.

Psalms 95:6-7

The great King cares for his people as a shepherd cares for his flock ([Isa 40:11](#)). • The Lord our maker, the Creator of heaven and earth, also made a people for himself ([Isa 45:9-12](#); [51:12-16](#)).

Psalms 95:8

To harden your hearts means to be stubborn and resist the Lord’s grace (see [Num 20:2-13](#); see also [Matt 13:3-23](#); [John 12:37-43](#); [Eph 4:17-32](#); [Heb 3:6-19](#); [4:6-11](#)).

Psalms 95:8-11

If people want to enter into the Lord’s rest, they need to respond immediately (see [Heb 3:7-4:11](#)).

Psalms 95:9

Israel’s ancestors . . . saw the wonders of the Lord, but they foolishly did not try to grasp their significance (see [92:5-6](#)).

Psalms 95:11

The generation of Israel that wandered in the wilderness for forty years failed to enter the place of rest that Israel enjoyed after the conquest of the land ([1 Kgs 8:56](#); see [Deut 12:9](#)). The Lord promised them the land and gave it to them ([Isa 28:12](#)), but they did not obey him ([Isa 28:1](#)). The warning reminds every generation of the need to obey in faith. • The rest that God provides includes peace, provision, and protection ([Ps 132:14–18](#)). The author of Hebrews challenged a new generation to enter the rest provided by Jesus Christ ([Heb 3:7–4:13](#)).

Psalms 96:1

Three psalms open with the exhortation to sing a new song ([Pss 96, 98, 149](#)); the song celebrates the Lord's universal kingship (see [33:3](#)).

Psalms 96:1–13

This psalm establishes the Lord's universal kingship (see [Ps 93](#)) and prepares for the coming of the Lord to bring justice and righteousness into the world. The psalmist invites everyone to worship the Lord ([96:1–3](#)), the glorious Creator of all the earth ([96:4–6](#)), because worship is due to him alone ([96:7–9](#)). The universe joins in praise as the righteous Judge establishes a new order ([96:10–13](#)). • This psalm (along with [105:1–15](#); [106:1, 47–48](#)) is included in David's song of praise recorded in [1 Chr 16:1–43](#).

Psalms 96:4

Great is the Lord! . . . most worthy of praise: With this refrain, the poet exalts the Lord over all the gods ([95:3](#)) and nations ([99:2](#)). He inspires awe more than anyone or anything else ([76:7, 12](#); [89:7, 99:3, 111:9](#)). He is beyond human possession or comprehension. The story of what he does to redeem his people causes them to praise him.

Psalms 96:4–6

The gods of the nations are as nothing before the glorious and majestic Creator of the earth.

Psalms 96:5

The Lord made the heavens, an even greater task than creating the earth. The idols, made by human hands ([115:4](#)), created nothing.

Psalms 96:6

Honor and majesty: The Lord is glorious ([96:6](#); [104:1](#); [148:13](#)), and so are his works in nature ([8:1](#)) and in redemption ([111:3](#); [145:5](#)).

Psalms 96:7

nations of the world (literally *families of the nations*): Families and clans represent subdivisions of the nations (see [Gen 12:3](#)). • The nations must respond to the Lord's glory ([Pss 8:1](#); [19:1–4](#); [24:7](#)).

Psalms 96:8

The courts of God's sanctuary were usually off-limits to non-Jewish people. In this psalm the nations of the world—the non-Jews—are invited in ([65:4](#); [84:2, 10](#); [100:4](#); [116:19](#); [135:2](#); [Isa 1:12](#)).

Psalms 96:9

Worshippers should tremble in awe ([96:4](#); see [18:7–15](#); [97:4](#)) at the splendor of the Lord's majesty and holiness ([Heb 12:25](#)).

Psalms 96:10

The Lord's coming means the end of injustice. He rules fairly ([9:8](#); [96:13](#); [98:9](#)) and inaugurates an era of harmony and order not experienced since Eden. • The Lord's reign over the world is founded on the strong pillars of "righteousness and justice" ([89:14](#)), so it cannot be shaken (cp. [11:3](#)).

Psalms 96:11–13

The psalmist exhorts the created order to respond with joy to the news of the Lord's coming. Cp. a similar theme in [98:7–9](#).

Psalms 96:12

All of nature will experience renewal in God's presence ([65:13](#); [72:6](#), [16](#); [Isa 44:23](#); [55:12](#); [Rom 8:21-22](#)).

Psalms 97:1

The farthest coastlands represent the most remote parts of the world.

Psalms 97:1-12

God is greatly exalted over the gods and over all the earth. Awe-inspiring phenomena accompany his coming. Even the created order is visibly affected and the wicked perish, but the people of Zion love his coming and rejoice.

Psalms 97:2-4

Dark clouds . . . Fire . . . lightning: This language shows that the Lord is coming in judgment.

Psalms 97:5-7

The created order stirs at the coming of its King. He alone deserves worship.

Psalms 97:6

As the Lord enters the world, the testimony of his righteousness resounds from above ([50:6](#)). • Every nation will view the open display of the Lord's glory (see [8:1](#); [19:1-4a](#); [24:7](#); [Isa 40:5](#)).

Psalms 97:7

At the Lord's coming, when every god must bow to him, those who worship other gods will face their own folly (see [95:3-5](#)).

Psalms 97:8-12

Jerusalem rejoices at the news of the Lord's coming, for he brings justice and rescues the upright of heart.

Psalms 97:11

The godly people of integrity (see [Prov 2:7](#), [21:3:32](#); [11:6](#), [11](#); [14:2](#)), whose hearts are right, maintain a relationship with the Lord and with others ([Pss 94:15](#); [125:4](#)). The wicked plan the downfall of the godly ([11:2](#)), but the Lord rescues them ([11:1](#); [36:10](#)). Then the sorrows of the godly turn to joy and praise ([32:11](#); [64:10](#); [111:1](#); [119:7](#)).

Psalms 98:1-9

This psalm celebrates the Lord's kingship. The Lord is Israel's true King, its champion and savior. His people sing a new song celebrating his victorious power and faithfulness to them. The Lord displays his righteous rule to all the nations throughout the earth, which will culminate in a worldwide kingdom of justice ([98:2](#), [9](#)). Consequently, all the earth must worship and rejoice together because the Lord is coming ([98:4-6](#)).

Psalms 98:2-3

The Lord makes known his righteousness and faithfulness (see also [Isa 52:10](#)).

Psalms 98:4-6

The psalmist invites the whole earth to worship the King (see [96:1](#)).

Psalms 98:6

The Temple musicians used trumpets to call people together for meetings (cp. [81:3](#)).

Psalms 98:7-9

The created order is personified as rejoicing at the coming of the righteous Judge (see [93:3-4](#); [96:11-13](#)).

Psalms 99:1

It is fitting to tremble and quake in response to the Lord's holiness (see [96:9](#)). • The throne between the cherubim refers to the cover of the Ark of the Covenant ([Exod 25:17-22](#)).

Psalms 99:1-5

The Lord is the holy and righteous King ([Isa 6:1-5](#)). Mount Zion, the location of the Lord's Temple, metaphorically stands as the highest point on earth ([Ps 113:4](#); [Isa 2:2](#); [6:1](#)). From this summit, the Great King ([Ps 47:2](#)) can see, rule over, and receive praise from all nations and peoples.

Psalms 99:1-9

The psalmist calls the nations to worship the Lord, the king of the earth who rules from Zion.

Psalms 99:4

The qualities of the Lord's rule include strength, justice, love, fairness, and righteousness (see [93:4](#); [97:2](#), [6-7](#), [12](#); [98:2-3](#), [9](#); [138:6](#)).

Psalms 99:6

Moses and Samuel were great models and leaders who had prayed on behalf of the Lord's people ([Exod 32:31-32](#); [1 Sam 12:23](#)).

Psalms 99:6-8

God showed favor by responding to his people in the past, while holding sinners accountable.

Psalms 99:7

The Lord spoke to Moses and Aaron from the pillar of cloud ([Exod 33:9](#); [Num 12:5-6](#)), and for a time, the people responded to the revelation.

Psalms 100:1-5

This psalm calls all nations to come to Jerusalem to worship the Lord and acknowledge his goodness to Israel.

Psalms 100:3

The Lord is the one who determines who his people are. • the sheep of his pasture: God will guide and protect his people ([23:1](#), [4](#)).

Psalms 100:4

Gates and courts were part of the Temple in Jerusalem.

Psalms 101:1-8

This hymn expresses a commitment to live with integrity and to avoid evil. Jesus meets this ideal.

Psalms 101:2

in my own home (literally *in my house*): This commitment to integrity might refer to private life at home. Some interpreters view *my house* as referring to the king's palace; the commitment would then refer to the policies of his administration. • Leading a life of integrity means choosing a wise lifestyle.

Psalms 101:4-5

The psalmist hates what the Lord hates ([Prov 6:16-19](#); see [Pss 5:5](#); [11:4-5](#)). • Perverse ideas come from corrupt human hearts (cp. [18:26](#)).

Psalms 101:6

The psalmist surrounds himself with people who are also committed to integrity ([101:2](#)).

Psalms 101:7-8

The psalmist commits himself to ridding his house and the city of the Lord—representing the entire kingdom—of all evil.

Psalms 102:1-2

The psalmist appeals to the Lord not to turn away (or *hide your face*). Israel experienced his turning his face away during their exile.

Psalms 102:1-28

A frail and afflicted human being prays for the Lord's compassion on Jerusalem and for his presence with its inhabitants.

Psalms 102:3

Smoke is an image of transitory life ([37:20](#); [68:2](#)). • The psalmist's bones represent his whole being (see [6:2](#); [34:19-22](#)).

Psalms 102:4

Like dried grass, the psalmist senses his life ebbing away.

Psalms 102:5

skin and bones: The psalmist has wasted away because of his anguish (see [102:9](#); [109:24](#)).

Psalms 102:6

The owl was associated with ruin and desolation ([Isa 34:11](#), [15](#)).

Psalms 102:7-8

The psalmist cannot sleep (see [63:6-8](#)). Like a bird on the roof, he feels isolated from both friends (see [88:8](#)) and enemies.

Psalms 102:10

The psalmist blames the Lord for his troubles.

Psalms 102:11

The psalmist's existence seems empty and transitory ([102:4](#); [109:23](#); [144:4](#)).

Psalms 102:12

forever . . . to every generation: The frailty of humans ([102:3-11](#)) contrasts with the permanence of the Lord.

Psalms 102:12-17

The topic changes from the psalmist's miseries to the Lord's glory. A vision of the Lord's compassionate kingship gives him confidence in Zion's future.

Psalms 102:13

Now is the time for the Lord to restore Jerusalem from exile (see [75:2](#); [Jer 29:10](#); [Dan 9:1-19](#)).

Psalms 102:15-16

When the Lord arises ([102:13](#)), the nations will tremble with fear because they will see his glory (see [8:1](#); [19:1-4a](#); [24:7](#)). The rebuilding of Zion and the Temple portray God's glory and fulfill this promise. An even greater fulfillment will come with the New Jerusalem ([Rev 21](#)).

Psalms 102:17

The people of Israel were destitute (or *naked*) during the Exile.

Psalms 102:18

Let this be recorded: The written record stands as a memorial to the Lord's goodness.

Psalms 102:18–22

The Lord will have mercy; Jews and Gentiles alike will worship him.

Psalms 102:19

The heavenly sanctuary refers to God's holy place on high (see [92:8–10](#)).

Psalms 102:22

The multitudes—both Jews and Gentiles—will join in the worship of the Lord (see [96:7, 9](#); [106:48](#); [Isa 2:2–4](#); [43:10–13](#); [57:15](#); [60:3–7](#)).

Psalms 102:23–28

Although the psalmist suffers in the present, he bases his hope for the future on the Lord's past faithfulness.

Psalms 102:24

The psalmist draws a contrast between his days ([102:23](#)) and God's years (cp. [90:4](#)).

Psalms 102:25–27

In contrast with the permanence of the Creator, the created order will wear out like a piece of clothing (see [Isa 40:28](#)). • The writer to the Hebrews describes this passage as having been addressed to Jesus, the Son ([Heb 1:10–12](#)).

Psalms 102:28

The Lord's presence provides the basis for the security and happiness of his people ([23:6](#)).

Psalms 103:1–2

Let all that I am praise the Lord: [Pss 103](#) and [104](#) each open and close with this commitment ([103:1–2, 22](#); [104:1, 35](#); see also [146:1](#)).

Psalms 103:1–6

The psalmist offers praise for the Lord's goodness.

Psalms 103:1–22

This psalm celebrates the Lord's perfection, compassion, forgiveness, and goodness.

Psalms 103:7–8

The Lord revealed himself to Moses in distinctive ways that ensured his relationship with his people (see [Exod 34:6–7](#); [Num 14:18](#)).

Psalms 103:9

If the Lord were to constantly accuse or remain angry forever, no one would be left (see [Isa 54:7–8](#); [57:16](#)).

Psalms 103:11–12

The Lord's love and forgiveness are infinite and complete.

Psalms 103:13

The Lord is like a father to his children: This analogy forms the basis for Jesus' teaching about God's fatherhood (see [Matt 5:43–48](#); [6:1](#); [10:19–20](#); [12:50](#); [Luke 6:36](#); [12:29–32](#); [John 8:31–59](#); [15:1–8](#); see also [2 Sam 7:14](#); [Jer 3:19](#); [31:9](#); [Mal 1:6](#); [2 Cor 6:16–18](#)).

Psalms 103:14–16

The Lord compassionately cares for frail humans (see [37:2](#); [90:5](#); [92:7](#); [102:4](#); [Isa 40:6–8](#)).

Psalms 103:17–19

the love of the Lord remains forever: The Lord's kingdom is everlasting, so he commits himself to his people across many generations.

Psalms 103:18

To obey God means to be faithful and loyal to him.

Psalms 103:20–21

The psalmist exhorts the Lord's angels, his servants and messengers, to praise the Lord.

Psalms 103:22

God's kingdom extends over all things, so all things are called to praise the Lord. • The concluding phrase takes us back to [103:1–2](#).

Psalms 104:1

Let all that I am praise the Lord: [Pss 103](#) and [104](#) each open and close with this commitment to praise ([103:1–2](#), [22](#); [104:1](#), [35](#)). • how great you are! This acclamation expresses praise for rescue (see also [35:27](#); [40:16](#); [70:4](#)).

Psalms 104:1–35

This creation hymn (see also [Pss 8](#), [33](#), [145](#)) exalts God's goodness and majesty. The psalmist reflects on the present world, the original creation, and a future new creation. He sees both creations as marvelously and wisely made (cp. [139:14](#)), as the work of the Lord's Spirit ([104:30](#); [Gen 1:2](#); [2 Cor 3:6](#)).

Psalms 104:2–4

The psalmist interacts with two of the days of creation (see [Gen 1:1–8](#)), when God created the heavens and light.

Psalms 104:3

This poetic portrayal envisions the clouds as beams that support heaven.

Psalms 104:4

Wind and lightning are seen as divine messengers. The Lord uses weather phenomena as he desires ([77:17–18](#); [78:26](#); [135:7](#); [148:5–6](#)). • The psalmist interacts with day three of creation ([Gen 1:9–13](#)). The Lord is master of water and earth.

Psalms 104:6

At first, water covered the earth.

Psalms 104:7

The Lord created dry ground on day three of creation ([Gen 1:9–13](#)).

Psalms 104:8

The earth originates in God's will.

Psalms 104:9

The Lord set a firm boundary for the seas to protect the land. God's sovereignty over sea and land was an argument against the existence of Baal, whom the Canaanites celebrated as victorious over the waters (see [Ps 29](#)).

Psalms 104:9–10

The Lord reigns over all bodies of water, including those on land. He replaced chaotic waters with order and abundance, and the earth became a splendid place for animals and humans, with water refreshing the ground, the birds, and the animals.

Psalms 104:11–18

The psalmist celebrates animal, plant, and human life, as well as the Lord's abundant provision for all of it ([Gen 1:9–30](#)).

Psalms 104:14

people to use: People are the managers of the created order, and they receive nourishment from the work of their hands.

Psalms 104:15

While both can be misused (cp. [Prov 21:17](#)), the Lord provides wine and olive oil as gifts to enhance life. Life is sustained by basic food, represented by bread.

Psalms 104:17–18

The storks migrated from northern Europe and resided in Palestine during the winter. • hyraxes: These animals are about the size of a rabbit and live in rocky places.

Psalms 104:19

the moon to mark the seasons: Ancient Israel based its calendar on the cycles of the moon. • the sun knows when to set: This is a poetic description from the perspective of normal observation. The sun goes down at a regular time every evening.

Psalms 104:19–23

The psalmist rejoices in the order of night and day, marking day four of creation ([Gen 1:14–19](#)). This cycle gives all creatures an opportunity to live.

Psalms 104:20–23

Cycles of darkness and dawn mark the days on earth.

Psalms 104:24–26

The Lord's works testify to his wisdom. All parts fit together—land and sea, night and day, land creatures and sea creatures. The Lord's wisdom makes life orderly and wonderful.

Psalms 104:25

The ocean, . . . teeming with life of every kind (see [Gen 1:20–21](#)), exemplifies the Lord's creative activities.

Psalms 104:26

ships sailing: Commercial vessels engaged in sea trade were one of the wonders of the ancient Near East (see [Isa 2:16](#); [23:1](#), [3](#)). • Leviathan: The psalmist says that this feared creature is nothing but the Lord's pet.

Psalms 104:27–30

All life depends on the gracious sustenance of the Lord of life and death (cp. [Matt 6:11](#)).

Psalms 104:29–30

When you give them your breath: Life on earth is only possible as the Lord's gift, symbolized by his breath (Hebrew ruakh, "breath, wind, spirit"). The Lord's Spirit is the agent of renewal ([Isa 32:15–20](#)).

Psalms 104:31

The Lord reveals his presence in the created order (see [8:1](#); [19:1–4](#); [24:7](#)) and takes pleasure in his new creation (see [Isa 65:19](#)).

Psalms 104:31–35

The psalmist moves from describing the known creation to anticipating the new creation, when the Lord will renew the created order into a world without sinners.

Psalms 104:32

The trembling earth and the smoking mountains represent the Lord's coming in judgment against sinners and salvation for his faithful people (see [18:7–15](#)).

Psalms 104:35

The Lord will remove all forms of evil that defile his creation. • The concluding phrase takes us back to [104:1](#) (see also [103:1-2](#), [22](#); [146:1](#)).

Psalms 105:1-5

The poet begins with the exhortation Give thanks (see also [106:1](#); [107:1](#); [118:1](#); [136:1](#)). The other psalms continue with the refrain “for he is good!” The rest of [Ps 105](#) tells of God’s goodness.

Psalms 105:1-45

This hymn praises the Lord’s faithfulness to Abraham and his descendants in all their journeys—from Ur to Canaan ([105:12](#)), to Egypt ([105:17](#), [23](#)), through the wilderness ([105:37](#), [41](#)), and back to Canaan ([105:44](#)). All of this fulfilled the Lord’s promise to Abraham ([105:9](#), [42](#)), which was the basis for Israel’s very existence. Joseph, whose suffering was changed into glory, is a paradigm of encouragement for Israel ([105:16-25](#)). • [Psalm 105:1-15](#) (along with [96](#); [106:1](#), [47-48](#)) is included in David’s song of praise recorded in [1 Chr 16](#).

Psalms 105:6-11

The story of Israel is based on the Lord’s commitment to Abraham. Even when a question arises about the future of God’s covenant with David ([Ps 89](#)), God’s covenant with Abraham stands, as does the spiritual bond between God and Israel, Abraham’s descendants.

Psalms 105:8

The covenant is the Lord’s irrevocable oath to be the Father of Abraham and his descendants (see [Gen 12:1-9](#); [15:1-21](#)).

Psalms 105:11

God promised the land of Canaan to Abraham’s descendants as their special possession, where they could live as God’s people ([105:44-45](#); [Gen 12:7](#); [15:7-21](#)).

Psalms 105:12-15

The Lord protected Israel’s patriarchs.

Psalms 105:15

Abraham was one of the nation’s prophets ([Gen 20:7](#)).

Psalms 105:16-22

These verses tell the story of Joseph (see [Gen 37-41](#)).

Psalms 105:19

tested Joseph’s character: See [Gen 39:6-12](#).

Psalms 105:23

Egypt (Hebrew mitsrayim) is called the land of Ham.

Psalms 105:23-25

These verses tell the story of Israel’s affliction in Egypt (see [Exod 1:1-14](#)).

Psalms 105:26-36

The psalmist recounts the story of Moses and the plagues in Egypt ([Exod 7:20-12:30](#)).

Psalms 105:37

not one . . . stumbled: The Lord protected all of his people (cp. [9:3](#)).

Psalms 105:37-45

The Exodus and the conquest of Canaan fulfilled God’s promise to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob ([105:9-10](#)). Unlike [Ps 78](#), the poet recites the

Lord's goodness without commenting on Israel's history of rebellion (cp. [Ps 106](#)).

Psalms 105:39

The Lord's presence was as evident to all as a fire in the darkness ([Exod 13:22](#)).

Psalms 105:42–45

The story of redemption is also the story of the Lord's faithfulness.

Psalms 105:44

Canaan was a land of pagan nations (see [111:6](#)). The psalmist might also be reflecting on God's promise to Abraham ([Gen 24:60](#)) regarding the lands given to Isaac ([Gen 26:3](#)).

Psalms 105:45

The Lord planned for Israel to testify about him by obeying him; Israel was to be his model people.

Psalms 106:1

Praise the Lord! This refrain (Hebrew halleluyah) characterizes four small subgroups in the psalms: [104–106](#), [111–113](#), [115–117](#), [146–150](#).

Psalms 106:1–48

The Israelite community in exile confessed the Lord's goodness and justice and their own historic sinfulness. From the humble state of exile, they pleaded for redemption and restoration, asking to be gathered back from all the places the Lord had scattered them in his wrath. The psalm does not end in despair but with the memory of the Lord's former mercy and the hope that his mercy will be renewed ([106:44–48](#)). Israel failed, but the Lord is constant. • Verses 1, [47–48](#) (along with [Pss 96; 105:1–15](#)) are included in David's song of praise recorded in [1 Chr 16:1–43](#).

Psalms 106:2–3

Wise people who practice justice and righteousness receive encouragement to proclaim the Lord's great acts.

Psalms 106:4–5

The poet prays individually for the Lord's favor before leading the community confession that follows.

Psalms 106:6

The story of Israel's redemption encompasses their sinful response from the days of the ancestors to the present ([106:43](#)). The themes of sin and divine wrath both open and close Book Four ([90:1–9; 106:6, 23, 43](#)).

Psalms 106:6–13

The community joins together to confess their sins and their ancestors' many acts of unbelief.

Psalms 106:9

Red Sea: See [Exod 14:15–31](#).

Psalms 106:13

They wouldn't wait: God's impatient people did not trust him to work according to his will (e.g., see [Exod 15:24; 16:2–3; 17:1–3; Num 14:26–45; 21:4–9](#)).

Psalms 106:15

he sent a plague: See [Exod 32:35; Num 11:33](#).

Psalms 106:16–18

The people became jealous because they presumed to have the same privileges as God's appointed priests (see [Num 16:1–35](#)). • the earth opened up: See [Num 16:28–33](#).

Psalms 106:19–23

they bowed before an image: The people forgot their Savior and committed the sin of idolatry (see [Exod 32:1–6](#)).

Psalms 106:22

The land of Ham here means Egypt ([106:21](#)).

Psalms 106:24–25

The people disobeyed God's command when they refused to enter the pleasant land (the Promised Land; see [Jer 3:19](#)). • they wouldn't believe his promise: See [Num 13:25–14:12](#).

Psalms 106:26–27

God's judgment when Israel refused to obey was death and exile ([Num 14:26–30](#)). The occasion for these severe judgments seems to have been disobeying God's word ([Ps 106:24–25](#)) and provoking the Lord's wrath ([106:28–46](#)).

Psalms 106:28

the worship of Baal at Peor: See [Num 25:3](#); [Deut 4:3](#).

Psalms 106:28–39

Israel's idolatry outside of the land came with them into the land. Their nature did not change; they continued to provoke the Lord to anger by their actions.

Psalms 106:30–33

Phinehas, who executed a flagrantly apostate Israelite man ([Num 25:3–8](#)), is an even better model of a righteous man than Moses, who failed at Meribah ([Num 20:11–13](#)).

Psalms 106:34

Israel continued to disobey the word of the Lord while living in the Promised Land. Rather than destroying the nations, Israel accepted them and their ways (see [Judg 2:1–3](#), [11–15](#); [3:5–6](#)).

Psalms 106:37

Pagan gods were demons (see [Deut 32:17](#)).

Psalms 106:39

Idolatry, like adultery, defiles God's people (see [Lev 18:24](#); [Hos 5:3](#)).

Psalms 106:40

God abhorred Israel's sin, as he does all sin.

Psalms 106:40–46

The psalmist returns to the Babylonian exile ([106:26–27](#)). The Lord judged Israel severely, but he also restrained his wrath, remembering the covenant he had made with Abraham.

Psalms 106:43–44

When Israel was finally destroyed, the destruction was not complete. The Lord pitied them, so he left a remnant.

Psalms 106:45

He remembered . . . and relented: Unlike Israel, the Lord is faithful to his covenant ([105:8](#)).

Psalms 106:46

As harsh as the Exile was, the Lord still protected his people (see [2 Kgs 25:27–29](#)).

Psalms 106:47

Gather us back: The community prays for restoration from exile (see [102:19–22](#); [107:3](#); see also [Isa 11:12](#); [40:11](#); [43:5](#); [54:7](#); [56:8](#); [66:18](#)).

Psalms 106:48

This doxology concludes Book Four (cp. [41:13](#); [89:52](#)). • from everlasting to everlasting! The reference to God's eternal nature links to the opening of Book Four ([90:1–2](#)). • Let all the people say, "Amen!": The Hebrew word 'amen means "It is true." The godly accept the Lord's will in exile and his promise to be their God.

Psalms 107:1–43

This psalm is a hymn of praise to God the Redeemer. After an introduction exhorting the redeemed to praise God for his goodness ([107:1–3](#)), the psalmist brings together four case studies of people whom the Lord redeemed from adversity ([107:4–32](#)). He then sums up the Lord's sovereignty ([107:33–42](#)) and concludes with an invitation to discern God's unfailing love in all areas of life ([107:43](#)).

Psalms 107:2

The redeemed might be all who came out of exile.

Psalms 107:3

exiles: People came from all nations where the people of Israel and Judah had been scattered.

Psalms 107:4–9

Those who were lost in the wilderness thank God for his rescue. The wilderness might be a metaphor for leaving the path of wisdom ([1:1](#); [Prov 4:10–15](#)).

Psalms 107:6

The psalmist does not specify the occasion of his trouble and distress. The generic nature of the

adversity permits readers in a variety of circumstances to identify with the laments.

Psalms 107:7–8

God led them like a shepherd (see [23:1](#)). • Verse 8 is a refrain that is repeated in [107:15](#), [21](#), [31](#).

Psalms 107:10–16

The psalmist calls for thanksgiving and praise from people in despair over the consequences of their rebellion.

Psalms 107:11

God's counsel includes his instruction and will.

Psalms 107:12

Exhausted by their hard labor ([Lam 5:13](#)), the people fell. While this might be expected of the wicked ([Pss 9:3](#); [27:2](#)), it was unlike the Israelites' flight from Egypt ([105:37](#)).

Psalms 107:17–22

Fools who received what they deserved but were rescued from death offer thanksgiving to the Lord.

Psalms 107:20

The Lord creates ([Gen 1:3](#)) and sustains the universe ([Heb 1:3](#)) simply by speaking ([Ps 147:18](#)); when he speaks, people are also healed ([Matt 8:8](#)).

Psalms 107:23–32

Sailors give thanks to the Lord when he saves them from the chaos and peril of the sea.

Psalms 107:25–29

The same God who speaks and brings about the sailors' distress can also calm the storm with just a word (cp. [Jon 1:4](#); [Matt 8:26](#)).

Psalms 107:32

This call for public praise expands the refrains in [107:21–22](#) and [107:31](#).

Psalms 107:33–35

The Lord can choose to make the earth fertile or barren ([74:15](#); [Isa 35:6–7](#)).

Psalms 107:33–42

These two sections ([107:33–38](#), [39–42](#)) expand the theme of the Lord's sovereignty over things that humans cannot control.

Psalms 107:38

God's presence can be seen in the abundance of his people's families and herds ([127:3](#); [133:3](#); cp. [109:8](#)).

Psalms 107:39

People often become impoverished when their rulers practice oppression.

Psalms 107:40

In his contempt for human rulers, the Lord rectifies their corruption on earth.

Psalms 107:41

The large families of the poor are evidence of God's blessing.

Psalms 107:42–43

Justice prevails in God's world ([1:6](#)), and Israel's history demonstrates God's faithful love.

Psalms 108:1–13

This psalm combines two excerpts from David's other psalms (cp. [57:5](#), [7–11](#); [60:5–12](#)).

Psalms 109:1

The psalmist sees no evidence that God cares (see [28:1](#)).

Psalms 109:1–31

The psalmist begins this lament with a general charge against his accusers: They do evil in return for good ([109:1–5](#)). At the end of the psalm, he turns to the Lord in prayer, asking for his protection ([109:21–25](#)) and vengeance ([109:26–31](#)).

Psalms 109:4–5

The psalmist's acts of kindness and godliness (see [35:12–14](#)) have only met with stubborn opposition and expressions of hatred.

Psalms 109:6–19

The NLT translates these verses as the words of the psalmist's accusers; Hebrew lacks They say, which makes it unclear who is speaking.

Psalms 109:8

The wicked person apparently held a position of leadership. Peter referred to this psalm in regard to Judas Iscariot ([Acts 1:20–26](#)).

Psalms 109:8–11

Family members of those guilty of capital crimes often died with the perpetrator ([Num 16:1–33](#);

[Josh 7:1-25](#)) or had their property confiscated ([1 Kgs 21:13-16](#)).

Psalms 109:13

If one's family name was blotted out, it meant there was no offspring to carry on the family name or remember its history (see [Prov 10:7](#)).

Psalms 109:14

Children inherit the sinful nature of their parents ([51:5](#); [Exod 20:5](#); [Eph 2:3](#)). The speaker wants the Lord to punish the perpetrator for the guilt of family members who went before him (cp. [Matt 23:35-36](#)).

Psalms 109:16

The defendant committed capital crimes and did not exercise even basic decency.

Psalms 109:18

Cursing is the accused person's whole way of life.

Psalms 109:20

The psalmist appeals to the principle of retribution (see [94:23](#)).

Psalms 109:21

The Lord's reputation is at stake. If the wicked triumph, others could think that the Lord is also wicked and be drawn to that wickedness ([1:1](#)).

Psalms 109:21-25

Vulnerable and miserable, the psalmist appeals to his Lord for help. The accusations have killed his inner spirit and even his physical stamina.

Psalms 109:23

A shadow at dusk suggests a transitory, empty existence ([102:11](#); [144:4](#)); a single locust could easily be brushed off one's clothing.

Psalms 109:26-31

These verses form a prayer for God's presence and for vindication. The psalmist wants everyone to see that he is vindicated by the Lord, not by any human agent.

Psalms 109:28

The Lord's servant demonstrates loyalty and obedience.

Psalms 109:29

The psalmist had been accused of being clothed with curses ([109:18](#)); now he asks that his accusers be clothed with disgrace and humiliation.

Psalms 110:1

The king of Israel had the great privilege of being the Lord's adopted son ([Ps 2](#); [1 Chr 22:10](#)), but he fell ([Ps 89](#)). This decree restores and heightens his position. • The Lord: Hebrew *Yahweh*, the name of God (see [Exod 3:6-14](#); [6:2-8](#); [20:2](#)). • my Lord (Hebrew 'adoni) means "my master" or "my superior." The psalmist viewed God's messianic ruler as his superior. The New Testament frequently cites this psalm to validate Jesus' claim to be the Messiah ([Matt 22:44-45](#); [Mark 12:36-37](#); [Luke 20:42-44](#); [Acts 2:34-35](#); [Heb 1:13](#)). • The Lord's right hand represents his authority, strength, presence, and benefits. The Lord chose the descendant of David and raised him up to be close to him ([Ps 80:17](#)). Jesus claimed this position for himself ([Matt 26:64](#); [Mark 14:62](#); [16:19](#); [Luke 22:69](#)), and the apostles announced that Jesus, having ascended to heaven, sits at the right hand of the Father ([Acts 2:33](#); [5:31](#); [7:55-56](#); [Rom 8:34](#); [Eph 1:20](#); [Col 3:1](#); [Heb 1:3](#); [8:1](#); [10:12](#); [12:2](#)). • Ancient Near Eastern kings were sometimes portrayed as placing their feet on the backs of their conquered enemies as on a footstool (see [Heb 10:12-13](#)).

Psalms 110:1-7

Jesus and the apostles cite this psalm to explain Jesus' unique ministry and status as the Messiah ([Matt 22:43-45](#); [Acts 2:32-36](#)). It reaffirms God's covenant with David and gives hope for the future (see [2 Sam 7:8-16](#)).

Psalms 110:2-3

The kingdom will expand and increase, beginning from Jerusalem, until all enemies are conquered.

Psalms 110:4

The Lord had made an unbreakable oath and covenant, so his apparent rejection of David's dynasty ([89:38](#)) in the Exile had led to a crisis. The placement of [Ps 110](#) in Book Five reaffirms the future of the dynasty: David's descendant must conform to God's standard of integrity ([Ps 101](#)). His ministry will be transformed as he serves under God's kingship ([Pss 93-100](#)). • You are a priest forever: The role of God's messianic ruler changes. The priestly kingship of David and his descendants extended to serving as patrons of the Temple. David had the Ark brought to Jerusalem ([2 Sam 6:15](#)) and arranged for the Temple service ([1 Chr 6:31-48](#); [15:11-26](#); [16:4-42](#); [23:4-32](#); [25:1](#)). Solomon supervised the Temple construction ([1 Kgs 5:1-7:51](#)). Even so, Israel's kingship was separate from its priesthood. In the messianic kingdom, the king would also minister as priest, as Melchizedek, king of Salem ([Gen 14:18](#)), had done. The New Testament develops the ministry of Jesus Christ as a fulfillment of this new order (see [Heb 5:6-10](#); [6:20-7:25](#)).

Psalms 110:5-6

at your right hand: This position brings help and protection (see [16:7-8](#); [108:13](#)). • The Lord will strike down rebellious kings. Rebellion against the Lord is a capital offense ([Ps 2](#); [Rom 6:23](#)).

Psalms 110:5-7

The new priestly role of David's descendant does not rescind his old role as conquering ruler. He must still bring the nations under his rule ([110:2-3](#); see [Ps 2](#)).

Psalms 110:7

God's messianic ruler obtains victory as a vigorous person, as if he had received nourishment from brooks along the way ([110:3](#)).

Psalms 111:1-5

The godly praise God and delight themselves in his great works. His mighty acts reflect his righteousness, grace, and compassion (see [116:5-7](#)). All who submit themselves to him experience his glory.

Psalms 111:1-10

This wisdom psalm contains many references to the works of the Lord that reveal his character. God is righteous, gracious, compassionate, faithful, just, trustworthy, upright, holy, and awe-inspiring ([111:3, 4, 7, 8, 9](#)). God's character gives hope in the covenant relationship ([111:5](#)). He rescued Israel from Egypt ([111:9](#)), gave them the land ([111:6](#)), and provides for his people ([111:5](#)). However, God demands that the beneficiaries of this relationship also be people of righteousness and integrity.

Psalms 111:1-117.2

The refrain Praise the Lord! (Hebrew halleluyah) characterizes this group of psalms.

Psalms 111:5

God takes care of his people's needs, even providing food. He remembers his covenant with Abraham (see [105:8-11](#)).

Psalms 111:6–8

Giving Israel the lands of other nations was just and good because the Lord was executing his justice on those he dispossessed and showing grace to the Israelites. However, if the Israelites do not live faithfully and with integrity, they will also be dispossessed. The Lord's people must reflect his character.

Psalms 111:9

The people of the Exodus generation went free because of God's grace.

Psalms 111:10

True wisdom is the source of life ([Prov 3:18](#); [9:11](#); [Eccl 7:12](#)); it begins with the fear of the Lord ([Prov 9:10](#)).

Psalms 112:1–5

The fear of the Lord leads to a life of wisdom that honors God and blesses the family and community. The godly joyfully imitate God; their obedience is not slavish.

Psalms 112:1–10

This psalm reiterates the themes of wisdom and the fear of the Lord ([Ps 111](#)). The wise have reason to be happy ([112:1–5](#)) and vigorous ([112:6–10](#)).

Psalms 112:2–3

successful: All will know the children of godly people (see [127:4](#)) because the godly leave a legacy for their children (see [1:3](#); cp. [Matt 6:20](#)).

Psalms 112:4–5

The godly imitate God by being generous, compassionate, and righteous ([51:1](#); [111:1–10](#); [2 Cor 9:9](#)). They lend money to the poor without charging interest ([Pss 15:5](#); [112:9](#); [Exod 22:25](#)).

Psalms 112:6

The honesty and compassion of the wise keeps them from stumbling ([15:5](#); [37:23–24](#)), ensuring that they will be long remembered ([Prov 10:7](#)).

Psalms 112:8

Because the godly joyfully expect God to prevail and rescue them, they face their foes triumphantly ([59:10](#); [112:4](#); [118:7](#)).

Psalms 112:9

Paul quotes this verse in his instructions about generous giving ([2 Cor 9:9](#)).

Psalms 112:10

The wicked . . . grind their teeth in anger out of their bitter envy ([35:16](#); [37:12](#)). The vigor and reputation of the godly cause conflict with those who want them dead. • The wicked will slink away out of fear and shame.

Psalms 113:1–3

The name of the Lord (Hebrew *Yahweh*; see [Exod 3:15](#)) reveals his being, character, and reputation. He is exalted in time (now and forever) and in space (from east to west).

Psalms 113:1–9

This hymn of praise exalts the greatness of the Lord's name and glory. God is greatly exalted and glorious in heaven ([113:4](#)); he also stoops down to take care of the lowly and needy on earth ([113:5–9](#)).

Psalms 113:1–118.29

These psalms form what is known as the "Egyptian Hallel" (*hallel* means "praise") because Jews use the collection in the celebration of Passover, which was instituted at the beginning of the exodus from Egypt. [Psalms 113–114](#) are recited before the Passover meal and [Pss 115–118](#) afterward.

Psalms 113:4

The Lord's glory reaches to the heavens ([57:5](#), [11:99:2](#); [108:5](#); [138:6](#); [Isa 6:1](#); [57:15](#)) and throughout the world of human relationships.

Psalms 113:5-9

The incomparable Lord intimately involves himself in caring for people on earth.

Psalms 113:6

The Lord stoops to the world's level to be directly involved with his people (see [138:6](#); [Phil 2:6-8](#)).

Psalms 113:7-8

These phrases are a quotation from Hannah's prayer of praise ([1 Sam 2:8-9a](#)).

Psalms 113:9

A childless woman was customarily treated with disdain ([Gen 16:4](#)); the Lord has the power to make her a happy mother, as he made Sarah ([Gen 21:2](#)), Rebekah ([Gen 25:21](#)), Rachel ([Gen 30:23](#)), and Hannah ([1 Sam 1:20](#)). • God's greatness and goodness provide ample reason to praise him.

Psalms 114:1-2

At the time of Israel's exodus from Egypt and their entrance into the Promised Land, Israel was one holy kingdom ([Exod 19:5-6](#)). • The separate references to the land of Judah and Israel indicate that the psalm was composed after the kingdom was divided ([1 Kgs 12:16-17](#); cp. [1 Sam 11:8](#); [1 Kgs 1:35](#)), and probably after the Exile. The land of Judah became God's sanctuary because the people worshiped God; his Tabernacle and later his Temple were located there.

Psalms 114:1-8

This lyrical celebration of the Lord's power in nature recalls Israel's beginning as a nation at the Exodus ([114:1-2](#)) and upon their entry to the Promised Land ([114:3-6](#)). It promotes reverence for the God of Jacob ([114:7-8](#)).

Psalms 114:3-4

hurried out of their way! The waters divided for Israel to escape Egypt ([77:17-18](#); [Exod 14](#)). • The Jordan River turned away when Israel arrived to cross over (see [Josh 3](#)). • skipped like rams: God's presence caused the mountains to quake ([Exod 19:16-20](#)).

Psalms 114:8

The Lord miraculously provided for his people in hard times after the Exile, just as he had done in the wilderness after the Exodus.

Psalms 115:1-3

The community confesses their faith that God will rescue them for the glory of his name.

Psalms 115:1-18

In this hymn of thanksgiving for God's blessings, the community ascribes all glory to the name of the Lord, who is the true source of hope and blessing. Meanwhile, those who trust in idols are greatly disappointed. The blessing of the Creator of heaven and earth extends to future generations ([115:14](#)), and especially to the priesthood ([115:12](#)).

Psalms 115:2-3

Where is their God? People deny God's presence or power when he does not act as they think he should (cp. [14:1](#); [42:3](#), [10](#)). However, God is in the heavens—he has all power, authority, and knowledge. He does as he wishes, not what people think he should do. He works out his plans in accord with his will ([Eph 1:11](#)) and acts in his own time and in ways he chooses.

Psalms 115:4-11

This entire section is repeated in [135:15-20](#). • Unlike the Lord ([95:3-5](#)), idols cannot do anything; they are good for nothing.

Psalms 115:8

Worshipping idols leads one astray and corrupts those who trust in them ([Isa 44:20](#)).

Psalms 115:9-11

Israel . . . priests . . . you who fear the Lord: The psalmist calls on all those in the God-fearing community to commit their ways to the living God. The threefold address assures them that the Lord is their true helper and shield (cp. [118:2-4](#)).

Psalms 115:12-13

The groups named in [115:9-11](#) receive assurance of the Lord's blessing, regardless of their social status (see [113:8](#)).

Psalms 115:14-15

The psalmist blesses ([107:37-38](#), [41](#)) all who trust in and fear the Lord. The Creator will care for the families of those who fear him. • who made heaven and earth: This statement speaks of the Lord's all-encompassing power in creation.

Psalms 115:16-18

The heavens belong to the Lord's: God's exaltation begins in heaven ([113:4](#)), far above the gods of the nations. Of course, the earth also belongs to him ([47:9](#); [95:4](#)). • The dead cannot participate in God's blessings. The living praise God in thanksgiving for his blessings ([79:13](#)).

Psalms 116:1

I love the Lord: This unique opening expresses affection for and commitment to the Lord (see

[18:1](#); [Deut 6:5](#)) on the basis of what the Lord has done.

Psalms 116:1-4

The psalmist praises the Lord for answering his prayers and rescuing him from death.

Psalms 116:1-19

This hymn of thanksgiving rejoices in God's character and in rescue from death ([116:1-11](#)). It gives an assurance of God's protection in life and reminds the godly that the Lord watches over them even at death. The psalmist commits to living as God's servant and resolves to honor him publicly ([116:12-19](#)).

Psalms 116:2

Because the Lord responds to the cry of his people ([107:41](#); [113:6-8](#)), the psalmist now strongly believes in prayer.

Psalms 116:3

It isn't clear if the psalmist's crisis was a literal near-death experience or if he was using the term figuratively.

Psalms 116:4

This is the first of three times that the psalmist calls on the Lord's name (i.e., reputation).

Psalms 116:5-7

The gracious, righteous, and compassionate Lord (see [111:1-5](#)) rescued and gave rest to the psalmist.

Psalms 116:6

People with childlike faith readily receive his wisdom and instruction ([19:7-11](#); [Matt 18:3-4](#)).

Psalms 116:8–11

The psalmist's near-death crisis made him more aware of life and of walking before the Lord. Though he had been in anguish, the Lord was faithful. However, people are all liars.

Psalms 116:9

I walk in the Lord's presence: The psalmist already lived with integrity, but since his experience of deep distress, he now enjoys open fellowship with the Lord (see [56:13](#); cp. [Job 42:5](#)).

Psalms 116:10

I believed in you: Paul quotes this phrase in [2 Cor 4:13](#).

Psalms 116:12–14

The Lord's gracious gifts are so great that the psalmist can do nothing to repay his debt. Keeping his promises publicly demonstrates his gratitude. • All he has done for the psalmist includes answers to prayer, rescue, and life. • The cup of salvation overflows with God's blessings ([23:5](#)), unlike the cup of judgment ([75:8](#)). • The psalmist makes promises ("vows," [116:18](#)) to praise the Lord publicly ([116:17–18](#)).

Psalms 116:15–19

No one lives or dies outside of God's will. Having been given a second chance at life, the poet readily commits himself to the Lord with renewed acts of public devotion.

Psalms 117:1

Paul quotes this verse to show that Gentiles would eventually praise the God of Israel ([Rom 15:11](#)).

Psalms 117:1–2

This psalm, the shortest in the Psalter, invites all . . . people of the earth to praise the Lord because of his unfailing love and enduring faithfulness.

Psalms 118:1–29

With an exultant testimony, the psalmist gives thanks for the Lord's goodness and encourages others to trust in his faithful love ([118:1–4](#), [29](#)). This poem is the last of the Egyptian Hallel ([Pss 113–118](#)).

Psalms 118:2–4

Israel . . . Aaron's descendants . . . all who fear the Lord: These three groups represent the whole of the covenant community (cp. [115:9–11](#); [135:19–20](#)).

Psalms 118:5–9

The Lord alone is the psalmist's helper.

Psalms 118:6–7

The Lord is for me: Cp. [Rom 8:31](#); [Heb 13:6](#). • God's presence cancels out the need to fear mere people ([Ps 56:11](#)). The psalmist joyfully expects God's rescue ([59:10](#); [112:8](#)).

Psalms 118:8–9

Trusting in the Lord is better than placing confidence in even the most powerful human leaders ([118:6](#); [146:3](#)).

Psalms 118:10–12

Strength comes in the name of the Lord, declared by the threefold mention of the attackers, the Lord's name, and victory. • Even when hostile people blazed . . . like a crackling fire, the Lord caused them to subside like burning thorns (see [Isa 9:18](#); [10:17](#)).

Psalms 118:14–18

The psalmist celebrates the victory of the Lord's strong right arm, which kept him from death.

Psalms 118:17–21

God has restored the psalmist from death to life, so he praises the Lord publicly (cp. [116:6](#), [12–19](#)).

Psalms 118:22

The cornerstone (or *keystone*) of a building or an arch gives the structure its shape and foundation. It is the most important of all the stones. The Lord chooses and places this stone for his sanctuary ([Isa 28:16](#)). Jesus referred to himself as this cornerstone ([Matt 21:42](#); [Mark 12:10–11](#); [Luke 20:17](#); see [Acts 4:11](#); [Eph 2:20](#); [1 Pet 2:6–7](#)).

Psalms 118:22–24

The psalmist sees his own salvation as the beginning of a new day in which the Lord will do great things.

Psalms 118:24

This is the day the Lord has made: The day of the Lord's victory has already arrived, although its completion awaits another day ([118:25](#)).

Psalms 118:25–29

The psalmist concludes with prayer and thanksgiving, anticipating an even greater revelation of God's victory and rescue.

Psalms 118:26

The one who comes in the name of the Lord brings the Lord's complete victory (see [118:10–12](#)). • During Jesus' triumphant entry into Jerusalem, the crowds called out various blessings, including phrases taken from this verse ([Matt 21:9](#); [Mark 11:9](#); [Luke 19:38](#); [John 12:13](#)). Jesus himself quoted this passage as he wept over Jerusalem ([Matt 23:39](#); [Luke 13:35](#)).

Psalms 119:1–4

The wise are happy. They are people of integrity (see [84:11](#)) who follow the path of divine instruction. They obey God's revelation and search for it with all their hearts (see [27:7](#); [119:10](#), [45](#), [94](#), [155](#)), and they reject all forms of evil. Cp. [1:1–2](#).

Psalms 119:1–8

Aleph (א): God, the author of these instructions, commands that his followers live by them. The psalmist prays to be given the grace to live by that revelation.

Psalms 119:1–176

This psalm combines elements of wisdom, lament, praise, thanksgiving, and confession. Eight Hebrew words are used frequently, translated as "instructions," "laws," "words," "regulations," "statutes," "commands," "decrees," "commandments," and "promises." Together, these words encourage love for and obedience to God's instructions, as found in the Scriptures (see [2 Tim 3:14–17](#)). The expression of deep commitment to these instructions unifies the psalm.

Psalms 119:4

To keep God's commandments means to guard them by obeying them.

Psalms 119:9

A young person tends toward foolishness ([Prov 22:15](#)) and can easily make mistakes that destroy his life ([Prov 7:6–23](#)). Youth is also the best time to develop personal discipline and pursue wisdom (see [Ps 34:11](#); [Prov 1:4](#)). • To stay pure means to remain uncorrupted by wickedness and sin and to develop the integrity of life defined in [Ps 15](#).

Psalms 119:9–16

Beth (ב): The psalmist is determined to pursue purity and encourages the cultivation of wisdom through God's principles ([119:9](#)) and instructions ([119:10–16](#)).

Psalms 119:10

The student asks God the teacher to discipline him so that he will not wander.

Psalms 119:14

God's wisdom is far greater than any riches humans seek ([119:72](#), [127](#); [Prov 3:14–15](#)).

Psalms 119:15

The way of wisdom includes meditating on God's ways (see [119:1](#), [3](#)). The wise reflect on the implications of God's word.

Psalms 119:17–18

The psalmist seeks to please the Lord with a full and obedient life of praise ([118:17](#); [119:25](#), [77](#), [116](#), [144](#), [175](#)). Only the Lord can remove his adversaries and enable him to see the wonderful truths found in God's instructions.

Psalms 119:17–24

Gimel (ג): Like a foreigner in hostile territory, God's servant needs God's guidance.

Psalms 119:20–21

The arrogant are probably those who mock the psalmist ([119:22–23](#)).

Psalms 119:23–24

Those who meditate on God's instructions receive wise advice from them.

Psalms 119:25–32

Daleth (ד): Though the poet feels anguish and sorrow, he entreats the Lord to revive him because he wants to obey the Lord. Suffering and death may

result from the Lord's chastening ([118:17–18](#); [119:67](#), [71](#), [75](#)), but his instruction revives the weary soul (see [119:12](#)).

Psalms 119:29

lying to myself: Self-deception is a fruit of sinful human nature ([Jer 17:9](#)); it leads to folly. • Access to God's word is a privilege, not a right.

Psalms 119:33–40

He (ה): As a student, the poet asks his teacher, God, to renew life and to transform disgrace into righteousness.

Psalms 119:36

The love for money can lead to sin (cp. [Exod 18:21](#); [1 Tim 3:1–5](#); [6:10](#)).

Psalms 119:41–43

The psalmist asks to be saved from enemies who speak harshly (see [42:10](#); [44:16](#); [89:50–51](#); [102:8](#)).

Psalms 119:41–48

Waw (ו): The psalmist prays that God's word would continue to be the source of his love and salvation.

Psalms 119:44–46

The psalmist is determined to obey the Lord.

Psalms 119:47–48

The psalmist finds delight in God's word in spite of pain ([119:92](#), [143](#)).

Psalms 119:49–56

Zayin (ז): The psalmist asks God to remember his word as the psalmist also remembers God's word and his name. Remembrance expresses devotion.

Psalms 119:52

The age-old regulations are the Torah (God's "instructions" or "law"), a term that refers to the books of Genesis—Deuteronomy.

Psalms 119:57–64

Heth (ח): The psalmist seeks God's favor and unfailing love. Although surrounded by evildoers, he remains a loyal servant of the Lord.

Psalms 119:61

Evil people try to drag him into sin, but the psalmist's memory of God's word keeps him standing firm (see [119:16](#)).

Psalms 119:64

God's goodness fills the earth; the whole created order provides evidence of his goodness (see [Isa 6:3](#); [11:9](#)).

Psalms 119:65–68

Good judgment and knowledge come from wisdom ([111:10](#)). • The psalmist admits that he used to wander off like a stray sheep ([119:176](#)). • you disciplined me: See [119:25–29](#). • You are good and do only good: God's character is perfect ([97:2](#); [Jas 1:17](#); [1Jn 1:5](#)).

Psalms 119:65–72

Teth (ט): The psalmist describes himself as a penitent sinner who gratefully accepts the Lord's discipline.

Psalms 119:73–76

As God's child, the psalmist asks for divine wisdom.

Psalms 119:73–80

Yodh (י): In this prayer for comfort and compassion, the psalmist commits himself to his Creator, who has afflicted him. He wants God to pay back his enemies for the wrongs they have done. He also prays to receive the gift of life. He not only prays for himself but also considers the whole community of the godly, asking that God's answers to prayer would encourage them.

Psalms 119:81–88

Kaph (כ): The psalmist is worn out from waiting for the Lord, but his hope is in God's future rescue.

Psalms 119:85–88

God's word is trustworthy, in contrast to the deceptions of the enemies who hunt the psalmist down without cause (see [119:78](#)).

Psalms 119:89–96

Lamedh (ל): The stability of God's wisdom gives understanding. God's word provides order and a framework for living, even when under pressure from adversaries.

Psalms 119:95

The wicked intended to kill the psalmist, but destruction ([1:6](#)) was their own fate.

Psalms 119:96

Even perfection has its limits: Humans cannot fully understand God's ways (see [Eccl 3:11](#)).

Psalms 119:97–102

make me wiser: God's word provides wisdom and perspective. God is the true source of wisdom.

Psalms 119:97–104

Mem (מ): The instruction and wisdom of God through his word are far superior to the best that human teachers can offer.

Psalms 119:103–104

Wisdom is preferable to even the finest food ([19:10](#); [81:16](#)). • The psalmist had already rejected the delusion offered by the way of folly (see [119:18](#), [78](#), [86](#), [163](#)).

Psalms 119:105–106

The Lord's word is a lamp that provides perspective, hope, and guidance in darkness ([18:25–29](#); [119:130](#)). Even more, this light gives life ([Prov 6:23](#)).

Psalms 119:105–112

Nun (נ): The psalmist's devotion to God's word comes from within his being ([119:112](#)) and guides his external life.

Psalms 119:108–112

offering of praise: This Hebrew expression is unique in the Old Testament (cp. [50:23](#)). • The psalmist is vulnerable to his opponents because of his commitment to a wise life.

Psalms 119:113

The godly hate the wicked and their deeds ([5:4–6](#); cp. [Ezek 33:11](#)).

Psalms 119:113–120

Samekh (ס): The psalmist declares his hatred of evil and his love for God and his ways.

Psalms 119:121–128

Ayin (ע): The servant of the Lord strains to endure the evil around him. He boldly petitions the Lord to rescue him immediately!

Psalms 119:125

Simply possessing God's law does not provide any benefits. The psalmist knows that only as the Lord gives discernment will he understand it.

Psalms 119:129–136

Pe (פ): The psalmist prays earnestly for God to speak to him as he suffers from his adversities.

Psalms 119:137–144

Tsadhe (צ): God is righteous, and his word is right and just, especially in contrast to the deceptions of the wicked.

Psalms 119:139

The psalmist's indignation (cp. [69:9](#)) comes from seeing the wicked disregard God's word.

Psalms 119:141

The psalmist is greatly troubled by his oppressors (see [119:143](#); cp. [Isa 53](#)).

Psalms 119:145–148

I rise and *anticipate* translate the same Hebrew verb.

Psalms 119:145–152

Qoph (ק): The psalmist prays to the Lord at night. Even when God seems distant, he is actually close.

Psalms 119:150–151

Coming to attack me (or *draw near*) is a Hebrew wordplay on *You are near*. The wicked stay far from God's instructions, but the psalmist stays close, so he does not need to fear.

Psalms 119:153–160

Resh (ר): This request for life appears throughout [Psalm 119](#), but it is focused in this stanza.

Psalms 119:161–164

my heart trembles . . . I rejoice: Fear, trembling, and joy mark the psalmist's devotion to God. • God's word is a treasure. • In the Old Testament, seven signifies wholeness.

Psalms 119:161–168

Shin (ש): The psalmist looks beyond his adversaries to the peace of God. This perspective allows him to praise God throughout the day.

Psalms 119:169–176

Taw (ת): God's servant petitions the Lord one final time; he still feels like a lost sheep.

Psalms 119:176

God, the Great Shepherd, seeks out his lost sheep ([23:1](#); [Luke 15:4–6](#)).

Psalms 120:1–2

The psalmist is surrounded by liars, so he makes his lament to the Lord, the only one who can help him.

Psalms 120:1–7

This short, individual lament expresses the psalmist's trust that the Lord will deal with deceptive evildoers. It also laments living as a

stranger among hateful liars. The psalmist's picture of his life in a foreign land might have been a reality as he set out for Jerusalem, or it might depict his feelings and concerns as he begins his pilgrimage. Overwhelmed with injustice, he trusts God and looks forward to arriving in the Lord's presence.

Psalms 120:1–134.3

These short, appealing songs were sung during pilgrims' journeys to Jerusalem for the national festivals three times per year ([Deut 16:16](#)). The title of these psalms includes the Hebrew word for stairs, which some take to mean "ascending to Jerusalem." These psalms (sometimes called the Songs of Ascents) take the reader on a pilgrimage to Jerusalem to praise God for his goodness to Israel throughout history.

Psalms 120:3–4

The psalmist dialogues with the liars who surround him. He feels reassured that the Lord will judge them. • The Divine Warrior (see [7:12–13](#); [11:4–6](#)) will throw sharp arrows and glowing coals on the liars.

Psalms 120:5

Meshech was a Japhethite territory far to the north of Canaan. Kedar was an Ishmaelite territory in Arabia. Violent people lived in both locations. Meshech was the home of a famous slave trade ([Ezek 27:13](#); cp. [Exod 21:16](#)) and Kedar of renowned warriors ([Isa 21:16–17](#)). These places can be understood as representative of the apostate, violent land where the psalmist suffered.

Psalms 120:5–7

The psalmist feels the anguish of alienation, isolation, and perpetual conflict.

Psalms 120:6–7

peace: See [37:11](#); [122:6–9](#); [125:5](#); [128:6](#).

Psalms 121:1

The mountains were known for their idolatrous worship ([Deut 12:2](#)), and Israel was enticed to the hilltop shrines ([Hos 4:13](#)). This verse can be understood as a rhetorical question expecting a negative answer: The gods of the hilltop shrines cannot rescue anyone. Others understand the mountains to be a symbol of the Lord's strength ([Ps 95:4](#)). In that case, the question would be interpreted literally (*Where does my help come from?*), with the answer given in the next verse

Psalms 121:1-8

The leader of the group of pilgrims uses word pictures to assure the group of the Lord's presence during the journey.

Psalms 121:4

God watches over his own, even and especially when they face many troubles ([12:5](#), [7](#); [69:29](#); [91:14](#); [146:9](#)).

Psalms 121:4-6

The Creator ([121:2](#)) is the guardian of Israel. • God stands beside Israel, supporting and caring for the godly (see [16:7-8](#)). • Both the sun and the moon were regarded as deities in the ancient Near East, but the Creator limits their power. They, too, praise the Lord ([148:3](#)).

Psalms 122:1

The central sanctuary was the house of the Lord. This phrase originally referred to the Tabernacle ([Exod 23:19](#); [34:26](#)).

Psalms 122:1-9

Jerusalem is here idealized as the city of God, the city of David, and the city of faith. A group of people on a pilgrimage joyfully arrive in the city ([122:1-2](#)). The psalmist sings an ode to Jerusalem ([122:3-5](#)) and prays for the city's peace ([122:6-9](#)).

Psalms 122:2

Several psalms celebrate or look forward to being inside the gates of the city ([9:14](#); [87:2](#); [100:4](#); [118:19](#)).

Psalms 122:3

In the time of David and Solomon, Jerusalem was renowned as a place of security ([1 Kgs 10:6-7](#)).

Psalms 122:3-5

Jerusalem is a metaphor for God's heavenly dwelling. David was the archetype for God's chosen rulers.

Psalms 122:4

Each of the people of Israel belonged to one of the tribes, and all of the tribes belonged to the Lord. • To give thanks is to present an offering acceptable to the Lord ([50:14](#), [23](#); [100:4](#); [118:19](#)). • as the law requires of Israel: See [Exod 23:17](#); [Deut 16:16](#).

Psalms 122:5

the thrones where judgment is given: In the eras of David and Solomon ([1 Kgs 3:28](#)), Jerusalem was the home of wisdom and justice; it would be so again ([Isa 9:7](#)).

Psalms 122:6-9

Prayers for the peace of Jerusalem are motivated by love of family and God's sanctuary.

Psalms 123:1-4

This lament on the psalmist's lowly position expresses vivid trust in the Lord ([123:1-2](#)). The psalmist prays for God's favor on the community, as the reality of evil surrounds them ([123:3-4](#)). The poet looks beyond Jerusalem ([Ps 122](#)) to God's throne in heaven.

Psalms 124:1-2

The negative rhetorical questions emphasize the positive idea that the Lord was indeed on their side.

Psalms 124:1-8

This thanksgiving song describes what might happen if the Lord were not present with his people.

Psalms 124:4-5

the raging waters of their fury: The enemies could have overwhelmed the Israelites and wiped them out if the Lord had not been with his people (cp. [69:15](#); [Jer 46:8](#)).

Psalms 124:6-8

The enemies of God's people, like lions or bears who tear their prey with their teeth (see [57:4](#); [Prov 28:15](#)), had their mouths shut by the Lord ([Dan 6:22](#)).

Psalms 125:1-5

The psalmist expresses the community's confidence in the Lord's protection ([125:1-2](#)) and prays for peace ([125:3-5](#)).

Psalms 125:2

surrounds: God guards and protects like a wall of fire ([Zech 2:5](#)).

Psalms 125:3

The godly might be tempted through peer pressure and cultural domination.

Psalms 125:4-5

People who reject the straight path of the upright are fools ([Prov 2:12-15](#)). God pours out his goodness on the godly (see [Ps 122:6-9](#)).

Psalms 126:1-3

The Lord brought about Israel's restoration from exile, just as he had brought Israel out of Egypt ([114:1](#)). The restoration transformed the weeping of the Lord's people into laughter and showed the Lord's character to the nations ([9:11](#); [64:9](#); [Isa 12:4](#)).

Psalms 126:1-6

This hymn celebrates Israel's return from exile ([126:1-3](#)). The psalmist prays for full restoration ([126:4-6](#)).

Psalms 126:4-6

The prophets had spoken of the restoration as a time when the wilderness would change into the Garden of Eden ([Isa 51:3](#); [Ezek 47](#)); the reality fell far short of paradise. Here the restoration community prays for full redemption (see [Hag 2:19](#)). • as streams renew the desert: The seasonal rains filled the dry river beds (*wadis*), and the land turned green again. The prayer looks for a similar transformation of Israel's fortunes, a fulfillment of the imagery of the "Second Exodus" in Isaiah (see "The Promise of a Second Exodus" Theme Note). • The harvest represents God's full restoration.

Psalms 127:1-2

Unless: These conditional sentences emphasize the positive idea that the Lord will protect the city (cp. [124:1-2](#)). • Human effort is futile unless the Lord blesses it (see [44:3](#)). • from early morning until late at night: This depicts an aggressive and competitive lifestyle. • God's loved ones enjoy a quiet night's sleep ([3:5](#); [4:8](#)).

Psalms 127:1-5

Blessing and protection come from God. Without his presence, there is no success ([127:1-2](#)). This is particularly true for children, who are God's gift ([127:3-5](#)).

Psalms 127:3-5

Children are one of God's blessings. The words translated "children" (Hebrew *banim*) and "builders" (*bonim*, [127:1](#)) form a wordplay. Having children builds a family.

Psalms 127:4-5

like arrows: God uses children to protect the reputation of his people against the wicked (cp. [120:4](#); [7:12-13](#)).

Psalms 128:1-2

Enjoying the fruit of one's labor means gaining benefit from whatever work one does.

Psalms 128:1-6

The godly, who fear the Lord, will know true happiness ([128:1-2](#)). The Lord is with them (see [127:1-2](#)), building their home life ([128:3-4](#)) and blessing them across the generations ([128:5-6](#)).

Psalms 128:3

Like vigorous young olive trees, children are saplings filled with potential. Olive oil symbolizes God's blessing ([104:15](#); [Num 18:12](#); [Jer 31:12](#); [Hag 2:19](#)).

Psalms 128:4-6

God will continually bless all who fear him ([133:3](#)) from his dwelling in Zion ([20:2](#); [50:2](#); [110:2](#)), no matter where they live. • grandchildren: God's blessings extend from generation to generation for the faithful ([79:12-13](#); [89:1](#); [100:4-5](#); [103:17-19](#)).

Psalms 129:1-2

Israel's earliest youth as a nation was during its sojourn in Egypt.

Psalms 129:1-8

The psalmist briefly reviews Israel's history of trouble ([129:1-2](#)) and redemption ([129:3-4](#)). He concludes with curses against the enemies and blessings on the godly ([129:5-6](#)).

Psalms 129:3-4

the Lord is good: He rescued Israel from Egypt, from many enemy attacks, and from the Babylonian exile.

Psalms 129:6-8

Grass on a rooftop had shallow roots and would scorch easily. A crop was ignored by the harvester when the yield was low. The enemies who had sown hurt among God's people would gain little.

Psalms 130:1-3

A cry from the depths is from a place of deep distress (cp. [69:2](#), [14](#); [Isa 51:10](#); [Ezek 27:34](#)). Out of the frailty of his being, the psalmist prays for divine favor.

Psalms 130:1-8

Beginning with himself as a representative of the community, the psalmist cries for God's mercy ([130:1-3](#)) out of deep distress. He places his hope in the Lord ([130:4-6](#)), knowing that the Lord will rescue when and as he chooses. Based on this confidence, the psalmist invites Israel to wait for the Lord ([130:7-8](#)).

Psalms 130:3

The psalmist knows that his sins make him guilty and deserving of God's judgment.

Psalms 130:4-6

The good news comes in God's readiness to forgive sinners. His grace encourages people to fear him and hope in him.

Psalms 130:5

God's word imparts hope ([119:42-43](#), [49](#); [147:11](#)).

Psalms 130:7-8

Israel is invited to hope in the Lord ([9:18](#); [27:14](#); [131:3](#)) because the Lord pays the costly price for redemption and covers whatever sin separates humans from him (see also [111:9](#); [Exod 6:6-8](#); [2 Sam 7:23-24](#); [Isa 43:1-4](#); [Titus 2:14](#); [Heb 9:12](#); [1 Pet 1:18](#)).

Psalms 131:1

The heart represents the whole being (see [27:8](#)). • God hates arrogance, which is a foolish way of life ([Prov 6:16-19](#)). • The psalmist does not trouble himself with matters that properly belong to the Lord.

Psalms 131:1-3

Out of his contentment in the Lord, the psalmist invites Israel to seek their rest in God ([131:3](#)).

Psalms 131:2

The psalmist calmed and quieted himself, surrendering his ambitions and taming his ego ([Gal 2:20](#)). • like a weaned child: The psalmist sees himself as a contented child.

Psalms 132:1-18

This psalm celebrates the Lord's faithfulness to David. When David wanted to bring the Ark into Jerusalem ([132:1-5](#)), the Lord granted the request and made Jerusalem his earthly home ([132:6-10](#)). The choice of Jerusalem marked God's election of David's line ([132:11-13](#)), of Zion ([132:14-17](#)), and of the priesthood ([132:9](#), [16](#)).

Psalms 132:6

Ephrathah is Bethlehem ([Gen 35:19](#); [48:7](#)). • Jaar is the singular form of the plural "Jearim." The Ark was at Kiriath-jearim for twenty years in Samuel's time ([1 Sam 7:1-2](#)).

Psalms 132:6-10

These verses form a recollection of David's moving the Ark of the Covenant to Jerusalem ([2 Sam 6:1-15](#)) and of the Lord's oath to David ([2 Sam 7:4-16](#)).

Psalms 132:8-10

These verses are a quotation from Solomon's prayer at the dedication of the Temple ([2 Chr 6:41-42](#)).

Psalms 132:9

The priests were to exhibit righteousness in their lives ([132:16](#); [Mal 2:6](#)).

Psalms 132:11-12

The Lord swore an oath to David ([2 Sam 7:4-16](#)): God's promise is unconditional, but the covenant is not (If . . . then). Those who break God's covenant can expect the discipline of God's judgment (see [Ps 89:30-37](#)).

Psalms 132:13-17

The psalmist recounts the selection of Jerusalem and of the priests.

Psalms 132:17

anointed one: The ruler God chose and established (see [Pss 1-8](#)) would never cease to provide light for the Lord's people. This light would burn continually (see [1 Kgs 11:36](#); [2 Kgs 8:19](#); cp. [John 8:12](#); [Rev 21:23-24](#)).

Psalms 132:18

The adversaries will be humiliated, in contrast to the glorious king ([132:9](#), [16](#)).

Psalms 133:1

Brothers are related by blood, by profession, or by commitment.

Psalms 133:1–2

The psalmist tells of the joy of consecrated relationships.

Psalms 133:1–3

In this wisdom psalm (see [Ps 1](#)), peaceful and harmonious relationships manifest the presence of God.

Psalms 133:2

The anointing oil was the oil used to ordain and consecrate Aaron for service in his office (see [Exod 29:7](#)). • head . . . beard . . . border of his robe: The oil consecrated Aaron completely.

Psalms 133:3

The dew represents the richness of divine blessings; in Jerusalem, it comes from moist winds from the Mediterranean Sea. Mount Hermon, which is capped with snow, is a place of abundant moisture. • A blessing is God's life-giving power, a guarantee of his provision and protection ([5:12](#); [41:2](#)), secured by his presence ([21:6](#); [67:1](#)). Even the other nations will ultimately be blessed ([Pss 67](#); [72:17](#)). Zion is the focal point of God's blessing ([134:3](#); [147:13](#)). • God gives life everlasting to human beings.

Psalms 134:1–2

Those who serve at night were the priests and Levites (see also [135:2](#)).

Psalms 134:1–3

In the last of the pilgrims' songs ([Pss 120–134](#)), the travelers call the Temple workers to praise the Lord. In return, they will receive a much-anticipated blessing.

Psalms 135:1–21

God, the Creator and the Lord of history, "made heaven and earth" ([134:3](#)). He deserves praise because, unlike idols, he redeems his people.

Psalms 135:4

The synonyms Jacob and Israel include all twelve tribes. The Lord cherishes his chosen people. They are his treasure out of all the kingdoms of the world ([Exod 19:5–6](#)).

Psalms 135:5

The Lord is superior to any real or imagined supernatural being (see [95:3–5](#); [115:4–8](#)).

Psalms 135:6

God is sovereign over the whole created order—he does whatever pleases him. • The phrase heaven and earth refers to all of creation.

Psalms 135:7

The psalmist tells of God's sovereignty over the weather ([Pss 29](#); [77:17–18](#); [78:26](#); [104:4](#); [147:8–9](#); [148:5–6](#)).

Psalms 135:8–11

In the tenth and culminating plague against Egypt, God destroyed the firstborn of each family. • The miraculous signs and wonders are the ten plagues (see [Exod 7–11](#); [Deut 4:34](#); [Neh 9:10](#)).

Psalms 135:8–12

The Lord was sovereign over the Exodus and the conquest of the Promised Land.

Psalms 135:13–18

The Lord's name and character stand in contrast to idols.

Psalms 135:15–18

Idols corrupt the thinking because they are merely things made by humans; they cannot speak, see, hear, or breathe ([Isa 41:22–24](#); [44:9](#), [18](#); [Rom 1:21–23](#)).

Psalms 135:15–20

This entire section is repeated in [115:4–11](#).

Psalms 135:19–21

The groups named here comprised the covenant community (see [115:9–11](#)).

Psalms 136:1–3

The psalmist invites the community to praise the Lord, who is good and full of love, the true Lord of humanity. Verse 1 alludes to the poetic expression in [2 Chr 5:13](#).

Psalms 136:1–26

This is the last of the Great Hallel psalms ([Pss 120–136](#)). It distinctively repeats the refrain His faithful love endures forever in every verse. The hymn is framed by a call to praise ([136:1–3](#), [26](#)). It proclaims the Lord as the Creator of all and the Redeemer of Israel, both in the distant ([136:10–22](#)) and in the recent past ([136:23–24](#)).

Psalms 136:10–22

The psalmist recounts the early history of Israel's redemption.

Psalms 136:23–24

The psalmist relates the recent history of Israel's redemption, although the circumstances are not specified.

Psalms 136:25

The Lord provides for all of his creatures.

Psalms 136:26

The phrase God of heaven is an exilic and postexilic designation for the Lord; it is found in Ezra ([Ezra 1:2](#); [5:11](#), [12](#); [6:9](#), [10](#); [7:12](#); etc.), Nehemiah ([Neh 1:5](#); [2:4](#), [20](#); etc.), and Daniel ([Dan 2:18](#), [19](#), [37](#), [44](#)).

Psalms 137:1–9

In response to the pain of exile ([137:1–4](#)), the psalmist resolves to remember Jerusalem even though the memories cause him pain ([137:4–6](#)). He also writes an astounding imprecation, or prayer for vengeance ([137:7–9](#)).

Psalms 137:2–4

Because the music of Jerusalem was tied to the joys of life in the Promised Land, the Exile removed any occasion for singing joyous songs. The Babylonians wanted the Judeans to sing and dance for them, but the exiles' grief made doing so either distasteful or impossible. The songs celebrating the Lord speak of his power and goodness, but his people were filled with doubts and questions. They hung their harps in trees, perhaps signifying the death of their joy under God's curse ([Deut 21:23](#)).

Psalms 137:5–6

The psalmist pledges his loyalty to Jerusalem, the city at the center of God's reign and the location of fellowship with him.

Psalms 137:7-9

The poet witnessed the betrayal of God's people from Judah by the Edomites, so he curses Edom. The long rivalry between Edom and Judah came to a head during Judah's last days, when the Edomites handed the Judeans over to the Babylonians ([Obad 1:10-11](#)) and rejoiced in Jerusalem's fall. • This prayer for vengeance is shocking.

Psalms 138:1-3

The Lord receives praise before the gods of the nations.

Psalms 138:1-8

In this wisdom psalm, the Lord is presented as the God of gods. He rescued his people and has a perfect plan for them as individuals. The nations will join Israel in glorifying God.

Psalms 138:1-145.21

In this final collection of psalms of David, praise and wisdom psalms ([Pss 138-139, 145](#)) form a frame around five poems of lament ([Pss 140-144](#)).

Psalms 138:4-5

As the Lord's glory fills the earth, the world's population must willingly submit to him. Every king (cp. [Ps 2](#)) will join the community of praise as they hear the Lord's ways of truth and love.

Psalms 138:6

God's holiness and excellence are great, beyond the scope of humanity (see [99:2](#); [113:4](#); [Isa 6:1](#); [57:15](#)).

Psalms 138:6-8

The exalted God takes care of the humble ([138:6](#)), especially his servant the psalmist ([138:7-8](#)).

Psalms 138:8

The psalmist expresses confidence in the Lord's plans, which are perfect, and prays for God's continued involvement. The psalmist sees himself as part of God's plans (see [9:10](#); [139:14](#)).

Psalms 139:1-6

The Lord knows the psalmist well; God has examined him thoroughly, in an inescapable examination that is painful at times ([Job 7:17-19](#)).

Psalms 139:1-24

In this wisdom psalm, the psalmist opens every aspect of his being, character, behavior, and speech to God's examination. As hard as life is, he wants to ensure his own growth in wisdom so that he does not come under God's judgment of the wicked ([141:5](#); [142:3](#); [143:8, 10](#); [144:3-4](#)). Further, the poet recognizes that he cannot escape from the Lord. His sense of stress disappears when he considers the Lord's loving care for him, even before birth ([139:13-18](#)). He then invites the Lord to continue examining him as he walks in the path of wisdom ([139:23-24](#)).

Psalms 139:2

The phrase sit down or stand up refers to daily activities (cp. [Deut 6:6-9](#)).

Psalms 139:3-6

The Lord's omniscience and omnipotence provide comfort to the godly, but they imprison the hearts of the wicked ([2:3](#)).

Psalms 139:6

The Lord's wonderful understanding lies beyond the psalmist's ability to comprehend (see [ludg 13:18](#)).

Psalms 139:7–12

The psalmist expresses his awe at the Lord's omnipresence.

Psalms 139:8

down to the grave: God has total access to his entire creation—even the most hard-to-reach places.

Psalms 139:9

ride the wings of the morning: This poetic expression describes traveling eastward, as far as the sunrise, if that were possible. • the farthest oceans: This expression takes the traveler in the opposite direction, far to the west.

Psalms 139:13

The delicate, inner parts of the body include a person's very being. • Even when hidden in his mother's womb, the psalmist was guided by the Lord.

Psalms 139:17

How precious are your thoughts about me: God's investigation reveals loving care. Fellowship with the Lord provides riches beyond description.

Psalms 139:19–24

The psalmist's sense of awe leads him to consider the wicked and to reflect on himself. The Lord, as the examiner of all people, judges the wicked for their destructive acts and speech; thus, the psalmist prays that he will not be among them.

Psalms 139:21

I hate: Rejection of evil is a mark of wisdom (see [1:1](#); [5:4–6](#)).

Psalms 139:23–24

The psalmist's prayer against the wicked leads him also to reflect on himself; he does not presume that he is righteous. This prayer has been repeated by believers over the centuries.

Psalms 139:24

The path of wisdom leads to everlasting life (see [1:6](#); [Prov 4:18](#); [6:23](#)).

Psalms 140:1–3

The psalmist prays for the Lord to rescue him from wicked people.

Psalms 140:1–13

In this individual lament, the psalmist artistically sketches God's enemies with all their evil intents. He prays for the Lord's protection and rescue with confidence in God's strength and justice. He foresees the evil as being judged by fire ([140:9–11](#)) and himself as being vindicated and dwelling in the Lord's presence ([140:13](#)).

Psalms 140:3

sting like a snake . . . a viper: These creatures depict the wicked as very corrupt people (see [Prov 23:32](#); [Isa 14:29](#); [Rom 3:13](#)).

Psalms 140:4–5

The psalmist asks for divine protection (see [Ps 121](#)), praying that the Lord will keep him safe from the many schemes of the wicked.

Psalms 140:7

The expression Sovereign Lord comes from combining the name Yahweh with the title Adonai (Master). See also [68:20](#); [69:6](#); [71:16](#); [73:28](#); [109:21](#); [141:8](#).

Psalms 140:9–11

The psalmist prays for God's judgment on the wicked.

Psalms 140:10

The psalmist wants fire to descend on his enemies, and he wants them thrown into pits so they can never attack again. The language foreshadows the New Testament teaching on hell ([Matt 5:22, 29–30; 10:28; 18:9; Mark 9:43–47; Luke 12:5; Jas 3:6; 2 Pet 2:4](#)).

Psalms 141:1–2

The psalmist prays urgently for rescue. He does not have at hand either incense or an evening offering ([Exod 29:38–39](#)), but his prayers and devotion are the reality that those elements represent (cp. [Isa 1:13; Rev 5:8](#)). • Upraised hands are a posture of prayer ([Pss 28:2; 88:9; 143:6; Exod 9:29; 1 Tim 2:8](#)).

Psalms 141:1–10

The psalmist prays for rescue and wisdom, and he envisions the end of evil. The principle of retribution ([141:10](#)) unifies the psalm.

Psalms 141:3–5

Wisdom sometimes requires protection from oneself. One could say or think things that lead to the evil path ([Prov 13:3; 21:23](#)). • Wisdom opens itself to correction from godly people (see [Prov 3:11; 9:8; 15:31; 19:25](#)).

Psalms 142:1–3

Though overwhelmed by his persecutors ([142:6](#)), the psalmist looks to the Lord for wisdom.

Psalms 142:1–7

regarding his experience in the cave: Cp. [Ps 57:title](#).

Psalms 142:7

His experience of confinement and duress is like being in prison (see [107:10](#)).

Psalms 142:3–4

The psalmist reaches a point of despair (see [77:3](#)), and the Lord cares for him in his distress. The psalmist commits himself to the Lord's wisdom (see [Ps 139](#)) but laments his entrapment by the wicked ([5:9–10; 140:5; 141:9; 142:3](#)).

Psalms 142:5

Though he is alone, the psalmist's trust remains in the Lord, who is his life (see [9:9; 16:5; 27:13](#)).

Psalms 142:6–7

Though overwhelmed by loneliness and trouble, the psalmist focuses on the Lord's goodness and protection. He knows that the Lord alone is his Redeemer, so he offers his praise.

Psalms 142

The psalmist faces severe persecution, so he cries to the Lord, and the Lord will rescue him.

Psalms 143:1–2

The psalmist prays for God's love and mercy.

Psalms 143:1–12

In this lament, the psalmist feels overwhelmed by constant harassment from his foes, so he turns to the Lord's love, righteousness, and faithfulness. He remembers God's acts in the past and yearns for the renewal of the Lord's love. He opens himself to God's wisdom because he knows that instruction will lead to life.

Psalms 143:2

All people are guilty before God ([Rom 3:20–24](#)).

Psalms 143:3–4

I am losing all hope: The psalmist confesses his desperation as his life slips away under oppressive and ruthless foes.

Psalms 143:5–6

Remembering God's acts from the past reassures the psalmist of God's faithfulness ([42:4](#); [63:6](#); [77:3, 6](#); [119:55](#)).

Psalms 143:6

The psalmist's thirst is a deep longing for God's redemption (see [42:1–2](#)).

Psalms 143:7

The psalmist experiences depression. He feels that he is dying from anguish ([31:10](#); [119:87](#)), exhausted ([39:10](#); [71:9](#); [119:81](#)), fainting with longing ([84:2](#)), and overwhelmed by the weariness of life ([90:7, 9](#)).

Psalms 143:7–10

The psalmist petitions the Lord for a renewal of his love.

Psalms 143:8–10

The psalmist prays for wisdom (see [5:8](#); [25:4–6](#); [138](#); [143:10](#)). • your gracious Spirit: The Spirit brings God's goodness (see [23:6](#)).

Psalms 143:11

To preserve means in this case to restore from despair ([80:19](#); [85:6](#); [138:7](#)).

Psalms 143:12

A prayer for vindication and renewal of life concludes the psalm.

Psalms 144:1–2

The psalmist's descriptive names for the Lord reveal his deep love for him.

Psalms 144:1–15

This lament begins with an exclamation of love for the Lord. The community then reflects on the transitory nature of life ([144:3–4](#)). The psalmist prays for divine intervention and anticipates victory ([144:5–11](#)). A new song ([144:9–10](#)) and a prayer for rescue ([144:11](#)) open up the theme of the Lord's blessing through his provisions and protection ([144:12–15](#)).

Psalms 144:3–4

what are human beings? The same question in [8:4–6](#) elicits the answer that humans are mere mortals but are also glorious rulers. The psalmist depicts humans as having a transitory, empty existence (see [90:3](#), [7–10](#); [102:11](#); [109:23](#); [146:4](#)).

Psalms 144:5–8

The psalmist prays for God's intervention against his enemies (cp. [18:7–19](#)).

Psalms 144:12

The psalmist compares sons and daughters to plants and pillars, which are images of strength and beauty.

Psalms 144:12–15

This prayer for the Lord's blessing brings the laments of [Pss 140–144](#) to a close. It offers a vision of God's provision and protection (see [Ps 127](#)), not only for the psalmist, but for his descendants and those of all the godly.

Psalms 144:13–14

no enemy . . . no cries of alarm: These images depict peace and security.

Psalms 145:1–3

The psalmist praises God, the Great King who reigns over all other rulers (see [47:2](#)).

Psalms 145:1–21

This hymn of praise is the last in this collection of the psalms of David ([Pss 138–145](#)). Praise continues in the last five psalms ([Pss 146–150](#)). This psalm celebrates the Lord as King of all ([145:1–3](#), [10–13](#)). God's actions reveal his royal qualities ([145:4–7](#)). He cares for all creatures ([145:14–17](#)) and for those who fear him ([145:18–20](#)).

Psalms 145:4–7

This litany praises God's character and mighty deeds. Each generation will continue to testify to God's power ([22:30](#)).

Psalms 145:8–9

God consistently demonstrates his character toward all his creation (see [136:25](#)).

Psalms 145:10–13

These verses form a description of the Lord's kingdom.

Psalms 145:14–20

The Lord cares for his creatures.

Psalms 145:20

The Lord cares for those who love him and fear him. God-fearers love the Lord and find refuge in him ([5:11](#)); they seek him as their only true Savior ([40:16](#); [70:4](#)). They will experience a grand future ([69:36](#)), as well as God's peace ([119:165](#)).

Psalms 146:1

This verse is reminiscent of [103:1](#), [2](#), [22](#); [104:1](#), [35](#).

Psalms 146:1–10

The call to praise ([146:1–2](#)) leads into a warning against folly and false confidence ([146:3–4](#)). The psalm concludes with a blessing for all who place their hope in the Lord ([146:5–7](#)).

Psalms 146:1–150.6

The Psalter ends with five hallelujah psalms, so named because each begins and ends with Praise the Lord! (Hebrew haleluyah).

Psalms 146:8–9

The fourfold repetition of the name of the Lord emphasizes that only he heals, unburdens, loves, and protects.

Psalms 147:1

This verse is a call to worship.

Psalms 147:1–20

The psalmist calls for the Lord to be praised for restoring and blessing Zion, caring for the poor, displaying his power over nature, and revealing himself to his people.

Psalms 147:2–6

The psalmist recalls the restoration of Jerusalem and the Lord's afflicted exiles.

Psalms 147:4-5

The Lord created the heavens. • He counts the stars: God's people can feel secure in knowing that the Lord attends to every detail of his creation; he knows all that belongs to him.

Psalms 147:6

God measures out his justice on the poor and on the wicked ([55:22](#); [140:12](#); [145:14](#); [146:7](#)).

Psalms 147:7-11

Human achievements fail to impress the God who commands nature; rather, he takes pleasure in those who fear him.

Psalms 147:8

God holds sovereign power over the weather ([77:17-18](#); [78:26](#); [104:4](#); [148:5-6](#)).

Psalms 147:10-11

human might: Any physical or intellectual achievement is a gift from the Lord, just like the strength of a horse. These gifts are a reason to praise the Lord, not to boast ([Jer 9:23-24](#)).

Psalms 147:13

The bars of the city gates symbolize defenses against enemies. • God blessed his people by empowering them with safety, prosperity, peace, and provisions (see [133:3](#)).

Psalms 147:15-18

Simply by speaking his command, the Lord can change the season from unbearable winter to refreshing spring (see [147:8](#); [148:5-6](#)).

Psalms 147:19-20

words . . . decrees . . . regulations: The Lord gave powerful words to Israel so that they might obey him ([105:45](#)).

Psalms 148:1

During Jesus' triumphant entry into Jerusalem, the crowds called out various blessings, including a phrase taken from this verse ([Matt 21:9](#); [Mark 11:10](#); [Luke 19:38](#)).

Psalms 148:1-14

This psalm calls for the whole created order to praise the Lord because he has honored his faithful people.

Psalms 148:6

The created order is stable because of the Lord's word (see [33:9](#)).

Psalms 148:8

In the ancient Near East, people viewed different gods as having control over separate aspects of nature. The Lord, however, reigns sovereign over all natural phenomena; all the parts of creation are his servants, bringing praise to him through their obedience ([77:17-18](#); [104:4](#); [135:7](#); [147:8](#), [15-18](#); [Num 11:31](#)).

Psalms 148:11-12

The psalmist calls all humans to offer praise to God, regardless of status, age, or gender.

Psalms 148:13-14

Universal praise of the Lord is fitting because he is glorious, and he has blessed his people (see [147:13](#); [Isa 46:13](#); [Eph 3:10](#)). • His faithful ones are his trusting and devoted servants ([Ps 86:2](#)).

Psalms 149:1–9

This hymn of praise celebrates the Lord's victory. He is the Maker of Israel ([149:1–2](#)) and the victorious King who shares his glory with his faithful ones ([149:3–9](#)).

Psalms 149:4

God's people, whom the world ignores and despises, will be vindicated ([Matt 19:30](#)). The humble will experience victory over their oppressors and persecutors (see [Isa 61:3](#)).

Psalms 149:6–9

Vengeance is the Lord's business (see [2:3](#); [94:1](#); [102:20](#); [142:7](#); [146:7](#)).

Psalms 150:1

The phrase mighty heaven alludes to [Gen 1](#) and to God's glorious work in filling the emptiness.

Psalms 150:1–6

Everything that breathes is commanded to praise the Lord as he deserves. The whole Psalter describes the greatness of the Lord, so this psalm is a fitting conclusion.

Psalms 150:3–5

The psalmist calls all people to praise God with instruments and dancing. flutes: These wind instruments are not mentioned as being used in Temple worship. • clanging cymbals: Temple musicians clapped two bronze bowls together as percussion instruments.

Psalms 150:6

Praise the Lord: This refrain is a fitting conclusion to the entire book of Psalms.